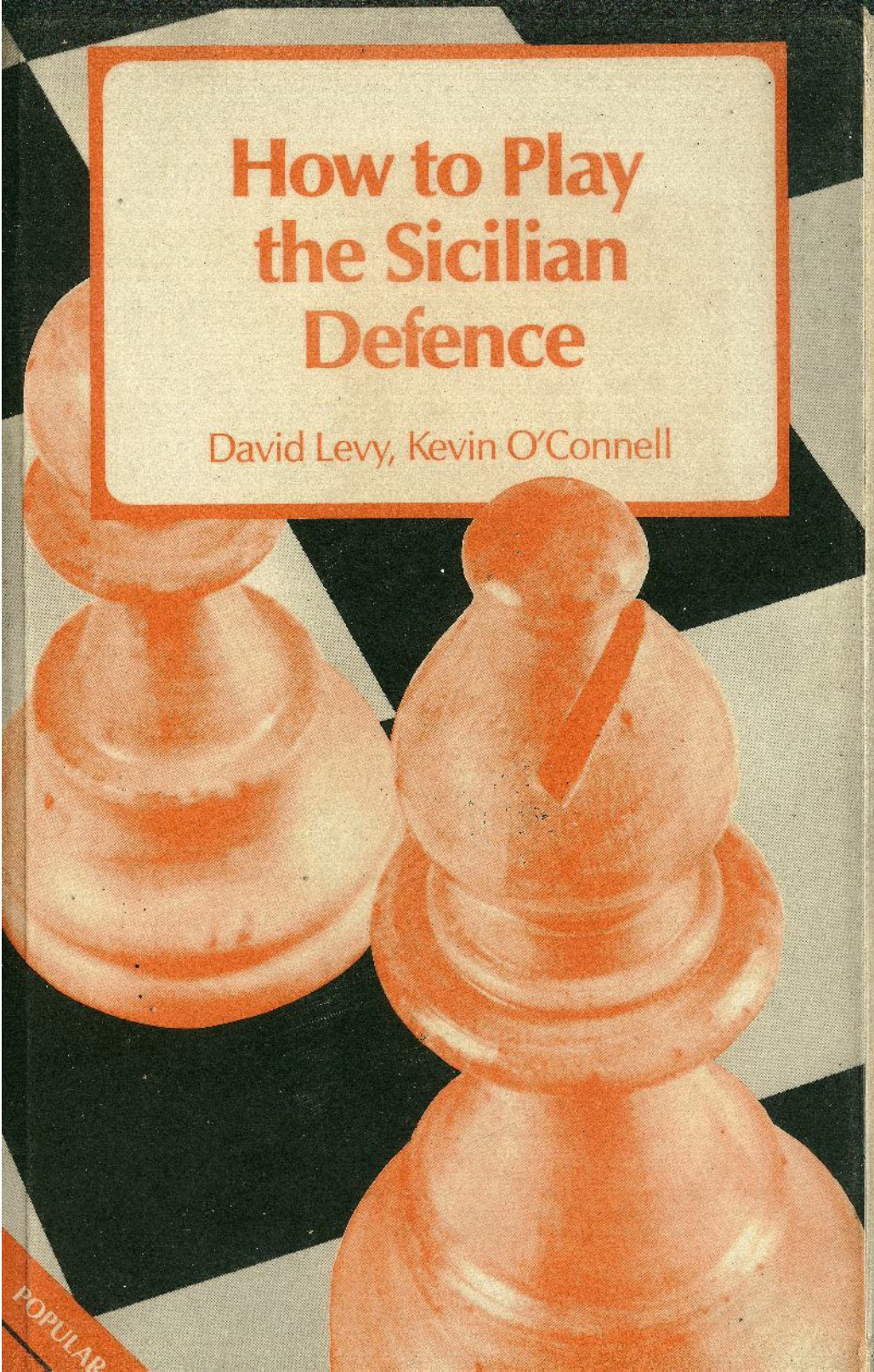
How to Play the Sicilian Defence

David Levy, Kevin O'Connell



POPULAR

How to Play the Sicilian Defence

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KEVIN O'CONNELL

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Preface

Ask any grandmaster what knowledge is essential to play the openings well and he is almost certain to reply "An understanding of the opening and the types of positions which arise". *It is much more important to UNDERSTAND an opening than to know it* (in the sense of rote-learning of moves). However, there is no alchemist's stone in chess, least of all in the openings; as Larsen has pointed out: "if you know only the 'ideas behind the openings', and he (your opponent) knows the ideas *and* a lot of variations, he is likely to beat you." But how many chess players do know both? Not very many; the grandmasters, yes, the international masters, probably, the rest . . .?

This book, and the others in the series, explain the ideas behind the openings and link them to key positions and thus to specific variations. *Batsford Chess Openings* and the *Encyclopaedia of Chess Openings* series provide *all* the variations known to man and are written by experts in each field.

Until now there has been only Reuben Fine's one volume *Ideas Behind the Chess Openings* to fill a complete gap in chess literature. Prior to the mid-1960s this may have been sufficient. Before then there were few openings monographs and one volume works were apparently quite sufficient for all except the world's leading players. Now even average club players seem to know as much, or even more, opening theory as the grandmasters of the inter-war and immediate post-war periods. What they lack is an *understanding* of these strings of moves. It is hoped that the current series will fill this void.

Symbols

+	Check
± ⩱	Slight advantage
± ∓	Clear advantage
±± ∓∓	Winning advantage
=	Level position
∞	Unclear position
!	Good move
!!	Outstanding move
!?	Interesting move
?!	Dubious move
?	Weak move
??	Blunder
corres	Correspondence
Ol	Olympiad
IZ	Interzonal
L	League
Ch	Championship
½f	Semi-final

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1 An Introduction to the Sicilian Defence

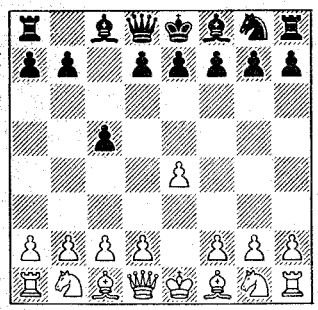
The Sicilian Defence, 1 e4 c5, is the most popular defence to the king's pawn opening. It dates back to the works of Giulio Cesare Polerio in about 1590 and was apparently given its name by the 17th century Italian master Gioachino Greco. The defence was comparatively rarely played and was generally given little attention unitl it was adopted in the famous match between La Bourdonnais and McDonnell in 1834. From then on its popularity steadily increased, helped in particular by Staunton who used it successfully against Saint-Amant in their famous match of 1843. Both Staunton and Jaenisch considered that it was the strongest reply to 1 e4, which in fact was reflected in their numerous writings.

Within the Sicilian Defence there are a large number of different variations which have been developed between the mid-19th century and the present day. Each of these variations has it own pawn structure and for each pawn structure the strategies of each side vary to some extent. There are now so many different Sicilian variations that over 25% of master chess games are Sicilians, which reflects the fact that the Sicilian Defence is Black's most successful method of combatting 1 e4. Thus in the seven most important tournaments of 1976 (Amsterdam, Euwe; Amsterdam, IBM; Biel Interzonal; Manila Interzonal; Manila, Marlboro/Loyola; USSR Championship and Wijk aan Zee) the Sicilian was played in 173 out of 743 games (23%) with the overall result that White won 47, 78 were drawn and Black won 48.

The reader might have formed a false impression of the Sicilian from the number of quick white victories that are published every year in the chess literature. It is true that when White wins against the Sicilian he often does so quickly but Black does have his own fair share of wins though these tend to be in somewhat longer games and hence they are

less likely to be published.

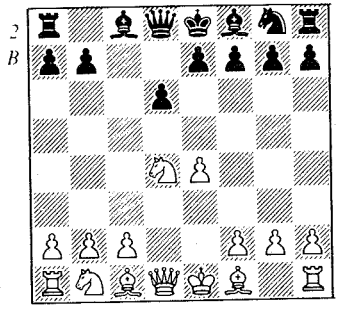
The Sicilian Defence offers enormous scope to players of every style, since there are many quiet, positional lines in addition to the more notorious wild, attacking variations. It has a claim to be the most exciting and dynamic of all the chess openings. With his very first move Black creates an unbalanced position and announces his intention of defending by means of counter-attack. White's normal strategy is to keep a firm grip on the centre and create attacking chances on the kingside. Black will attempt to challenge White's centre control and to launch an offensive on the queenside, in particular along the c-file.



Let us first look at the starting position of the Sicilian Defence, after the moves 1 e4 c5. White has one pawn in the centre of the board (e4, d4, e5, d5) whereas Black has none, but each player attacks one of the central squares in his opponent's half of the board – White's e-pawn attacks the d5 square and Black's c-pawn attacks the d4 square. These two squares are amongst the most important in the Sicilian Defence. White usually tries to occupy d4 with a minor piece and to keep d5 under careful observation and, if necessary, restraint. The d5 square is even more important – if he can build up support for the square and then play ... d5, Black will normally be assured of at least equality.

The struggle for the control of the d4 and d5 squares represents the underlying strategic theme of the defence. For Black the thrust ... d5 is, at first, only a dream – he must prepare for it patiently and he must calculate its consequences carefully before playing it should he get the chance to do so. White is more fortunate in that he can afford to play d4 almost at once (even 2 d4 has its possibilities). White's normal second move is ♘f3 and this is usually followed by d4 (it may seem strange to offer to exchange a centre pawn – usually regarded as more valuable – for a flank pawn, but in exchange for this small concession, White obtains a space advantage), whereupon Black exchanges pawns. This is one of the reasons why the Sicilian Defence is considered so dynamic – as early as move three

the battle lines are drawn; White has a space advantage, Black a preponderance of pawns in the central files. A typical opening sequence is **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4**.

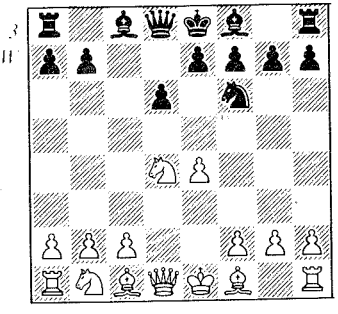


White has succeeded in his first aim – he has a knight well placed on d4, a space advantage and a slight lead in development. In compensation Black has a central pawn majority and he has half-opened the e-file which will later be the source of much of his counterplay.

Before proceeding any further there are two points that should be made about this short opening sequence. First, White is by no means *compelled* to play 2 ♘f3 and 3 d4, but experience (apart from mere fashion) has shown that most other plans do not contribute as much to White's centre control and consequently Black has fewer difficulties in neutralising White's initiative. Likewise, Black's second move, 2 ... d6, is just one of many possibilities: 2 ... ♘c6, 2 ... e6, 2 ... ♘f6, 2 ... a6 and 2 ... g6 are all playable, but we have chosen 2 ... d6 here because it best illustrates an important idea.

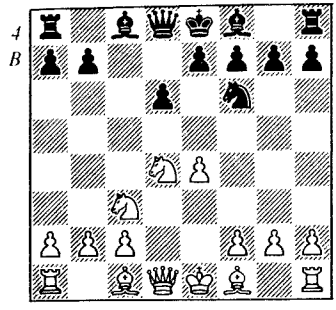
In the position shown in diagram 2, if it were White's turn to move he could play c4, gaining a firm grip on the d5 square and thereby making it increasingly difficult for Black to achieve the freeing thrust ... d5 (this motif is examined in detail in chapters 2 and 3).

In order to prevent c4 by White, Black now attacks the white e-pawn so as to encourage White's queen's knight to move to c3 at once: **4 ... ♘f6** (now we see the reason for 2 ... d6 – White cannot play e5).



White can only maintain his lead in development by defending his e-pawn with a minor piece and since, as a general rule, knights

should be developed before bishops, White's logical continuation is **5 ♘c3.**



It is now, after 5 ♘c3, that Black can decide which variation to play. His next move might be 5 ... a6, 5 ... ♘c6, 5 ... e6 or 5 ... g6. Whichever variation Black adopts, the stage has already been set for the struggle that follows – White dominates d5 and Black is beginning to undermine this domination by putting pressure on White's e-pawn. The result of this struggle for control of the centre will ultimately decide whose overall strategy will be the more successful – White's on the kingside or Black's on the queenside.

Let us now take a look at the fundamental ideas that occur most often in almost all variations of the Sicilian Defence.

White Kingside Attack

Look once again at the position shown in diagram 3. There are various factors visible which explain why White's most sensible strategy is to play for a kingside attack:

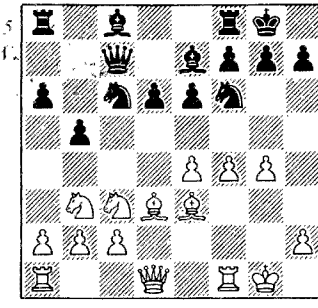
1) The half-open e-file makes it unlikely that Black will be able to castle queenside since his king would not be so well shielded;

2) White's queenside pawns are intact so it *is* possible for White to castle queenside as a preparation for a kingside pawn advance;

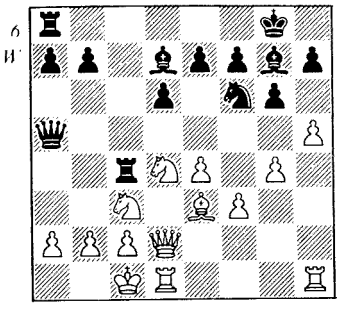
3) White's king's bishop can be aggressively posted at c4 or d3, bearing down on the black kingside;

4) The presence of Black's knight on f6 gives White a preliminary target for his queen's bishop (on g5) or for an advance of his g-pawn.

Here are some examples of typical white attacking formations:

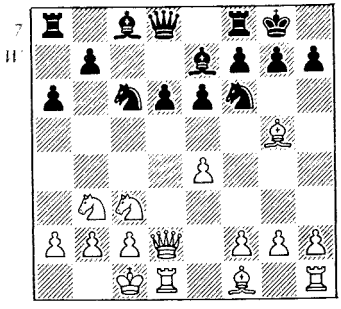


White continues with g5, driving the black knight from the defence of its h7 square, followed by ♕h5 and ♖f3-h3, a crude but often effective way of playing for mate.

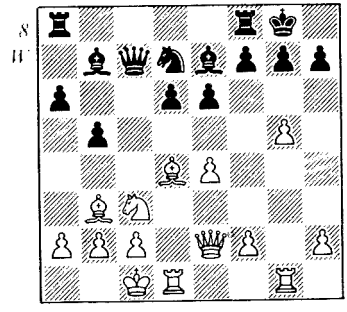


White has castled queenside so that his king will not be exposed by the rapid advance of his kingside pawns. In order to force his attack home, White must first accomplish three tasks:
1) He must half open the h-file with a timely exchange on g6.
2) He must trade off the dark-squared bishops (by ♗h6 at the appropriate moment) in order to weaken Black's kingside still further – the dark-squared bishop is the only suitable piece in Black's possession to cover his h6 square;
3) He must, finally, drive Black's knight from f6 so the h7 pawn (or square) will be insufficiently protected.

In contrast to the previous example Black has considerable counterplay in this position (6), in particular the exchange sacrifice ... ♖xc3 opening the way for an attack against White's king, may well disrupt White's plans at a crucial moment.



Here Black's king's bishop is fulfilling a dual role, guarding both the d-pawn and the f6 knight. White can try to take advantage of this overworked bishop by **1 ♗xf6 gf** (if 1 ... ♗xf6, Black loses his d-pawn for nothing) **2 ♕h6** followed by ♖d3 and ♖h3.



White's king's bishop has been developed on the a2-g8 diagonal via the move ♗c4. It helps to inhibit the advance ... d5 and puts pressure on Black's kingside by tying the black f-pawn to the defence of the e-pawn. White can now continue his attack with

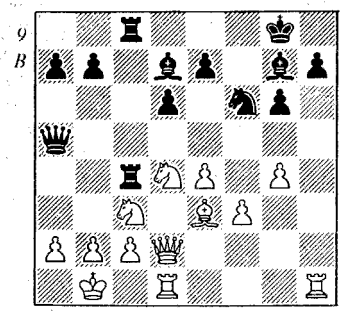
1 ♕h5 threatening, amongst other things, ♖g3 followed by ♖h3. If Black meets ♕h5 with **1 ... ♖fc8** creating an escape square for the king, White wins by **2 g6 hg 3 ♖xg6! fg 4 ♗xe6+ ♔f8 5 ♕h8 mate.**

Attacking formations such as these are seen very often in Sicilian games and there are two distinct methods of combatting White's kingside strategy:

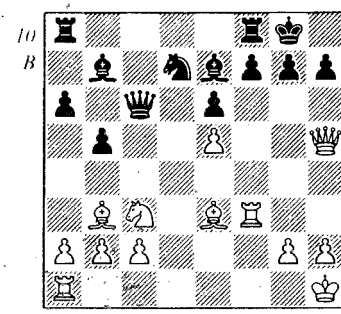
1) Black may launch an early offensive on the queenside so that White's attack is met blow for blow by Black's counter-attack;

2) He may try to put so much pressure on White's centre that White is tied to its defence and never finds time to develop the full potential of his attack.

Black's Queenside Counterattack



This position arose from a variation of diagram 6 in which White's attack was not pursued with the utmost vigour (White had wasted a tempo with ♔b1). Black continued **17 ... ♗xg4!!** (undermining e4) **18 fg ♖xc3** and now 19 bc loses at once to 19 .. ♘xe4 and 20 ... ♘xc3+. So White tried **19 ♘e6** but after **19 ... ♕e5 20 ♘xg7 ♘xe4 21 ♕d4 ♖xe3 22 ♕xe5 de 23 ♘e6 ♘f2** Black's extra pawns were decisive. The moral of this story is that when players are attacking each other on opposite wings, every move must be direct and to the point – a single wasted move ("tempo") can lead to immediate disaster.



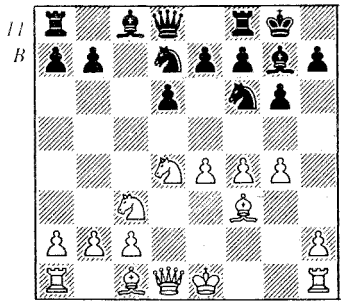
This position stems from one of the sharpest variations of the Sicilian to have come on the market in recent years. If White is given time for ♖g1, defending the g-pawn and thereby freeing the f3 rook, Black will find it difficult to defend against the threat of ♖g3 followed by ♕h6. But while White has been shifting his heavy artillery over to the kingside,

Black has not been idle; his a- and b-pawns are ready to advance and bring confusion to White's ranks. A sample continuation is **16 ... b4 17 ♗a4** (if the knight moves 17 ... ♕e4 is strong) **17 ... ♕c7 18 ♖h3 h6 19 ♗xd7** (19 ♗xh6 ♕xe5 20 ♗g5 ♗xg2+ also favours Black) **19 ... bc 20 ♗xh6 g6** and now 21 ♖g3 ♔h7 22 ♕h3 ♖h8 leaves White over-extended. This resource of ... h6, which encourages ♗xh6 so as to block the h-file for a tempo and make ... g6 possible, is a useful defensive device in many Sicilian positions.

Note that the key to Black's defence lay in the advance ... b4 and it is partly for this reason that the move ... b5 forms an integral part of Black's counter-attack in many variations (especially when the e4 square is vulnerable). Often White meets ... b5 with a3 in order to prevent the further advance of Black's b-pawn, but a3 costs White a move and weakens his queenside.

Black Pressurises White's Centre

The second way in which Black can combat White's kingside plans is to put pressure on White's centre. The Golden Rule "Meet a premature wing attack with a counterstroke in the centre" holds good in the Sicilian, especially so if White has not yet castled.

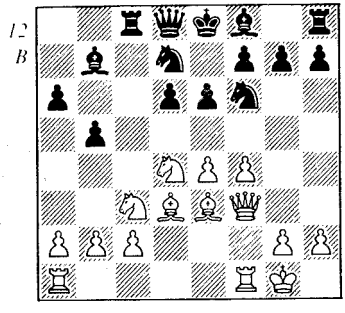


11 B

White's last move, 9 g4?, violates all logical principles. Black has a lead in development and his kingside is secure. White's king is still in the centre and two pieces (his queen's bishop and his queen) must move before he can castle queenside. Why then should White think that he can afford to weaken himself with this rash advance? **9 ... e5 10 ♘db5 d5!** smashing open the centre **11 ed e4 12 ♗e2 ♘b6 13 g5 ♘fxd5 14 ♘xe4 ♕e7 15 ♘f2 ♖e8** and White's king will never find a safe haven.

This example was rather drastic, but even when White has not flouted the basic principles of the game it is possible for Black to build up pressure on the centre. An excellent target for attack is provided by White's e-pawn. On e4 this pawn is subject to attack from Black's f6 knight, from the queen's bishop on the long diagonal, and sometimes from the queen's

knight which can make its way to c5 via d7. The e-pawn is usually protected by White's queen's knight on c3, but once Black has played ... b5, there is always the possibility ... b4, driving away the queen's knight, and the ubiquitous exchange sacrifice (... ♖xc3) often finds sufficient compensation in White's e-pawn and the actively placed minor piece that captures it.



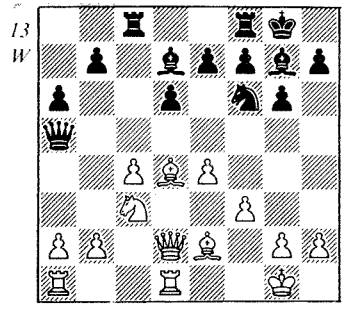
This position illustrates the various ways in which Black can put pressure on White's e-pawn. This pressure can be increased by ... b4 and/or ... ♘c5. While White remains tied to the defence of his e-pawn he finds himself unable to undertake any serious action on the kingside.

The Struggle for d5

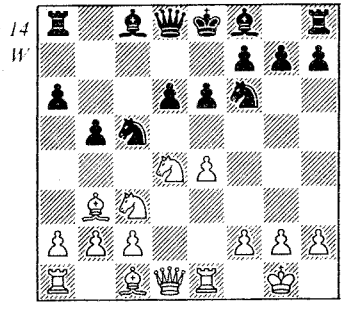
We have already mentioned the importance of the d5 square in the Sicilian Defence and it is a factor that can hardly be given too much emphasis. Very many games have been won by players of White as a direct result of their being able to put a piece on d5 at a crucial moment (see, for example, position 13). When Black has been able to play ... d5 with impunity, the results have very much favoured the second player. Having said all this, it will now be even more apparent why Black's plan of keeping up pressure on White's e-pawn is so important – this e-pawn is needed to hold back the advance ... d5 and it is often used to support whatever piece jumps on to d5.

As it happens, the pressure on White's e-pawn and Black's striving for ... d5 are closely linked. Black's attack on the e-pawn usually comes from his knight on f6, his bishop on b7 and/or the possibility of the exchange sacrifice ... ♖xc3. These three pieces – Black's knight on f6 and bishop on b7 and White's knight on c3 – all exert influence both on the d5 square and on the white pawn on e4 (which of course itself also has a part in the fight for control of d5), and it is the dual role of the minor pieces that links the twin struggles for e4 and d5.

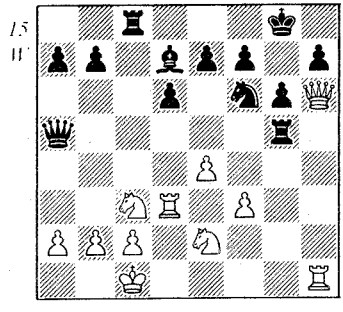
Let us now look at some typical winning ideas that are based on White's occupation of the d5 square.



Black must lose a pawn because his queen is unprotected: **13 ♘d5! ♕d8** If 13 ... ♕xd2 14 ♘xe7+ ♔h8 and only then will White recapture with ♖xd2. **14 ♘xf6+ ef** Or 14 ... ♗xf6 15 ♗xf6 ef 16 ♕xd6. **15 ♗c3** and Black will not be able to save his d-pawn. This motif of the *zwischenzug* (an in-between move) ♘xe7+ or ♘xf6+ is quite common in Sicilian positions when White's queen is on d2 and Black's queen, often undefended, is on a5.



White has an enormous lead in development and Black's king is stuck in the centre, so White forces open the e-file and begins an immediate attack on the enemy king: **10 ♗d5!** An offer that Black cannot refuse. If the rook moves then 11 ♘c6 is crushing, while 10 ... ♗b7 11 b4 ♗xd5 12 ed and 10 ... ♘b7 11 ♗c6+ ♘d7 12 ♘f5! ef 13 ef+ ♗e7 14 ♘d5 are equally unpleasant for Black. **10 ... ed 11 ed+ ♔d7 12 b4 ♘a4** If 12 ... ♘b7 13 ♘c6 ♕c7 14 ♕f3 White threatens the devasatating check 15 ♕h3. **13 ♘xa4 ba 14 c4 ♗b7 15 ♕xa4+ ♔c7 16 ♗g5!** White has two pawns and an overwhelming attack to compensate for the sacrificed piece. The further advance of White's queenside pawns will prove decisive.

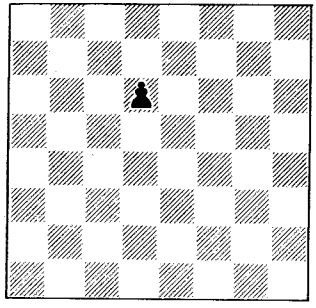


21 ♖d5! Taking advantage of the fact that Black's knight is tied to the defence of the h-pawn. **21 ... ♖xd5 22 ♘xd5 ♖e8 23 ♘ef4!** Intending 24 ♘xf6+ ef 25 ♘d5 (again!) followed by 26 ♕xh7+ and 27 ♕h8 mate. **23 ... ♗c6** Now the d5 square is too hot for

comfort but it has already served its purpose. **24 e5!** ♗xd5 Or 24 ... de 25 ♘xf6+ ef 26 ♘h5 gh 27 ♖g1+ mates. **25 ef ef 26** ♕**xh7+** ♔**f8 27** ♕**h8+** Black resigns. If 27 ... ♔e7 28 ♘xd5+ ♕xd5 29 ♖e1+ picking up the rook.

Perhaps the easiest way to explain why d5 is such an important square for White is to consider, once again, the fundamental roles most frequently acted by both players in the Sicilian Defence.

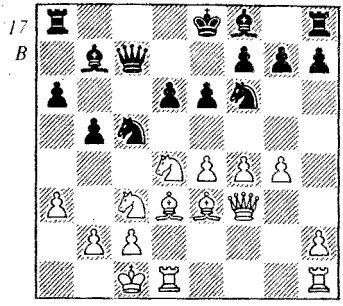
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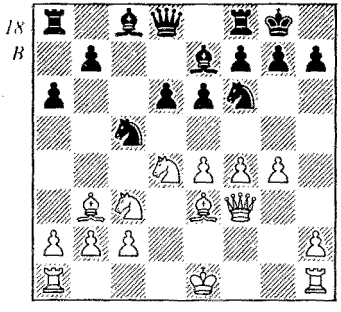
Under normal circumstances White will attack on the kingside and Black on the queenside. If Black's pawn is fixed on d6 and White has occupied d5 with one of his own pieces, these two squares (d5 and d6) form a kind of barrier. This barrier makes it difficult for Black's forces to switch from one side of the board to the other – his third and fourth ranks are blocked and so he has only two ranks on which to manoeuvre his pieces; to the kingside if they are needed for defence, to the queenside if they are required for a counter-attack. In contrast, White has the full use of his first four ranks, and so it will be far easier for White to attack than it will be for Black to defend. Similarly, White will also find it much easier to switch his pieces from one area to another should he need to defend or should he find another object to attack. This barrier (d5 and d6) often has such a pronounced effect on the communication between Black's pieces that White can sometimes afford to sacrifice a piece, as in example 14, in order to achieve it (for a fuller discussion of these sacrificial possibilities see pp. 55-56 and 121-123).

Since the d6 pawn so often restricts the freedom of movement of Black's forces; and since White's e-pawn is such an obvious target for attack, the thrust ... d5 is always in the thoughts of the experienced Sicilian player. Once ... d5 has been played Black's pieces usually increase their scope and it is sometimes even possible for Black to bargain his d-pawn in return for this increased mobility.

The next diagram is an example of a typical Sicilian position where the players are attacking on opposite sides of the board. **12 ... d5 13 e5** White cannot afford to open up the long diagonal by


17
B

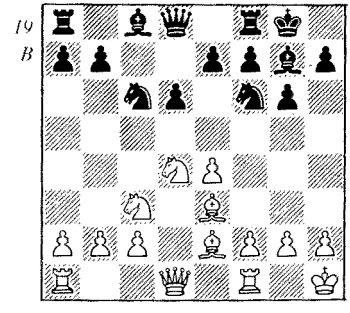
exchanging on d5 because he would immediately lose material. **13 ... ♘fe4!** A normal move in such positions. Black does not mind the doubled e-pawns because the pawn on e4 controls some useful squares and the d5 square is vacated for occupation by a piece. **14 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 15 ♘xe4 de 16 ♕f2 ♗d5** Black has achieved at least equality even though he has not yet castled. White's queenside is vulnerable, he cannot advance his f-pawn at the moment and Black has the advantage of the two bishops.


18
B

Here is another example of an early kingside attack by White. Black has not yet expanded on the queenside but he has a soundly developed position and so decides to begin the tactics while White's king is still exposed.

11 ... d5 12 ed 12 e5 ♘fe4 13 ♘xe4 de would be even better for Black than the previous example because here he has already castled and so he can make full use of his initiative, e.g. 14 ♕h3 ♕a5+ (encouraging the e3 bishop to move to an inferior square) 15 ♗d2 ♕c7 16 g5 ♖d8 and Black has a very active game. **12 ... ed 13 g5 ♘xb3 14 ab ♘e4 15 ♘xe4 de 16 ♕g2** The point. If 16 ♕xe4?? ♗b4+ followed by 17 ... ♖e8 with tremendous pressure. **16 ... ♗b4+** 17 c3 **♗c5** Black has the better chances because White's king will always be a little exposed.

These two examples serve to show what can happen when White is overactive on the kingside before he can take a firm grip of


19
B

the centre. The next example shows how effective ... d5 can be against passive opening play.

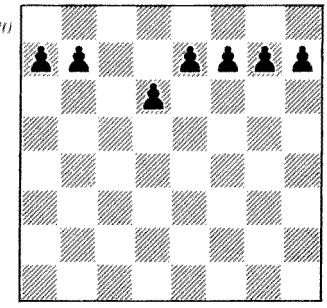
White has just played the passive move 9 ♔h1 (he should have played 9 ♘b3, preventing ... d5, and then continued actively with f4). **9 ... d5! 10 ed** 10 ♘xc6 bc 11 e5 ♘d7 12 f4 e6 is perfectly satisfactory for Black who will continue with ... f6 to undermine White's pawn centre. As a general rule White should always avoid exchanging knights on c6 unless (a) Black cannot recapture with the b-pawn or (b) there is a good reason for allowing Black to strengthen his centre. **10 ... ♘xd5 11 ♘xd5 ♘xd4 12 ♗xd4 ♕xd5** The position is completely level.

Weak Squares

There are a number of different pawn structures that Black can adopt in the Sicilian Defence and associated with some of these pawn structures there are weak squares. The reader may wonder why any level-headed player of the black pieces would voluntarily submit himself to a position containing one or more weak squares. The answer lies in the fighting nature of the Sicilian – while White is trying to take advantage of the weak squares, Black is creating dynamic counterplay elsewhere on the board.

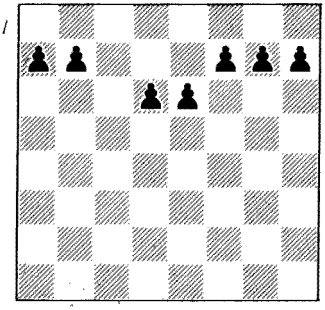
Let us look at some typical Sicilian pawn structures and pinpoint Black's weaknesses.

20



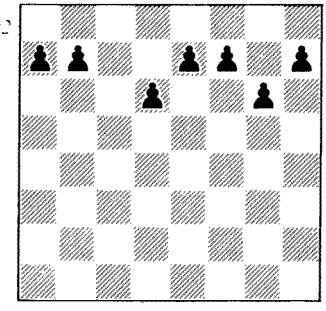
No weaknesses.

21



No weaknesses, provided that the d-pawn is well protected – it is an obvious target.

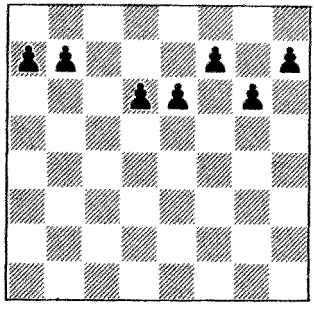
22



The typical "Dragon" formation.

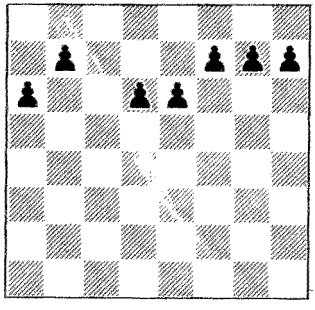
There are no real weaknesses but h6 is vulnerable and it is this square that White most often uses to exchange the dark-squared bishops after which h6 can become a real weakness.

23



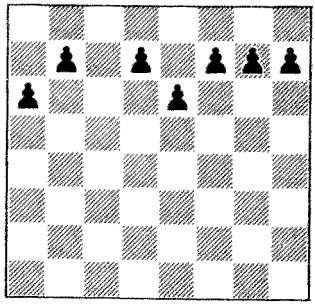
A mixture of two systems has been employed here. The d6, f6 and h6 squares are all vulnerable. Black's dark-squared bishop can only defend two of the squares simultaneously and should it be exchanged then Black's position will be very difficult with three weak squares to defend.

24



There are no real weaknesses in the structure unless White can advance his a-pawn to a5 and fix Black's b-pawn on b7 (then b6 might be invaded by a minor piece).

25

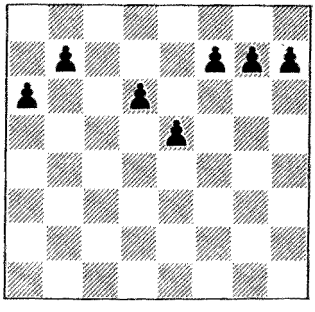


The b6 and d6 squares are potentially weak. White has two possible methods of taking advantage of this structure:

1) To establish pieces on b6 and/or d6 (which usually necessitates the advance of the a- or e-pawn to the fifth rank);

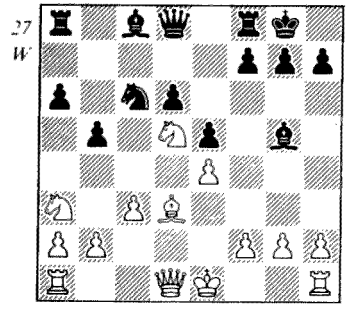
2) To adopt measures which will not allow Black to advance his b- or d-pawn (then Black will have severe problems trying to develop his pieces and will have to play without his queen's rook and queen's bishop).

26



This position illustrates probably the most common square weakness in the Sicilian. Black has advanced his e-pawn to e5, driving White's d4 knight away but leaving the d5 square wide open for occupation by White. The following variation, which has recently become extremely popular in master chess, illustrates some of the advantages and disadvantages of Black's pawn structure:

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 Hitting the weakness on d6. **6 ... d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3** So as to redeploy the a3 knight in the centre by ♘c2, thus gaining even firmer control over d5 **11 ... 0-0 12 ♗d3 ♗g5**



Now Black's plan can be seen quite clearly. While White is trying to consolidate his centre, Black will be playing for ... f5" (possibly prefaced by ... g6) and it will be Black who is attacking on the kingside.

Having said that Black's thematic break in this type of position is ... f5, let us look at a slightly different variation: **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♗xf6** Saddling Black with doubled pawns. **8 ... gf 9 ♘a3 f5** Obviously the doubled pawns have their compensation because now Black may be able to play his thematic break twice! **10 ♕h5 d5!** Black's dynamic play negates the effect of his weaknesses. **11 ed ♗xa3 12 ba ♕a5 13 ♔d2 ♘e7** and Black has a fine game – White's king is exposed and Black has excellent prospects by, for example, ... ♗d7 followed by ... ♖c8.

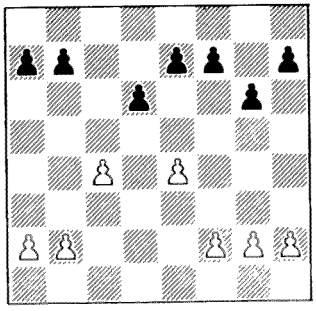
We have now introduced the basic thematic ideas in the Sicilian Defence. In the subsequent chapters the reader will find a more detailed discussion of these themes, and how they should be applied, in the context of specific pawn structures and a set of "Golden Rules" which, if followed, will help him to find the correct plans and the best moves when he is playing the Sicilian with either colour.

At the end of the book there is a special chapter which deals with some sacrificial ideas that recur in many Sicilian positions and the Sicilian player should always be on the alert for such possibilities as they usually have a decisive effect on the outcome of the game.

2 The Maroczy Bind with ... g6

The cramping effect of White's e-pawn and c-pawn (in positions such as that shown in diagram 28) is known as the "Maroczy Bind" and it forms the central theme of some important variations of the Sicilian. This pawn duet hinders Black's normal freeing manoeuvres ... d5 and ... b5.

28



The Maroczy Bind is most often seen in action against variations in which Black has fianchettoed his king's bishop and that is the subject of this chapter. (For Maroczy Bind positions in which Black plays ... e6 and ... ♗e7 see Chapter 3).

Some examples of variations that lead to normal Maroczy Bind positions, which can also arise from the English Opening, are:

1) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 ed 4 ♘xd4 g6 5 c4.**

2) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♕xd4 a6** (or 4 ... ♗d7) **5 c4.**

3) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 ♗b5+ ♗d7 4 ♗xd7+ ♕xd7 5 c4,** followed by d4.

In each case White has exchanged his opening initiative (the extra move) for a slight advantage in space and the restricting effect of the Maroczy Bind.

White's Basic Strategy

To maintain the bind, which means:

1) Being aware of the possibilities at Black's disposal to destroy White's grip, so he

2) Must constantly watch for pawn breaks.

3) To strengthen his position.

4) Ultimately:

a) to strangle Black; or

b) to launch an attack on the kingside; or

c) to go for the endgame which is normally very favourable for White.

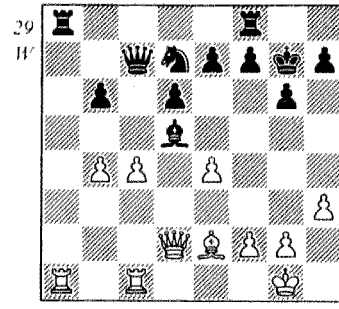
Black's Basic Strategy

Try to break the bind, which means:
1) Being aware of the ways in which he can destroy White's grip, so he
2) Must constantly see if he can employ a pawn break.
3) To strengthen his position.
4) Ultimately:
a) to obtain active counterplay, even if necessary, at the cost of a pawn; or
b) to try to hold the ending – often this can be done, but it is an exacting task.

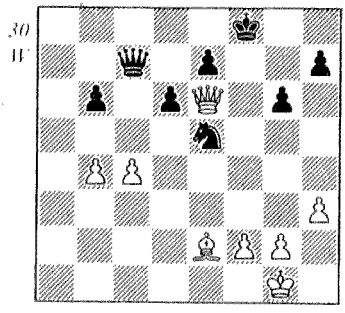
The Maroczy Bind dates back to 1904 and the game Swiderski-Maroczy at Monte Carlo (Maroczy began to recommend the white side of the position the following year). In this, the first known game to feature the bind, some of the basic strategies are in evidence.

Swiderski-Maroczy
Monte Carlo 1904

1 e4 c5 2 c4 ♘c6 3 ♘f3 g6 4 d4 cd 5 ♘xd4 ♗g7 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 ♘c3 d6 8 ♗e2 ♗d7 9 0-0 0-0 10 h3?! 10 ♖c1 or 10 ♕d2 would be the modern choice and more in keeping with the position. **10 ... ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♗c6 12 ♕d2 ♘d7 13 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 14 b4 b6 15 ♖fc1 a5 16 a3 ab 17 ab ♕c7 18 ♘d5 ♗xd5** *(29)*



19 ♕xd5? 19 cd is correct. When ♘d5 is good for White, and it usually is, it is most often so because the recapture with the c-pawn opens the c-file and further solidifies the bind. Swiderski would also have had the advantage of a supported entry square at c6. **19 ... ♖xa1 20 ♖xa1 f5** Although White had misplayed the position, this is Black's only possibility for counterplay and, if he had not taken it, he might still have been lost. **21 ♕e6 ♘e5 22 ef ♖xf5 23 ♖a8 ♖f8 24 ♖xf8 ♔xf8** *(30)*



25 c5? An important possibility in

this type of position, but here it is simply unsound. **25 ... dc 26 f4 ♘f7 27 ♗c4 ♕xf4 28 bc bc 29 ♕c8+ ♔g7 30 ♕xc5 ♕e5 31 ♕c8 ♘d6 32 ♕g8+ ♔h6 33 ♕f8+ ♔g5 34 ♗f1** 34 h4+ gives rise to some pretty variations which lead to mate, but they are not forced. **34 ... ♕e3+** 35 **♕f2** Forced. 35 ♔h1 loses to 35 ... ♘f5. **35 ... ♕xf2+ 36 ♔xf2 ♔f4 37 ♗d3 ♘e4+ 38 ♔e2 g5 39 ♗c2 h5 40 ♗b3 e5 41 ♗f7 h4 42 ♗c4 ♘f6 43 ♔f2 ♔e4 44 ♗f7 ♔d3 45 ♗g6+ e4 46 ♗f5 ♔d2 47 ♗xe4 ♘xe4+ 48 ♔f3 ♔d3** White resigned.

Let us now take a closer look at how each side should handle a typical Maroczy Bind position. The material is divided as follows:

Ideas for Black

Black plays ... f5.
Black plays ... e6 followed by ... d5.
Black plays ... b5.

Ideas for White

White plays c5.
White plays ♘d5.
White uses ♘d5 to force an endgame.
White gets a kingside attack.

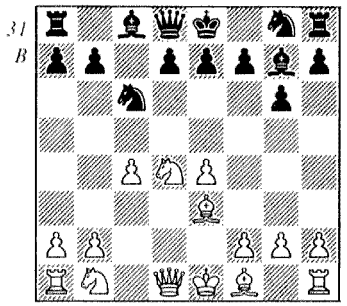
Other Themes

Black attacks on the queenside.
Black gives up his fianchettoed king's bishop.

We will first examine Black's possible freeing manoeuvres and this should lead us to a greater understanding of how White should maintain and increase the effect of the bind.

Ideas for Black

Why should Balck always try to destroy the bind with a pawn break? If he does not then he will encounter great difficulties in trying to find good squares for his pieces, especially the rooks. Consequently, Black aims to use a pawn break to destroy the bind and open lines for his pieces.



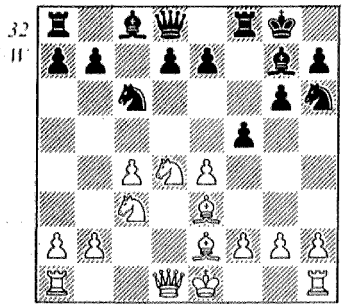
This position arises after White's sixth move in the accelerated form of the Dragon Variation. In this variation, Black delays the move ... d6 in the hope that he will later be able to play ... d5 at one stroke, thereby saving a tempo.

What targets are there in the white position for Black to aim at? It is true that White's e-pawn and c-pawn restrict Black's activity

but each of these pawns is liable to come under attack. Black can attack the e-pawn by preparing ... d5 (which also attacks the e-pawn) or ... f5, or he can try to destroy White's queenside by preparing ... b5. These attacks on White's pawns represent by far the most popular methods of play against the Maroczy Bind.

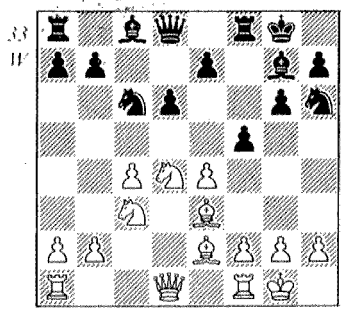
Black plays ... f5

Before looking at the examples below, it should be mentioned that ... f5, while putting pressure on the white centre, does weaken the black king position and Black must be on the look out for kingside attacks, one of which brought White victory in the Tal-Kupreichik example (p. 19).



Furman-Spassky
USSR Ch 1957

Spassky has just played 8 ... f5, which threatens 9 ... f4 and puts pressure on White's centre. **9 ef ♗xd4** So that Black will be able to recapture on f5 in comparative safety. **10 ♗xd4** Stronger is 10 ♗xh6 destroying the piece that Black would most like to place on f5. **10 ... ♘xf5 11 ♗c5 d6 12 ♗a3 ♘fd4 13 0-0 ♗f5** Black already has an active position. **14 ♖c1 ♕d7 15 ♘d5 ♖f7 16 b3 ♖af8 17 ♗b2 e5 18 b4 ♗e6 19 ♗d3?** Relatively best was 19 b5 although after 19 ... ♗xd5 20 cd ♘xe2+ 21 ♕xe2 ♘e7 Black would still have the initiative. **19 ... ♗g4! 20 f3** If 20 ♕d2 ♘f3+! 21 gf ♗xf3 (threatening mate in two!) 22 ♕g5 ♘xb4 23 ♘xb4 ♖f4, with a winning attack. **20 ... ♗xf3!** A useful point to remember is that such sacrifices on this square recur frequently in the Maroczy Bind. **21 gf ♘xf3+ 22 ♔h1 ♕h3 23 ♖f2** If 23 ♕e2 ♘fd4 24 ♗xd4 ♘xd4 25 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 26 ♕d2 e4! with a winning attack. **23 ... ♘e1** White resigned.



Tal-Kupreichik
Sochi 1970

Here Black exchanges an extra

pair of minor pieces before recapturing on f5: **10 ef ♘xd4** 10 ... ♗xd4 is met by 11 ♗xh6! so that Black will not be able to recapture on f5 with the knight, but now 11 ♗xh6?? fails to 11 ... ♘xe2+ winning a piece. **11 ♗xd4 ♗xd4 12 ♕xd4 ♘xf5 13 ♕d2** So Black has achieved his aim – he has established his knight on f5 – but his position contains two serious defects. First, he has three pawn islands to White's two, so that White has the better endgame prospects. Also, Black's king is exposed along the diagonals and an awkward check may be possible in many variations. **13 ... ♗d7 14 ♗f3 ♗c6 15 ♗d5+ ♔g7 16 ♖fe1** Threatening 17 ♖e6. **16 ... e5 17 c5!** Blasting open the position for an assault on Black's king. **17 ... dc 18 ♖xe5 ♕d6 19 ♖ae1 ♖fe8 20 ♖e6 ♖xe6 21 ♖xe6 ♕d7 22 ♕f4! ♗xd5** If 22 ... ♖e8 23 ♕e5+ ♔h6 24 ♕xf5 winning, or 22 ... ♖f8 23 ♕e5+ ♔h6 24 g4 ♘d4 25 ♕e3+ winning. **23 ♕e5+ ♔f7 24 ♖f6+ ♔g8 25 ♘xd5 ♕a4** If 25 ... ♖e8 26 ♖xg6+! **26 h3 ♖d8** Or 26 ... ♖e8 27 ♖e6 ♖xe6 28 ♕xe6+ ♔g7 29 g4! **27 ♖xf5!** Black resigned. 27 ... hg 28 ♕e6+ wins the rook – 29 ♕e7+ or 29 ♕f6+.

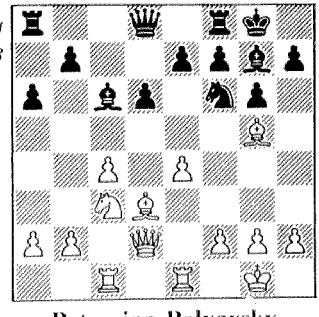
Conclusion

After ... f5 White's position generally improves with each exchange of minor pieces, particularly if it is possible to exchange on h6 under favourable circumstances. If Black can avoid too many piece exchanges he has good chances of creating counterplay.

Black Plays ... e6 followed by ... d5

Another way for Black to try to weaken White's pawn bastions is the attempt to force the thematic Sicilian pawn break ... d5. It is true that ... d5 is the very move against which White's bind is aimed, but if Black is allowed to prepare with ... e6 and then implement ... f5 it may be possible for him to liquidate the centre to his advantage.

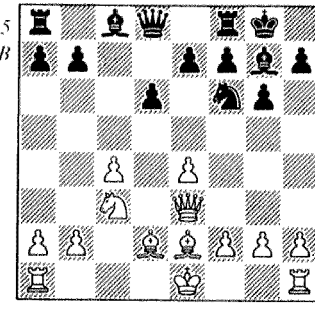
34 B



Petrosian-Belyavsky
USSR Ch 1975

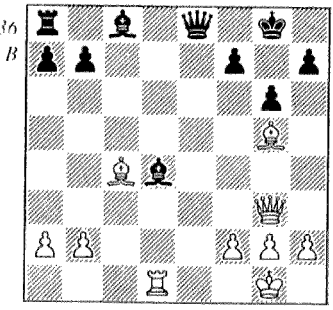
White already has some advantage and Black becomes impatient for counterplay. **13 ... e6 14 b4! b6** 14 ... d5 is impossible because of 15 e5, winning a piece. Belyavsky had hoped to be able to remove his queen from the d8-h4 diagonal so that ... d5 would become a real possibility, but

Petrosian's threat of b5 had to be met. **15 ♖ed1 ♕e7** A difficult decision. 15 ... ♖a7 can also be met by 16 ♕f4, while if 15 .. ♕b8 or 15 ... ♕d7, unpinning the knight, White plays 16 ♗b1 and increases the pressure on the d-pawn. 15 ... ♕c7 would allow the well-known idea 16 ♘d5! ed 17 cd, when White will gain the advantage of the two bishops and he will retain his pressure on the weak black d-pawn. **16 ♕f4 ♖fd8** 16 ... e5 17 ♕h4 ♕e6 allows the white knight to jump into d5. **17 a3 ♖ac8 18 ♕h4 a5** What else? Black is completely tied up. **19 h3 ♖c7 20 f4** Threatening e5. **20 ... h6** Sacrificing a pawn in order to relieve some of the pressure on his position. If 20 ... e5 21 b5 ♗b7 22 ♘d5 ♗xd5 23 cd, with a decisive positional advantage. **21 ♗xh6 ♗xh6 22 ♕xh6 ab 23 ab ♘h5 24 ♗e2 ♘f6 25 ♗d3 ♘h5 26 f5! ♕f6 27 ♘e2** Threatening 28 g4. **27 ... ♕e5 28 fg fg 29 ♕c3!** Not 29 ♕xg6+ ♖g7, when Black has a strong attack. **29 ... ♖b8.** Looking for counterplay with ... b5. **30 c5 bc 31 bc** White has a safe extra pawn and Black's king is dangerously exposed. The game concluded: 31 ... ♖d8 32 cd ♖xd6 33 ♖c5 ♖d5 34 ♖c3 ♖dd7 35 ♖dc1 ♗b7 36 ♖xc7 ♖xc7 37 ♖xc7 ♕xc7 38 e5 ♔g7 39 ♕g5 ♕f7 40 g4 ♕f3 41 ♕xg6+ ♔f8 42 gh Black resigned. Black's d-pawn never got past d6!



Keres-Barczay
Budapest 1970

Black decides to prepare for the advance of his d-pawn: **10 ... e6?! 11 0-0 d5 12 cd ed 13 ed** only to discover that White's superior development has become virtually decisive. **13 ... ♖e8** If 13 ... ♘xd5 at once then 14 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 15 ♗f3 leaves White well on top, e.g. 15 ... ♕d4 16 ♕xd4 ♗xd4 17 ♗b4 ♖e8 18 ♗a3, followed by ♖fd1. **14 ♕g3 ♘xd5 15 ♗b5! ♖e5** If 15 .. ♗d7 16 ♗g5! **16 ♖ad1 ♕e7 17 ♘xd5 ♖xd5 18 ♗c4! ♖d4 19 ♗g5 ♕e8 20 ♖xd4 ♗xd4 21 ♖d1** *(36)*



White has made good use of his lead in development to keep Black on the run. Every one of White's pieces is active, whereas only Black's king's bishop has advanced from the first rank. **21 ... ♗e6 22 ♖xd4 ♗xc4 23 h4** Now the threat to Black's bishop gives White time to mount a kingside attack. **23 ... ♗e6 24 ♗h6** Also good was 24 ♗f6. **24 ... f6 25 ♕d6** The queen would also be actively placed on c7. **25 ... ♖c8 26 ♖e4 ♔f7 27 ♖f4 ♕e7 28 ♕d4 ♖c1+ 29 ♔h2 ♖c4 30 ♕xa7 ♕c7 31 ♕a3! ♖c5 32 ♕g3 ♖f5.** Now 33 ♖b4! would have left White in command, but Keres mistakenly exchanged rooks and the endgame, with the resulting bishops of opposite colours, was drawn.

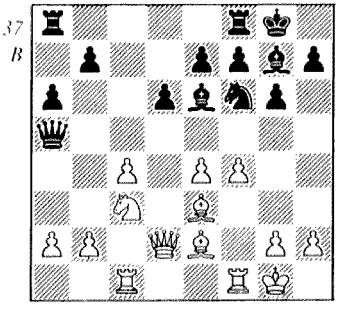
Conclusion

The plan of ... e6 followed by ... d5 is slow and difficult to put into operation in the Maroczy Bind lines where Black has fianchettoed his king's bishop. White can often use the time to help his development, with the result that after the exchanges in the centre White's initiative is substantial. If Black tries for ... d5 (by means of ... e6) and fails to execute his plan, his weak d-pawn (remember diagram 21) will quite likely be a permanent liability and he will be reduced to passivity.

Black Plays ... b5

The most successful of Black's pawn thrusts against the Maroczy Bind (in those lines where Black has fianchettoed his king's bishop) is the advance of the b-pawn. By attacking with his queenside pawn minority Black hopes to eliminate the pawn on c4, thereby destroying the bind and paving the way for the traditional Sicilian counterplay (i.e. pressure along the c-file and the possibility of ... d5).

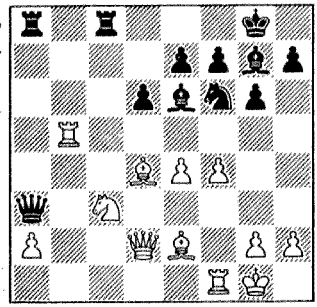
The following example shows the ideal situation from Black's point of view.



Cardoso-Adorjan
Arrecife de Lanzarote 1975

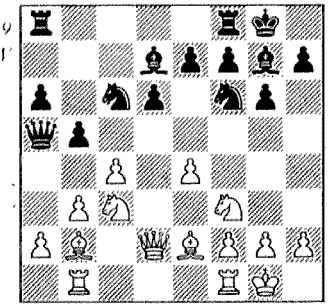
White has made the mistake of advancing his f-pawn too far – it usually belongs on f3 from where it can protect the e-pawn. **13 ... b5! 14 cb** White should be content to keep the game on an even keel with 14 b3 bc 15 f5 ♗d7 16 ♗xc4 **14 ... ab 15 b4** After 15 ♗xb5 ♘xe4

16 ♘xe4 ♕xb5 Black has the advantage. He has succeeded in exchanging a wing pawn for a central pawn (normally a good idea) with the result that he has the better control and White's queenside pawns are vulnerable. **15 ... ♕xb4 16 ♖b1 ♕a3 17 ♖xb5 ♖fc8** Now White's queenside is under tremendous pressure. **18 ♗d4** *(38)*



18 ... ♖xc3! 19 ♕xc3 ♘xe4 20 ♖b8+ 20 ♕xa3 loses at once to 20 ... ♗xd4+. **20 ... ♖xb8!! 21 ♕xa3 ♗xd4+ 22 ♔h1 ♘f2+ 23 ♖xf2** 23 ♔g1 ♖b2 is also extremely unpleasant. **23 ... ♗xf2 24 h3 h5** Threatening 25 ... ♖b1+ 26 ♔h2 h4 and ... ♗g3+. **25 ♕f3 ♖b1+ 26 ♔h2 ♗g1+ 27 ♔g3** Or 27 ♔h1 h4 and 28 ... ♗f2+. **27 ... ♖b2 28 ♕e4 ♖xa2 29 h4 d5!** Another pawn thrust. White's position is hopeless. The end was: 30 ♕e5 ♗c5 31 ♕b8+ ♔g7 32 ♕e5+ ♔h7 33 ♗f3 ♖a4 34 ♕c7 ♗d6 35 ♕c6 ♖xf4 36 ♔f2 ♖c4 37 ♕b5 ♖xh4 38 ♗xd5 ♖f4+ 39 ♗f3 ♗g4 40 ♕d5 ♖f5 41 ♕d3 h4 42 ♕e4 and White resigned because of 42 ... ♗xf3 43 gf h3 etc.

After Black's advance ... b5, White may decline to make the capture cb, but then he must reckon with the possibility of ... b4.



Andersson-Najdorf
Hastings 1971-2

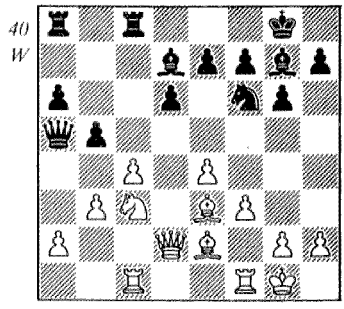
Black has just played 12 ... b5 under rather favourable circumstances. White's queen's knight is overworked in its tasks of controlling and defending a2 and e4, just as in the previous example, and so White cannot capture twice on b5. **13 a3 b4!** Ruining White's queenside. **14 ♘d5?!** Inappropriate here. Better was 14 ab ♕xb4 15 ♗a1, although after 15 ... ♖ab8 Black still has the advantage because of his pressure on White's queenside pawns. **14 ... ♘xe4 15 ♕e3 ♗xb2** If 15 ... ♘c3 16 ♘xc3 bc 17 b4, and it is White who has the advantage on the queenside.

16 ab ♕a2 17 ♗d3 17 ♕xe4?? would lose to 17 ... ♗f5. **17 ... ♘c3 18 ♘b6 ♘xb1 19 ♗xb1 ♕a3 20 ♘xd7 ♘xb4! 21 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 22 ♕xe7 ♕xb3** Black has an outside passed pawn and he is a pawn up. The game is a simple win: 23 ♕c7 d5 24 cd ♕xd5 25 h4 a5 26 ♕b6 ♖e8 27 ♕a7 ♔g7 28 ♕b6 ♖c6 29 ♕b8 ♗e5 30 ♕a7 ♗f6 31 ♖c1 ♖a6 32 ♕b8 ♕d6 33 ♕b5 ♖a7 34 ♗e4 a4 35 ♖b1 a3 0-1.

White's Counterblows against ... b5

Properly prepared, the thrust ... b5 can often serve as a most successful antidote to the Maroczy Bind. It is therefore most important for the player of the white pieces that he is always ready to meet ... b5 with a strong counterblow. This counterblow usually takes one of two forms – White either advances his c-pawn to the fifth rank, thereby throwing Black's game into disarray, or he has built up so much control over b5 and over the e4 and a2 squares that he is able to capture Black's b-pawn with impunity. Let us see how each of these ideas works out in practice.

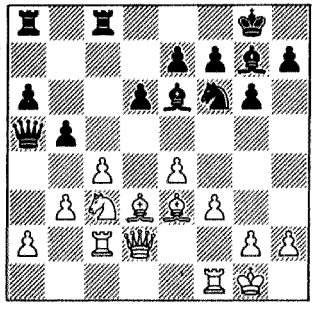
In our first example (diagram 40) Black has just played ... b5 under rather unfavourable circumstances – his bishop on d7 is not very well protected and this gives rise to the possibility of **15 c5!**



Polugayevsky-Bednarski
Siegen Olympiad 1970

because 15 ... dc?? loses a piece to 16 e5. **15 ... ♖c6** If 15 ... b4 16 ♘b1! and White will continue with 17 a3!, taking advantage of the fact that Black's b-pawn is pinned against his queen. Another possibility is 15 ... ♘e8, defending the d-pawn, but then comes the frequently recurring theme 16 ♘d5, and afer 16 ... ♕xd2 17 ♗xd2 ♖xc5 18 ♘xe7+ White has a big endgame advantage because of Black's isolated d-pawn. **16 cd ed** Weaker is 16 ... ♖xd6? 17 ♕e1 (threatening the fork 18 e5) 17 ... ♖c6 18 e5 ♘e8 19 ♘d5, and after the exchange of queens, White's pieces dominate the board. **17 ♖c2 ♖ac8 18 ♘d5** Having saddled Black with an isolated d-pawn on the semi-open file, White can evidently exchange off into the endgame. **18 ... ♕xd2 19 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 20 ♖xd2 ♗c3** 20 ... ♖c2 21 ♖fd1 ♗e6 22 ♔f2 also

leaves White with the better ending. **21 ♖dd1** Not 21 ♖c2?? ♗d4! winning material. White must always be on the look-out for his opponent's possibilities along the g1-a7 diagonal. **21 ... ♔f8 22 ♔f2 ♔e7 23 ♗d3 f6** Black could try 23 ... f5 but then the exchange would leave Black with three isolated pawns. **24 g4!** White begins to make use of his space advantage on the kingside. **24 ... ♗e6 25 h4 ♗b4 26 ♔g3 ♗c5 27 ♗f4 ♗a3 28 g5 ♗b2 29 ♗e3 ♖f8 30 ♖f2 ♗a3 31 ♗d4 f5 32 ef gf** Or 32 ... ♗xf5 33 ♗f6+ ♔d7 34 ♗xf5+ gf 35 ♔f4! and Black is lost. **33 ♖e2 ♖c1 34 ♖xc1 ♗xc1 35 ♖c2 ♖c8 36 ♖e2 ♔f7 37 f4 ♗a3 38 h5 ♖g8 39 g6+ hg 40 h6!** Black resigned. As we shall see later on in this chapter, White's advance c5 is often a serious positional threat.



41
W

Portisch-Gheorghiu
Siegen Olympiad 1970

White's e-pawn and a-pawn are so well protected that Black has no way to undermine their defences. White can now afford to exchange pawns on b4 leaving Black with an isolated pawn. **16 cb ab 17 ♖fc1 ♗d7?** Overlooking White's combination. Relatively best was 17 ... b4 18 ♘b5, when White's pieces are more active and Black has a weak isolated pawn. **18 ♘xb5!** Black had thought this move to be impossible because of **18 ... ♖xc2 19 ♖xc2 ♗xb5** when at first sight it appears that White has lost a piece; but after **20 ♖c8+!** it becomes clear that it is Black who loses. Note that 20 ♕xa5 ♖xa5 21 ♗d2 would be met by 21 ... ♖xa2! 22 ♖xa2 ♗xd3 when Black has two pieces for a rook. **20 ... ♖xc8** After 20 ... ♗e8 21 ♕xa5 ♖xa5 22 a4! threatening 23 ♗b5 with an overwhelming position. 20 ... ♗f8 21 ♖xa8 ♕xd2 22 ♗xd2 ♗xd3 23 ♗h6 would leave Black helpless against the advance of White's a-pawn. **21 ♕xa5 ♗xd3 22 b4!** Although White is nominally behind in material, his b-pawn streaks up the board at lightning speed. **22 ... ♘d7 23 b5 d5** After 23 ... ♗c3 24 ♕a6 White would continue by advancing the a-pawn. **24 b6 d4 25 b7 ♖b8 26 ♗f4 e5 27 ♕c7 ef** Or 27 ... ♗b5 28 ♕c8+! ♗f8 29 ♗xe5 ♖xc8 30 bc♕ ♘xe5 31 ♕b8, forking two pieces. **28 ♕xd7 ♗e5 29 ♕d5 ♖e8??** Losing

at once, but after 29 ... ♗c7 30 ♕c6 ♗e5 31 a4, White would still have every chance of winning the game, e.g. 31 ... ♗e2 32 ♔f2 ♗d1 33 a5 d3 34 ♔e1 ♗c2 35 a6 ♗d4 36 ♕c8+ ♔g7 37 ♕xb8 ♗c3+ 38 ♔f1. Now, after 29 ... ♖e8??, White would play 30 ♕xe5 ♖xe5 31 b8♕+ winning everything, but in the game Black lost on time with eleven moves still to make.

Conclusion

Black's ... b5 is most likely to be successful when White's e-pawn and/or a-pawn are inadequately protected. Before playing ... b5 Black should check the consequences of White's c5 and he should also make absolutely sure that the complications arising from White's twofold capture on b5 are not to White's advantage.

Principal Ideas for White

If White is able to stifle Black's freeing attempts ... f5, ... d5 and ... b5 (see above), it will be possible for him to keep control of the game and to build up his position to such an extent that Black is left powerless. White can then exploit his advantage in various ways:

1) If he has firm control of the d-file and/or the c-file, it will often be possible for him to advance his c-pawn up to c5 with devastating effect.

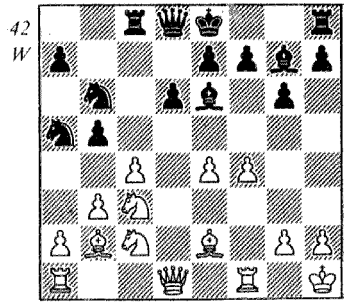
2) If his major pieces are geared more to control of the c-file than the d-file, White can usually play ♘d5 and after the virtually inevitable exchange on d5 he can recapture with the c-pawn and exploit his domination of the c-file, usually by infiltrating with a rook on the seventh rank.

3) If White's major pieces are well placed for an attack along the e-file, he can play ♘d5 and recapture with the e-pawn, thereby pressuring Black's pawn at e7.

4) If Black's position offers absolutely no hope of counterplay, White may be able to afford the luxury of a kingside attack.

White Plays c5

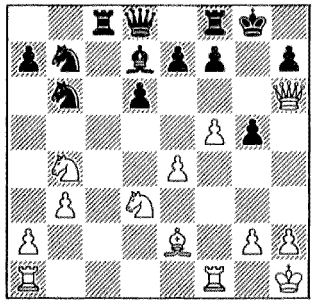
The Polugayevsky-Bednarski game above (p. 23) introduced the idea of c5. As soon as White advanced his e-pawn, Black's position collapsed. Here is another equally devastating example.



42
W

Taimanov-Jimenez
Leningrad 1967

14 c5! b4 Black cannot afford to capture the c-pawn because of (14 ... dc) 15 ♗xb5+ ♗d7 16 ♕e2, followed by ♖ad1 with tremendous pressure. 14 ... ♖xc5 loses material immediately to 15 b4. **15 ♘xb4 ♖xc5 16 ♘a4 ♗xb2 17 ♘xb2** The exchange of bishops has left Black weak on the dark squares and especially vulnerable on the kingside. **17 ... 0-0 18 ♕d2 ♘b7 19 ♘2d3 ♖c8 20 f5** Converting his initiative into a blistering attack. **20 ... ♗d7 21 ♕h6** Threatening 22 ♖f4 and mate on the h-file. **21 ... g5** What else can Black do? If 21 ... ♔h8 (intending to meet 22 ♖f4 with 22 ... ♖g8 23 ♖h4 ♖g7) 22 fg fg 23 ♘f4! ♖g8 24 ♗a6 and if 24 ... ♖b8 25 ♗xb7 ♖xb7 26 ♘xg6+ or 24 ... ♕c7 25 ♘bd5 ♘xd5 26 ♘xd5 followed by ♖f7 and mate on h7.



22 h4! f6 22 ... gh loses to 23 ♖f4 etc. **23 hg fg 24 ♕xg5+ ♔h8 25 ♘f4!** Black resigned. 25 ... ♖g8 is met by 26 ♘g6+.

Conclusion

If White can advance c5 without losing a pawn, the move will often cause great disarray in Black's ranks.

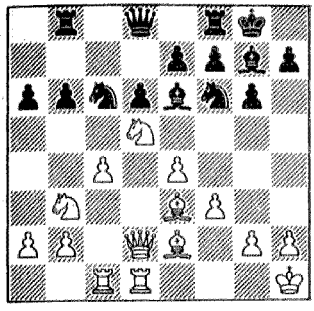
White Plays ♘d5

We have already seen, earlier in this volume, that d5 is the key square in the Sicilian Defence. If Black can successfully play ... d5 at any stage he almost invariably gets at least a satisfactory game, while if White keeps this square under control it will usually be he who retains the advantage. Since the Maroczy Bind, more than any other motif, is specifically designed to maximise White's control of d5, it is natural that the move should be constantly considered. An understanding of the merits and disadvantages of ♘d5 is essential if the reader is to have a good feel for Maroczy Bind positions.

Black does not or cannot exchange the knight on d5

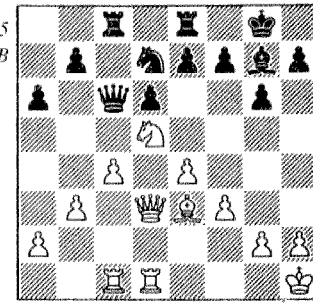
When White plays ♘d5 in the typical Maroczy Bind position, Black inevitably exchanges it off, either for his king's knight on f6 or for his queen's bishop on e6 (or occasionally c6). Why this exchange is so necessary can be seen from the two examples that follow.

44
B



Petrosian-Venalainen
Nice Olympiad 1974

45
B



Vasyukov-Triana
Cienfuegos 1975

White has just played ♘d5 and Black cannot exchange pieces because after the recapture with the c-pawn, White will be attacking both the a-pawn and the knight on c6. **16 ... ♘d7 17 ♘d4 ♘xd4 18 ♗xd4 ♗xd4 19 ♕xd4 ♖e8** To overprotect the e-pawn so that his queen will be free to move. **20 ♖c3** Intending a kingside attack beginning with f4 and ♖h3. **20 ... ♕c8 21 f4 ♕c5 22 ♕d2 ♖bc8 23 ♖dc1 ♕f2 24 ♖f1 ♕h4** If 24 ... ♕c5 25 f5 with a growing attack. **25 f5! ♗xd5 26 ed** Black resigned. Black is helpless against the threat of 27 ♖h3 ♕f6 28 fg ♕xg6 29 ♖g3. If 26 ... ♘e5 then 27 b3 followed by ♖h3.

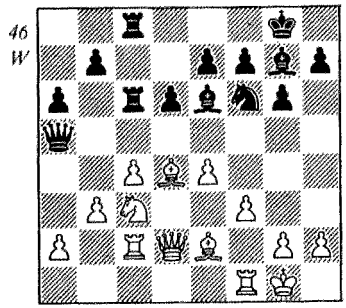
Diagram 45: **18 ... ♘c5 19 ♕d2 b6** Naturally Black can never drive away the knight with ... e6 as his d-pawn would then be fatally weak. **20 ♗h6 ♗xh6 21 ♕xh6 ♘d7 22 ♕h4 f6 23 ♖c3 ♘c5 24 f4** With the same idea as in the previous example – mate on on the h-file. **24 ... ♘xe4 25 ♖h3 ♕c5 26 ♖f1** Just in case anything unpleasant appears on f2, as there is nothing concrete yet after ♕xh7+. **26 ... ♕d4 27 f5! h5** Or 27 ... gf 28 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 29 ♕xf5 and mate soon follows. **28 ♖e3 gf 29 ♖xf5** Black resigned.

Conclusion

Although, in the two examples given above, Black was never able to exchange off White's knight on d5, these examples do serve to show that this knight can cause Black a variety of serious problems if it is allowed to stay on d5. Because of this it is nearly always the case that the move ♘d5 is almost immediately met by ... ♘xd5 or ... ♗xd5.

White Uses ♘d5 to Force an Endgame

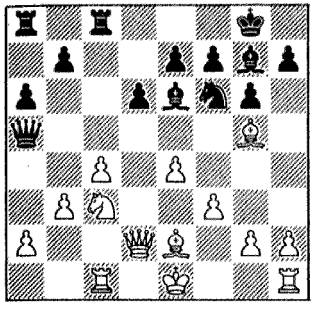
White very often delays the move ♘d5 until Black's queen is on a5 and White's is on d2. Then the move ♘d5 virtually compels Black to exchange queens, resulting in an endgame that experience has shown to be very much in White's favour. The next two examples illustrate the sort of difficulties that Black faces in these endings.



Tal-Ignatiev
USSR 1971

17 ♘d5! Black must exchange queens, otherwise he will be saddled with an isolated d-pawn (17 ... ♕d8 18 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 19 ♗xf6 ef). **17 ... ♕xd2 18 ♖xd2 ♗xd5 19 ed** Since Black has already doubled rooks on the c-file, White naturally recaptures this way, planning eventually to build pressure along the e-file. **19 ... ♖6c7 20 ♗b6 ♖d7 21 g4 ♘e8 22 ♔g2 e6** Trying to gain some freedom for his pieces which, at the moment, can hardly move – a clear illustration of the effect of the Maroczy Bind on Black's rooks when no satisfactory pawn break has been achieved. However, the text increases White's endgame advantage by leaving Black with three pawn islands (in general the fewer "islands" the better). **23 de fe 24 f4 ♗c3 25 ♖d3 ♗b4 26 ♗d4** Now we see the reason for Tal's 22nd move. With his king still on g1, White would not be able to keep this useful bishop on the board (26 ... ♗c5). This type of resource is often available to Black once the g1-a7 diagonal has been opened by the advance of White's f-pawn, and so White must always be on the lookout for Black's possibilities on the dark squares. **26 ... ♖f7 27 ♖e3 ♘g7 28 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 29 ♖xe6** Black's position is hopeless. In addition to being a pawn up, White has retained the more active position. The conclusion of the game was 29 ... ♖cf8 30 ♔g3 ♗d2 31 ♖e4 a5 32 g5 b6 33 h4 h5 34 ♗d3 ♔h8 25 ♗c2 ♔g7 36 ♖f3 and Black resigned.

Diagram 47: **14 ♘a4** Well, a4 is not quite the same as d5, but the effect is just the same. In fact 14 ♘d5 ♕xd2+ 15 ♔xd2 ♗xd5 16 ed allows Black the opportunity for 16 ... b5, with good counterplay. **14 ... ♕xd2+ 15 ♔xd2 ♖c6**



Karpov-Kavalek
Nice Olympiad 1974

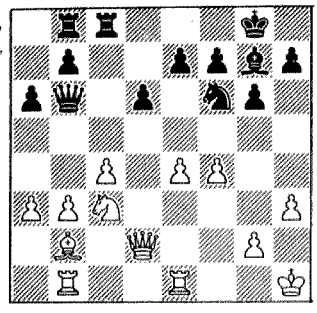
16 ♘c3 ♖ac8 17 ♘d5 ♔f8 17 ... ♗xd5 would eventually transpose back into the game. **18 ♗e3 ♘d7 19 h4 ♗xd5 20 ed ♖6c7 21 h5 ♔g8 22 f4 ♘c5 23 ♗g4 ♘e4+ 24 ♔d3 f5 25 ♗f3 b5 26 g4! bc+ 27 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 28 bc ♘c5+** Hoping that the opposite coloured bishops will help Black. If 28 ... ♖b8 29 ♗xe4 fe+ 30 ♔xe4 ♖b2 31 h6 ♗f8 32 g5, and Black is virtually a bishop down. **29 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 30 h6 ♗f8** 30 ... ♗h8 31 ♖b1 would be equally hopeless. **31 ♔c3** Here a more convincing continuation for White would have been 31 g5, and if 31 ... ♖a5 32 ♖b1 ♖xa2 33 c5 dc 34 d6 with an easy win. **31 ... fg 32 ♗xg4 ♔f7 33 ♗e6+ ♔f6 34 ♗g8 ♖c7 35 ♗xh7 e6 36 ♗g8 ed 37 h7 ♗g7??** Correct was 37 ... ♖xc4+ 38 ♔d3 ♗g7 39 ♗xd5 ♖c5 40 ♗e4, when White will not find it so easy to win. **38 ♗xd5 ♗h8 39 ♔d3 ♔f5 40 ♔e3 ♖e7+ 41 ♔f3 a5 42 a4 ♖c7 43 ♗e4+ ♔f6 44 ♖h6 ♖g7 45 ♔g4** Black resigned – he is paralysed. If 45 ... ♔f7 then 46 ♔g5 ♔e7 47 ♖h1 ♔f7 48 ♗d5+ ♔f8 49 ♖b1! ♖xh7 50 ♖b8+ ♔g7 51 ♖g8 mate.

Conclusion

Black must be very wary of allowing White to enter this type of ending. Black rarely has any counterplay and is faced with the very difficult task of trying to find the "right" move time and time again and if he should ever fail in this task, he will almost certainly lose.

White gets a Kingside Attack

When ♘d5 is played under cirumstances that do not allow the exchange of queens, a different option is open to White. He may recapture on d5 with the e-pawn instead of the c-pawn, thereby introducing the possibility of pressure on Black's pawn at e7. It is not so much this pressure that should worry Black as the effect of combining the attack on the e-pawn with veiled threats against Black's kingside. After all, with queens still on the board, there is no reason why White should not launch a kingside attack once Black's army has been tied to the defence of the e-pawn.



Tal-Jakobsen
Skopje Olympiad 1972

21 ♘d5! ♘xd5 22 ed ♗xb2 23 ♖xb2 ♕c7 Compare the two armies of major pieces. White is by far the more active and the more mobile. Also, White has the traditional advantage in space that normally accrues once he has set up the Maroczy Bind. **24 f5! b5 25 fg hg 26 ♕g5 bc** The best chance. If 26 ... ♖e8 27 ♖be2 ♖b7 28 ♖e6! ♔g7 29 ♖xg6+ fg 30 ♖e6 with a mating attack. **27 ♖xe7 ♕c5 28 ♕f6 ♕xd5** If 28 ... ♖f8 29 ♖e4 followed by ♖h4 and mate. **29 bc ♕xc4** 29 ... ♕f5 30 ♖f2 ♕xf6 31 ♖xf6 ♖f8 32 ♖xd6 gives White a won ending. **30 ♖f2 ♖f8 31 ♖f4 ♕c1+ 32 ♔h2 ♕b2** If 32 ... ♖b1 33 ♖g4, and White's attack is decisive, e.g. 33 ... ♕h6 34 ♖xf7 etc. **33 ♖xf7 ♕xf6 34 ♖7xf6 ♖xf6** The pawn ending, after 34 ... ♔g7 35 ♖xf8 ♖xf8 36 ♖xf8 ♔xf8 37 ♔g3 is an easy win for White because he can create an outside passed pawn. **35 ♖xf6 ♔g7 36 ♖xd6** The rest is simple: 36 ... a5 37 ♖d5 ♖a8 38 a4 ♖a6 39 ♔g3 ♔f6 40 ♔f4 ♔e6 41 ♖b5 ♔f6 42 ♖c5 ♖b6 43 ♖xa5 ♖b4+ 44 ♔g3 ♖b3+ and Black resigned.

Conclusion

A white knight firmly established on d5 is a powerful weapon since it is aimed at Black's weak dark squares on the queenside, it attacks Black's e-pawn and it might eventually take part in a direct assault on the black king.

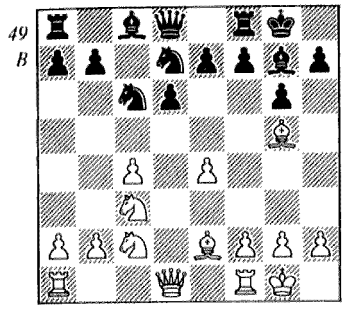
Whether or not White can afford to play ♘d5 depends on the assessment of the position after Black exchanges off the knight. The resulting endings tend to favour White unless his opponent has play along the e-file.

Other Themes

We have now discussed all of the most frequently seen ideas in typical Maroczy Bind positions. The examples which follow illustrate other themes which, although they do not occur so often, should be remembered when playing the Maroczy Bind or fighting against it.

Black Attacks on the Queenside

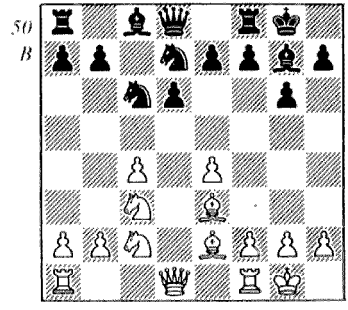
Diagram 49: Black plans to launch a queenside attack before White can establish a grip on the game.



Cvetković-Sahović
Yugoslav Ch 1974

10 ... ♘c5 Also possible is 10 ... ♗xc3 11 bc ♘c5 with similar play to the next example. **11 f3 a5 12 ♕d2 a4 13 ♖ab1 ♕a5 14 ♔h1?** White should exchange queens by ♘d5. **14 ... a3!** Smashing White's queenside. 15 ♘xa3 loses a piece and so **15 b4 ♗xc3 16 ♕e3** If 16 ♕xc3 ♘xe4 17 fe ♕xg5 and Black is a safe pawn ahead. **16 ... ♘xb4 17 ♕xc3 ♘a4! 18 ♕xb4 ♕xg5 19 ♖b3 ♘c5 20 f4 ♕h6 21 ♖e3** White has nothing to show for the lost pawn. **21 ... ♖a4 22 ♕c3 ♗d7 23 ♘b4 ♗c6 24 ♘d5 ♗xd5 25 ed ♕g7! 26 ♕e1 f5** The rest is not very complicated: 27 ♗d1 ♖xc4 28 ♖xe7 ♕f6 29 ♗f3 ♖e4 30 ♖xe4 fe 31 ♗g4 ♕d4 32 ♗e6+ ♔h8 33 ♕h4 ♕f6 34 ♕h3 ♘d3 35 ♕e3 ♘c5 36 ♕xa3 ♘xe6 37 de ♕xe6 38 ♕b2+ ♔g8 39 ♕xb7 e3 40 ♕f3 d5 41 ♖d1 d4! 42 ♖e1 0-1.

Black Gives up his Fianchettoed King's Bishop



Stein-Kapengut
USSR Ch 1971

10 ... ♗xc3! It is not very often that a fianchettoed king's bishop *can* be given up for a knight because of the resulting weakness of the castled king's position. Here the "sacrifice" is fully justifiable because, by doubling White's c-pawns Black ensures his knight a safe square on c5. **11 bc ♕a5 12 ♕d2 ♘c5 13 f3 ♗e6 14 ♘d4 ♖ac8** The pressure mounts on White's doubled, isolated pawns. **15 ♖ab1 b6 16 ♗h6 ♖fe8 17 ♖b5 ♕a3 18 ♘xe6 fe** Black's doubled pawns are of no real consequence and they control some important central squares. **19 h4 ♘d8 20 h5 ♘f7 21 hg hg 22 ♗e3 ♔g7** White has no more play on the kingside and Black now proceeds to increase his command of the board: 23 ♖f2

♖h8 24 ♗f1 e5 25 g3 ♘d7 26 ♕c2 ♖h7 27 ♖b4 ♕a6 28 ♕a4? (28 c5 would have left Black with only a slight positional advantage. But after the exchange of queens White can never hope to hold the endgame) 28 ... ♕xa4 29 ♖xa4 ♖c7 30 ♖d2 ♘d8 31 f4 ♘e6 32 ♗g2 ♘ec5 33 ♖b4 ♘f6 34 fe de 35 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 36 ♖b5 ♖h8! 37 ♖xc5 bc 38 ♖b2 ♖d8 39 ♖b5 ♖d1+ 40 ♔h2 ♘g4+ 41 ♔h3 ♘f2+ 42 ♔h2 ♘g4+ 43 ♔h3 ♘e3 44 ♖xc5 g5! 45 ♖xe5 ♔f6 46 ♖c5 g4+ 47 ♔h4 ♖d2 0-1.

The Golden Rules of the Maroczy Bind with ... g6

1) If Black remains passive, White's positional advantage must tell in the long run.

2) Black should try for ... b5 so long as White's e-pawn and/or a-pawn are insufficiently protected.

3) Black can only afford to play for ... f5 when he can be sure of recapturing on f5 with his knight (h6) – if White can exchange off this knight and then exchange on f5, Black will (at best) have a bad ending.

4) Black should not expect to be able to play ... e6 and ... d5 so long as he is behind in development.

5) Both sides should always be on the alert for White's c5.

6) If White's queen's knight goes to d5, Black should exchange it as soon as possible.

7) If Black's queen is on a5 and White's is on d2, the ending arising after ♘d5 ♕xd2 will favour White unless Black has control of the c-file.

8) If Black plays ... a5 White should watch out for the further advance of this pawn, and then try to take advantage of Black's weak b5 square.

9) If Black is completely tied to defence and queens are still on the board, White can consider a king-side attack.

10) Black's king's bishop can be exchanged for White's c3 knight if Black can create play against the doubled pawns (i.e. establishing a knight on c5 and/or a rook on c8).

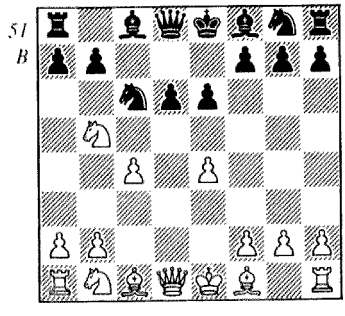
3 The Maroczy Bind with ... e6

Positions of the type considered in this chapter arise perhaps slightly less frequently than those in the previous chapter, though perhaps rather more often directly from the Sicilian; this is because the positions dealt with here are almost invariably reached via the Sicilian. To be precise, these positions normally occur in the following variations:

1) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 a6.**

2) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘b5** and, most often,

3) **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘c6 5 ♘b5** 5 c4 at once is weak: 5 ... ♘f6 6 ♘c3 ♗b4 and the pressure on White's centre suggests that it is over-extended. **5 ... d6 6 c4**



As in the variations examined on p.15, White has exchanged his opening initiative for a slight advantage in space and the restricting effect of the Maroczy Bind. There are three significant differences:

1) Black has more influence in the centre thanks to the pawn on e6;

2) That advantage is partly cancelled by the comparative weakness of the pawn on d6.

3) White has lost time with his knight manoeuvre to b5. However, this is not a serious drawback since, because of the additional pressure on d6, Black will have to use a move to chase the knight away.

The assessment of both the position and of the variations which lead to it is that chances are balanced; everything depends upon the accuracy and the understanding with which both players carry out their strategy.

White's Basic Strategy

To maintain the bind, which means:

1) Being aware of the possibilities at Black's disposal to destroy White's grip, so he
2) Must constantly watch for pawn breaks;
3) To strengthen his position, especially on the d-file.
4) Ultimately:
a) To strangle Black;
b) To win Black's d-pawn;
c) To attack on the kingside if the opportunity presents itself; or
d) To go for the endgame if it is going to be favourable but this will be the case less often here than in the previous chapter (primarily because Black is better off in the centre).

Black's Basic Strategy

Try to break the bind, the lump in his throat caused by the difficulty of internal communications within his position, which means:
1) Being aware of the ways that can destroy White's grip, so he
2) Must constantly look to see if he can employ a pawn break;
3) To strengthen his position;
4) Ultimately:
a) To obtain active counterplay, even, if necessary, at the cost of a pawn; or
b) To try to hold the ending.

Let us now look more closely at how each side should handle these positions. The material is divided as follows:

Ideas for Black

Black plays ... b5
Black plays ... d5
Black plays ... f5

Ideas for White

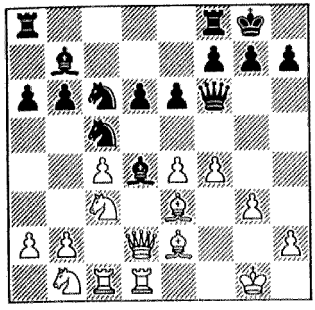
White plays ♘d5
White plays c5
White gets a kingside attack.

Before examining the individual ideas in detail, it is well worth looking at the following game; a flawless example of the complete triumph of White's entire strategy and a complete denial of Black's.

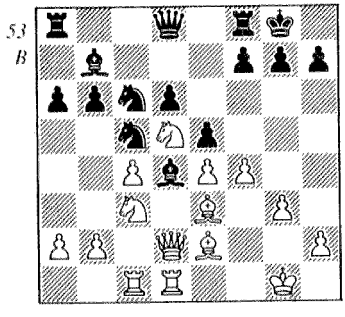
Karpov-F.Olafsson
Amsterdam 1976

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘b5 d6 6 c4 ♘f6 7 ♘1c3 a6 8 ♘a3 ♗e7 9 ♗e2 0-0 10 0-0 b6 11 ♗e3 ♗b7 12 ♕b3 Putting pressure on d5 and b5. The active phase of the opening now gets underway. **12 ... ♘d7 13 ♖fd1 ♘c5** Chasing away some of the pressure. **14 ♕c2** Not 14 ♗xc5 bc 15 ♕xb7 ♘a5 and White's queen is lost. **14 ... ♗f6 15 ♖ac1 ♗e5** Black is right not to be tempted by the pawn: 15 ... ♗xc3 16 ♕xc3 ♘xe4 17 ♕d3! ♘b4 18 ♕b3 a5 19 ♘b5 d5 20 ♗f3 with a tremendous position for White; 20 ... dc 21 ♖xc4 ♗d5 loses to 22 ♖xe4! **16 ♘ab1 ♕h4 17 g3 ♕f6 18 f4** Black's attempts on the king-

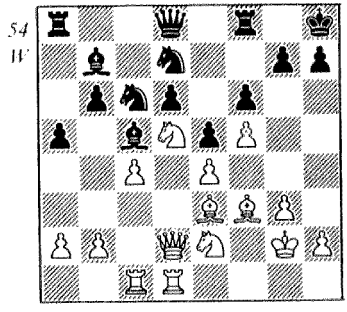
side result in further territorial gains by White. **18 ... ♗d4 19 ♕d2** *(52)*


52
B

19 ... e5 Now Black has lost the possibility of the freeing ... d5 but 19 ... ♗xe3+ 20 ♕xe3 would result in a complete positional bind. In order to withstand White's onslaught, Black must hold his advanced post at d4. **20 ♘d5 ♕d8 21 ♘bc3** *(53)*


53
B

21 ... ♔h8 Not 21 ... f5 22 ef ♖xf5 23 ♗g4 ♖f8 24 b4 with an immense advantage. **22 f5** Two of Black's possible breaks are gone for good and his d-pawn is backward on a half-open file. **22 ... ♘d7 23 ♗f3 ♗c5** Trying to stave off the advance of White's queenside pawns but this involves further positional concessions. **24 ♔g2 f6 25 ♘e2 a5** *(54)*


54
W

The next hole in the black camp; unfortunate but it cannot be helped (otherwise b4 is very strong). Now *all* of Black's pawn breaks have been prevented *and* White controls the d5 square in front of Black's backward pawn. **26 ♘dc3 ♖f7 27 ♘b5 ♕b8 28 ♘xd6** The positional crush reaches its conclusion and Black's d-pawn falls off. Karpov duly won the ending. A remarkable demonstration of a total triumph for White's basic strategy.

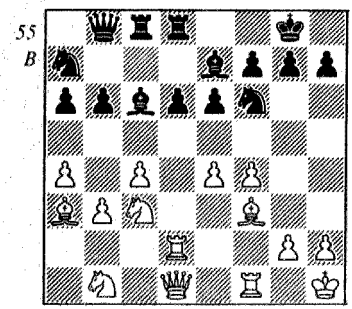
Ideas for Black

The three main ideas at Black's disposal are the pawn breaks:

... b5
... d5
... f5

Black plays ... b5

This idea is much less common here than in positions with Black's king's bishop fianchettoed on g7. In the latter case ... b5 often acts as a prelude to mounting a serious onslaught on c3 and the knight, frequently undefended, which sits innocently on that square. With Black's king's bishop on e7, ... b5 has no such recommendation and is usually a luxury, to be employed *after* Black has already freed his position.



Tatai-Jansa
Madonna Di Campiglio 1973

White has built up the pressure on d6 and has done what he can to hold back both ... b5 and ... d5, while Black has done almost all he can to prepare those moves and so: **18 ... b5** 18 ... ♗f8, retaining the tension, waiting for a more opportune time to strike, is probably much better. **19 e5 b4 20 ef ♗xf6 21 ♗b2 bc 22 ♗xc3 ♗xc3 23 ♘xc3** Now if we assess this position we see that it is favourable for White. The main reasons for this conclusion are that White has a queenside pawn majority, still hinders Black's freeing move ... d5 and his pieces are more centrally located. ... b5 really does seem to be possible only after Black has achieved a measure of freedom elsewhere. **23 ... ♗xf3 24 ♖xf3 ♘c6** Taking care of one problem – the off-side knight. **25 ♘e4** A mistake, not so much in analysis as in strategy. White has played completely logically up to this point but now errs, albeit in a "logical" manner, putting more pressure on d6 when he could, and should, have taken the opportunity to start a kingside attack with 25 ♖g3. **25 ... d5! 26 cd ed 27 ♘g3** 27 ♖xd5 fails to 27 ... ♖xd5 28 ♕xd5 ♖d8! – a useful idea to remember. **27 ... d4 28 ♘f5 ♖d5 29 ♘e3** Draw Agreed.

Conclusion

Since Black's ... b5 does not act as a prelude to mounting a sustained attack on c3, as it did in the positions dealt with in the previous chapter, it follows that the idea has less force here. Since this is the case, Black should regard the move as a luxury which may be of value (as in diagram 62, p.41) but which should be held in reserve

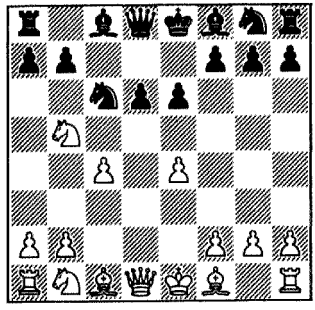
until one of the more forceful freeing moves has been played.

Black Plays ... d5

This move, so rare in the previous chapter, is the mainstay of Black's liberation attempts in the type of position under consideration in this chapter.

First of all an example in which ... d5 achieves equality; no more, no less.

51 B

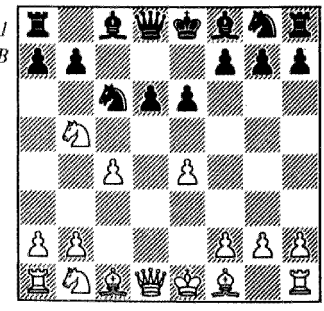


Lutikov-Taimanov
USSR Championship 1960

From diagram 51 play went **6 ... ♘f6 7 ♘5c3 ♗e7 8 ♗e2 0-0 9 0-0 b6 10 b3 ♗b7 11 ♗b2 d5! 12 cd ed 13 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 14 ed ♘b4** A common idea for regaining the pawn shed by ... d5 which would otherwise be premature. **15 ♘c3 ♘xd5 16 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 17 ♕xd5 ♗xd5** and a draw was agreed since the position is dead level.

Under more favourable conditions, ... d5 can lead to a substantial advantage for Black.

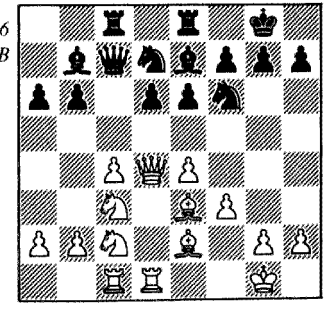
51 B



Adorjan-Portisch
Wijk aan Zee 1972

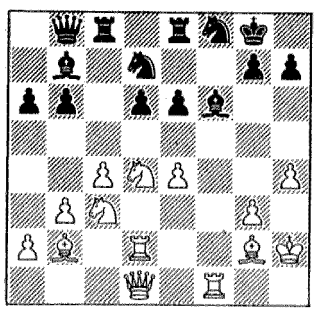
6 ... ♘f6 7 ♘1c3 a6 8 ♘a3 ♗e7 9 ♗e2 0-0 10 0-0 b6 11 ♗e3 ♗b7 12 ♕d2 ♘e5 13 ♕d4 A waste of time, this move achieves nothing. **13 ... ♘ed7 14 ♖fd1 ♖e8!** This is often a very, very useful move. In isolation it is hard to comprehend its value but Black's main difficulty is in activating his pieces, especially the rooks, so this piece is placed here in anticipation of a pawn break (not available yet) when it will be well placed on an open or half-open file. **15 ♘c2 ♕c7 16 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 17 f3** *(56)*

56 B



It will soon become clear that this is a mistake. f3 is a common enough idea for White (to strengthen his centre) but it can, as here, involve a weakening of the centre if the position should be opened up; there will be a greater danger of dark square weaknesses and the bishop on e3 is denied a useful defender. **17 ... d5!** The conditions are ideal and this now leads to a win. **18 cd ed 19 ♘xd5** Not 19 ed ♗c5 and ... ♖xe3 will be very unpleasant. **19 ... ♘xd5 20 ed ♗f6 21 ♕b4 ♕e5!** Threatening 22 ... ♖xc2 **22 f4** Or 22 ♖d3 ♕xb2 23 ♖b3 ♕xa2 **22 ... ♕xb2 23 ♗g4 ♖xc2 24 ♕xb2 ♖xb2 25 ♗xd7 ♖xe3 26 ♖c7** To restore material equality, but now **26 ... ♗d4 27 ♔h1 ♖d2 28 ♖b1 g6 29 ♖xb7 ♗c5 30 ♗c6 ♖ee2 31 d6 ♖xd6 32 ♗f3 ♖xa2 33 f5 a5** White resigned.

... d5 invariably frees Black's play and here White's weaknesses were the deciding factor.

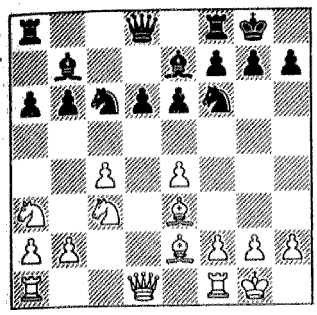


57
B

Geller-Fraguela
Las Palmas 1976

... d5 is rarely bad. The most common reason for the failure of ... d5 is that it leaves something *en prise*! However, "the move" is not the be-all and end-all of Black's strategy and if he has already freed his game in some other way, then he *must* think before playing ... d5 as well; it may be too greedy and rebound by freeing White's game more than Black's, as in diagram 57.

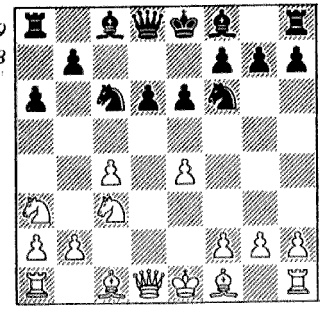
This position was arrived at, incidentally, from an English Opening. Black now had to decide if he should play ... d5. He did: **29 ... d5??** This move is just not necessary here. Earlier on, White had played f5 and captured on e6 opening the f-file. So Black's basic problem, the constriction of his position and lack of open files, was already solved. Fraguela should have played 29 ... ♘e5 with a good game. Never play a pawn break just because you can; play it because you need to. **30 ed! ed 31 ♘xd5 ♗xh4** This was Black's idea but what has actually happened is that he has simply opened up the position for a decisive kingside onslaught by White. **32 ♕g4 ♘g6 33 ♘f5! ♗f6 34 ♘h6+! gh 35 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 36 ♖xf6 ♗xg2 37 ♖xg6+** and Black resigned in view of the fact that he would find himself mated after 37 ... hg 38 ♕xg6+.



58
W

Karpov-Kasparov
Moscow (game 3) 1984-5

12 ♕b3 ♘a5 13 ♕xb6 ♘xe4 14 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 15 ♕xd8 ♗xd8 16 ♖ad1 d5?! 17 f3 ♗f5 18 cd ed 19 ♖xd5 Black really does not have anything for the pawn. **19 ... ♗e6 20 ♖d6 ♗xa2 21 ♖xa6 ♖b8 22 ♗c5 ♖e8 23 ♗b5! ♖e6 24 b4 ♘b7 25 ♗f2 ♗e7 26 ♘c2 ♗d5 27 ♖d1 ♗b3 28 ♖d7! ♖d8** If 28 ... ♗xc2 then 29 ♖xe6 fe 30 ♖xe7 ♘d6 31 ♗d7 ♖xb4 32 ♗c5 ♖b1+ 33 ♔f2 wins. **29 ♖xe6 ♖xd7 30 ♖e1! ♖c7 31 ♗b6** Black resigned. If 31 ... ♖xc2 then 32 ♖xe7 ♘d6 33 ♗c5.



59
B

Karpov-Kasparov
Moscow (game 16) 1985

8 ... d5 Widely hailed as the most interesting move of the last 40 years! **9 cd ed 10 ed ♘b4 11 ♗e2 ♗c5 12 0-0 0-0 13 ♗f3** Giving back the pawn by 13 ♗g5 ♘bxd5 14 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 15 ♗xf6 ♕xd1 16 ♖fxd1 gf would establish equality. **13 ... ♗f5 14 ♗g5 ♖e8 15 ♕d2 b5 16 ♖ad1 ♘d3** Black's pieces enjoy remarkable, and well co-ordinated activity in return for the pawn. **17 ♘ab1 h6 18 ♗h4 b4** Putting both the white knights offside. **19 ♘a4 ♗d6 20 ♗g3 ♖c8 21 b3 g5! 22 ♗xd6 ♕xd6 23 g3 ♘d7!** Freeing f6 for the queen and eyeing a possible route towards d3 to reinforce the other, huge knight. **24 ♗g2 ♕f6 25 a3 a5 26 ab ab 27 ♕a2** White is almost in zugzwang on an open board! **27 ... ♗g6 28 d6 g4 29 ♕d2 ♔g7 30 f3 ♕xd6 31 fg ♕d4+ 32 ♔h1 ♘f6 33 ♖f4 ♘e4 34 ♕xd3 ♘f2+ 35 ♖xf2 ♗xd3 36 ♖fd2 ♕e3 37 ♖xd3 ♖c1 38 ♘b2 ♕f2 39 ♘d2 ♖xd1+ 40 ♘xd1 ♖c1+** and White resigned.

Conclusion

Both sides should remember that in this type of position, ... d5 is hardly ever bad for Black; the only circumstances when it should not be played are: (a) when it simply loses a pawn and (b) when it gives White too much scope for a kingside attack (as in Geller-Fraguela).

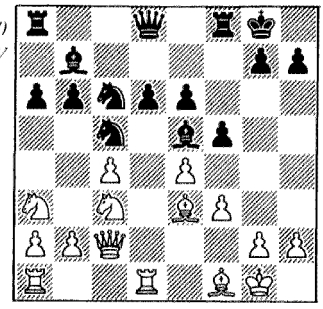
Two particular ideas which may enable ... d5 to be played when it appears simply to lose a pawn are: (a) ... ♘b4, attacking the white pawn which has arrived at d5 and discovering a second attack on that pawn from the bishop on b7; (b) if White has played f3, he may not be able to capture on d5 if Black has a rook on e8 because of threats along the e-file. These possibilities should be watched for carefully by both players.

Black plays ... f5

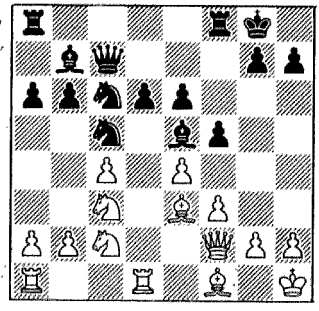
It is not so often that Black gets the chance to play ... f5, but it is a very important idea, especially if White has incurred any weaknesses in the defences around his king. Timing, as always, is of the greatest importance and if White plays f3 too early then it is well worth Black checking to see if ... f5 can be employed, as it can pave the way for a fierce kingside attack against the white king.

Faibisovich-Furman
Leningrad 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘b5 d6 6 c4 ♘f6 7 ♘1c3 a6 8 ♘a3 ♗e7 9 ♗e2 0-0 10 0-0 b6 11 ♗e3 ♗b7 12 ♕b3 ♘d7 f3 ♖fd1 ♘c5 14 ♕c2 Again not 14 ♗xc5 bc 15 ♕xb7 ♘a5 and the white queen is lost. **14 ... ♗f6 15 f3 ♗e5 16 ♗f1 f5** *(60)*


60
W

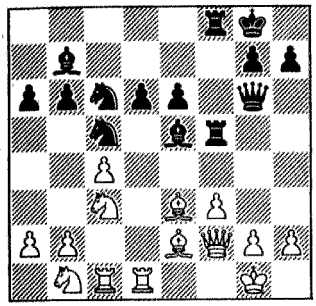
Six years before this game was played, Furman (Black) had reached the position in diagram 61 against Gufeld in the Soviet Championship.


61
W

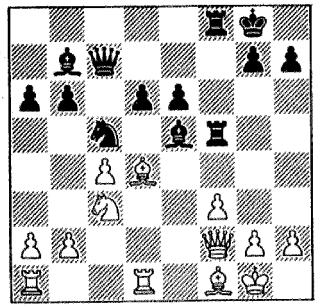
If we compare the two positions, we see that Gufeld has had time to centralise his knight from a3 to c2 and has played his king into the corner, so there is not even a potential pin on the g-file; thus f3 is less of a weakness. Gufeld had time for such building repairs because Furman had lost time playing ... ♖fe8-f8.

Faibisovich has no such advantages and the game continued

17 ef ♖xf5 18 ♕f2 ♕f6 19 ♖ac1 ♖f8 20 ♘ab1 ♕g6 Threatening 21 ... ♖xf3! This is the other major drawback to the move f3; when Black played ... d5 we found that the main weakness lay on e3, now the sore spot is shifted to the right. **21 ♗e2** *(62)*


62. B

What a difference Black's saving in time has made.


63. B

In diagram 63, reached in the Gufeld-Furman game after (from diagram 61) 20 ef ♖xf5 21 ♘d4 ♘xd4 22 ♗xd4 ♖af8 23 ♔g1, Black has achieved complete equality and the game was drawn by repetition after 23 ... ♗f4 24 ♗e3 ♗e5 25 ♗d4 etc.

Meanwhile, in the Faibisovich-Furman game, the tide has swung completely in favour of Black and he is able to carry out another of his thematic breaks; not just because he can but because he wants to. **21 ... b5! 22 cb ab 23 ♘d2** 23 ♗xb5 is not on because of 23 ... ♖xf3!, e.g. 24 ♕d2 ♘d4! and the threat of 25 ... ♖f2 is decisive. 23 ♘xb5 also does not bear thinking about for long – White's kingside is too weak; one possible line is 23 ... ♘e4 24 ♕e1 ♗xh2+ 25 ♔xh2 (25 ♔h1 ♗g3 and ♕h5+ mating, or 25 ♔f1 ♗g3 somewhat embarrassing White's queen!) 25 ... ♖h5+ 26 ♔g1 ♘g3 27 ♔f2 (otherwise 27 ... ♖h1+) 27 ... ♖h2 with an overwhelming attack. **23 ... ♘b4** More pressure goes on f3 (and on d3 too). **24 ♕h4 ♘cd3** Black's position is overwhelming. White had to give up material now and Black was able to convert his advantage comfortably enough in an endgame (prolonged due to extreme time pressure): 25 ♕g4 ♘xc1 26 ♖xc1 ♕xg4 27 fg ♖5f7 28 ♘xb5 ♘xa2 29 ♖c4 ♗d5 30 ♖a4 ♘c1 31 ♗f3 ♗xb2 32 ♘xd6 ♖d7 33 ♘2c4 ♗xc4 34 ♘xc4 ♗d4 35 ♖a3 e5 36 h3 ♖b8 37 ♔h2 ♘b3 38 ♗xd4 ed 39 ♘e5 ♖d6 40 ♘c6 ♖b5 41 ♘e7+ ♔f8 42 ♘f5 ♖d8 43 ♖a7 d3 44 ♘xg7 ♘d4 0-1 (time).

Conclusion

Since Black's king's knight frequently remains seated on f6, the idea of ... f5 is not as common as that of ... d5. However, Black's f6 knight may hop round to c5, usually to attack the white queen on b3. White should not automatically assume that this is *solely* to reduce the pressure against b5 and d5 and should be on his guard for a subsequent ... f5, especially if he has played f3, as this usually shows up to be a severe weakness whenever the position becomes sharp.

Ideas for White

Really White's principal idea is to prevent Black from breaking out of the bind; if White can succeed in that then he doesn't need too many other ideas ("look after the Bind and the Bind will look after the points"). However, there are a few useful ideas to remember:

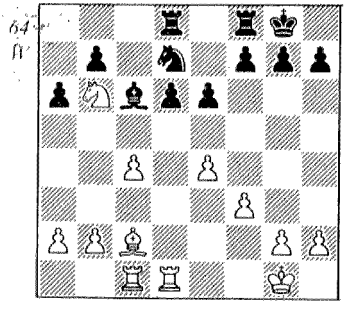
1) ♘d5, usually as a means of capitalising on the Bind;
2) c5 as a means of improving the Bind;
3) Using the space advantage conferred by the Bind to launch a kingside attack.

White Plays ♘d5

Even though Black has a pawn on e6, White (and Black!) should bear in mind the possibility of ♘d5. Though this move does not appear with the same frequency that it does in ... g6 Maroczy Binds, when it can be played it is often more destructive.

The principal requisites for the move to be playable are either
1) Black should have a piece on c6;
2) Black's queen should be on c7 or a piece should be on d7 so that either cd pins a piece against the queen or ed attacks a piece on c6 which has no flight square.

The move ♘d5 often has extra force in these positions because it usually attacks a piece on e7 rather than just a pawn as in the previous chapter. Purely tactical opportunities for ♘d5 should be comparatively easy to calculate, so here is a more difficult, positional example.



Fischer-Rossetto
Mar del Plata 1959

Black was now taken by surprise when Fischer played **19 ♘d5!**

Rossetto's state of confusion was shown by his reply **19 ... ♗xd5** 19 ... ♘e5! was a safe defence. **20 ed e5 21 b4** Playing for the important breakthrough – c5. **21 ... g6 22 ♗a4 b6** Or 22 ... ♘b6 23 ♗b3 followed by c5. **23 ♖d3 f5?** 23 ... a5 was a better defence, making it harder for White to achieve his break. **24 ♖a3!** Threatening simply 25 ♗xd7. **24 ... ♘b8** The only other try is 24 ... a5 and then 25 ba ba 26 ♗c6! ♘c5 27 ♖xa5 and White should win. **25 c5!** White's strategy triumphs. The conclusion of the game is a demonstration of how elegantly good technique can win a won game: **25 ... bc** 25 ... b5 26 ♗b3 ♖f7 27 c6 ♖c7 28 ♖a5! ♔f7 29 a4 ba 30 ♖xa4 ♔e7 31 ♗c4 is Fischer's analysis for picking up the a-pawn. **26 bc dc 27 ♖xc5 ♔g7 28 ♖b3 ♖f7 29 d6! ♘d7 30 ♖c7 ♘f8 31 ♖bb7 ♖xc7 32 dc ♖c8 33 ♗b3!** Black is now reduced to pawn moves. **33 ... a5 34 a4 h6 35 h3 g5 36 g4 fg 37 hg** 1-0. Black has completely run out of moves. 37 ... ♔f6 38 ♖b8 or 37 ... ♘g6 38 ♗e6 or 37 ... ♖e8 38 c8♕+.

Conclusion

If Black has either a minor piece on c6 or a queen on c7, both sides should bear in mind the possibility of ♘d5; if Black's piece disposition includes both of the above then each player should think very hard indeed about the consequences of the knight "sacrifice".

White Plays c5

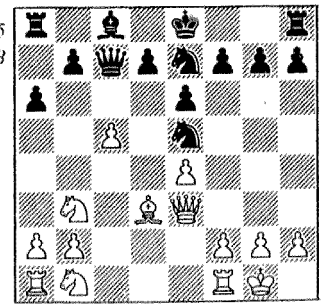
In Chapter 2 we saw the disruptive power that could be exerted by the move c5. If Black's d-pawn is still unmoved, the power of c5 can be enormous and just the one pawn may exert a comprehensive bind on Black's possibilities (or lack of them) for development.

The following example of this idea also shows the classic theme of the "transfer of advantages"; White's enormous advantage in space is converted into a winning kingside attack.

Karpov-Taimanov
USSR Olympiad 1972

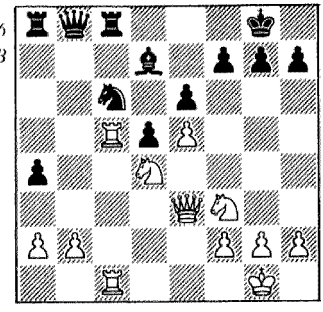
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♗d3 ♗c5 6 ♘b3 ♗b6 7 0-0 ♘e7 8 ♕e2 ♘bc6 9 ♗e3 ♘e5 10 c4! ♗xe3 11 ♕xe3 ♕c7 12 c5! *(65)*

65
B



White now threatens to build up an enormous bind and would have

no objection to playing f4 and e5, with a4-a5 for good measure, as a long-term plan; then Black really would be dead. **12 ... ♘xd3** If 12 ... ♘g4 then 13 ♕g3 ♕xg3 14 hg and after the further 14 ... ♖b8 15 ♘1d2 b5 16 cb ♖xb6 17 ♘c4 ♖c6 18 ♘ba5 ♖c7 19 ♘d6+ ♔f8 20 ♖ac1 Black might well feel tempted to resign, White has such a bind on the position. **13 ♕xd3 b6** The only the way to try to escape the bind. **14 cb ♕xb6 15 ♘1d2! d5** Usually the desirable freeing move, here it only blocks Black's bishop but he cannot allow the penetration of the white knight via c4 to d6. **16 e5! ♗d7 17 ♖fc1 0-0 18 ♕d4!** White now has seven (!) distinct positional advantages: (1) control of d5; (2) control of c5; (3) more space; (4) a queenside pawn majority; (5) he is the first to occupy the open c-file; (6) Black's bishop is bad; (7) Black must avoid the exchange of queens since the bad bishop v. good knight ending would be hopeless. As compensation for all this, Black has some vague hopes of a queenside counter-attack. **18 ... ♕b8 19 ♘f3 ♘c6 20 ♕e3 ♖c8 21 ♖c5 a5 22 ♖ac1 a4 23 ♘bd4** *(66)*


66
B

White has the luxury, at least in theory, of winning this position in three different ways: (1) by advancing his queenside pawn majority; (2) by exploiting a good knight v. bad bishop ending; (3) by using his space advantage to switch pieces to attack the kingside faster than Black can defend. In practice there are objections to the first two plans: (1) would be very difficult – marching into the teeth of Black's massed ranks. (2) is also difficult to achieve – if Black has any sense he will avoid all unnecessary piece exchanges, so White chooses (3). **23 ... ♘a5** 23 ... ♕xb2 loses a piece to 24 ♘xc6. **24 ♖xc8+ ♗xc8 25 b3 ♗d7 26 h4! h6 27 g4 ♕b7 28 h5 ♘c6** The exchange of rooks by 28 ... ♖c8 would do little to stop White's attack and a lot to bring an ending still closer. **29 g5 ♘xd4** So maybe losing an ending is better than getting mated! **30 ♘xd4 hg 31 ♕xg5 ♔h7** To prevent 32 h6 g6 33 ♕f6 ♔f8 34 h7! **32 ♖c3** Now the attack cannot be thwarted; the immediate threat 33 h6. **32 ... ♕b4 33 ♖g3 ♖g8 34 ♘f3 ab 35 ab ♕xb3 36 ♕c1** Threatening 37 ♘g5+,

winning the queen, and slowing Black's "counterplay" to a standstill. **36 ... ♕a2 37 ♘g5+ ♔h8 38 ♘xf7+ ♔h7 39 ♕g5 ♕b1+ 40 ♔h2** and Black resigned. There is simply no way for him to prevent mate.

Conclusion

If White has the opportunity to play c5 with impunity, he should do so. Black should do his utmost to avoid this happening. If it does happen then Black *cannot* allow the pawn to remain there lest the bind be made complete by the advance of White's e-pawn to e5; Black must exchange his b-pawn for the c-pawn even though this will leave White with a great space advantage and a queenside pawn majority which will be a highly significant factor in any endgame.

The Golden Rules of the Maroczy Bind with ... e6

1) If Black remains passive, White's positional advantage must tell in the long run.

2) Black should try for ... d5 or, if cirumstances permit, ... f5.

3) Black should remember that ... b5 is usually a luxury.

4) If Black has not played ... d6, both sides should be alert to the possible reprecussions of c5, significantly increasing the bind.

5) White should think twice before playing f3 – will it *really* strengthen the centre or will it just create weaknesses?

6) Both sides should always be on the look-out for White's principal tactical threat: ♘d5.

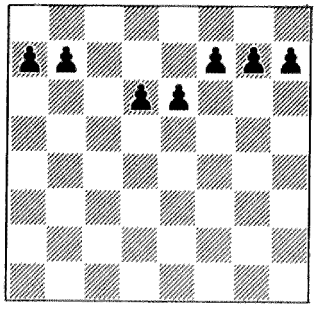
7) Black must not be too greedy; if he has achieved some freedom then he *must* reorganise his pieces before attempting any additional pawn break(s), otherwise, when the central pawn formation lifts, he may find himself on the wrong end of a mating attack.

3) Although the positional struggle is mainly one of manoeuvre, neither side, especially Black, should forget that *active*, not passive, manoeuvres are essential.

4 Little Centre

In many variations of the Sicilian Defence Black plays both ... e6 and ... d6 at an early stage of the game, thereby producing the pawn structure shown in the following diagram.

67



We shall call Black's adjacent d-pawn and e-pawn the little centre.

Before we enter into a deep discussion of little centre positions it would be as well to make some elementary observations. Black's pawn duo attacks four important squares, c5, d5, e5 and f5. The c5 square is the least crucial of the four though the queen's knight occasionally arrives there via d7 and it is always useful to have this knight supported by a pawn. The d5 square, as we have already mentioned, is probably the most important square on the board in the Sicilian Defence and the e6 pawn performs the dual functions of defending d5 against the invasion of a white piece and supporting d5 for the eventual advance of the d-pawn. e4 is another square that must be carefully guarded since if White's e-pawn is allowed to advance to e5 with impunity it often throws Black's defensive plans into disarray. Finally, f5 must be defended against the advance of White's f-pawn as well as the invasion of White's d4 knight.

The black e-pawn and d-pawn can thus be sen to perform defensive functions, though later in the game, if White has mishandled his kingside attack, it is not uncommon to see either or both of these pawns acting in a more aggressive capacity.

White's Basic Strategy

1) To take advantage of the greater space that he controls:
a) maybe he can set up a Maroczy Bind.
b) more likely he can aim for a kingside attack.
2) Guard against a freeing ... d5 by Black.
3) Consider the tactical repercussions of f5, ♗xe6, ♘xe6 and ♘d5.
4) Watch for the chance to disrupt Black's centre, most often achieved by e5 (or one of the ideas in 3 above).
5) Increase the central pressure:
a) on d5, to prevent the central counter ... d5.
b) especially on e6, if seeking a kingside attack with a bishop posted on the a2-g8 diagonal.

Black's Basic Strategy

1) To maintain his little centre; the pawns may be lusting to expand but they must be held in check until the right moment.
2) When the moment comes, free his game with ... d5 or, again under the right circumstances, ... e5.
3) Until the moment comes, keep up pressure in the centre, especially on White's e-pawn, after all, pressure on e4 involves implicit support for ... d5 and if the pressure is strong enough, White's energies may need to be devoted entirely to support for e4 with none left over for a kingside attack.
4) If nothing is happening in the centre, then look for active queenside counterplay.
5) Find the right time to castle; too soon and the king may walk into a mating net, too late and the black monarch may suffer the same fate, trapped in the centre.
6) Look for ways to relieve White's pressure:
a) consider exchanging off White's white square bishop if it has taken up an aggressive post (d3, c4, b3) but be sure to check that this will not waste too much time and that it will not strengthen White's pawn formation too much.
b) ... ♘xd4 may also relieve White's central pressure, especially in conjunction with ... ♗c6 and/or ... e5.
7) Be alert to the possibilities of White's disruptive and/or sacrificial moves: e5, f5, ♘xe6, ♗xe6, ♘d5.
3) Look to the endgame, which is more often than not favourable.

How each side should handle little centre positions depends largely on what sort of attacking plan White adopts. This, in turn, will often depend upon which system of development he chooses.

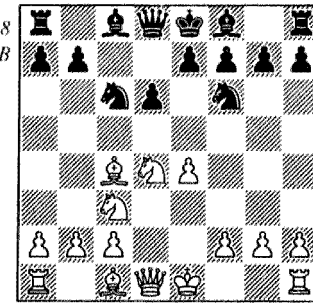
For the sake of convenience we shall split our discussion of little centre positions into four, according to whether White develops his king's bishop on c4 (and then b3), d3, e2 or g2. In this chapter we shall generally refrain from dealing with variations in which White plays ♗g5 since these inevitably arise after the move ... d6 and are therefore examined in Chapter 9. In most of the positions considered in this chapter White's queen's bishop is developed to e3.

White's King's Bishop Goes to c4 (and then b3)

One of the many contributions to opening theory made by Bobby Fischer was the popularisation of the move ♗c4 against two different defensive systems. Before Fischer became a top class player it was thought that the move ♗c4 put White's king's bishop on a rather feeble diagonal, since Black can blunt its power at once by means of the move ... e6, but Fischer's games and analyses showed that there were many hidden attacking resources in White's position and today, thirty years after Fischer gave his support to ♗c4, the move is still regarded as a serious attacking weapon.

Let us first look at the most crude and fundamental point behind the move ♗c4. 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 *(68)*

68
B



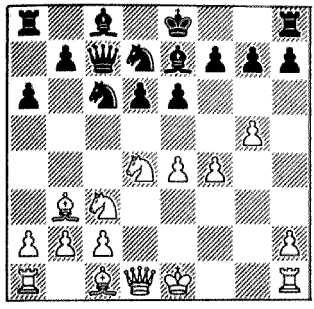
If Black now plays carelessly he can lose in three moves, e.g. 6 ... a6 (or 6 ... g6) 7 ♘xc6 bc 8 e5 de?? 9 ♗xf7+ winning Black's queen. Of course, 8 ... de is by no means compulsory but any move of the knight will leave White with a big lead in development and a space advantage in the centre.

Having seen this rather drastic example of the vulnerability of the f7 square, the reader will not be surprised to learn that the move ♗c4 is nearly always met by ... e6. We shall now consider the strategies for each side when White's king's bishop is on the a2-g8 diagonal and Black has played ... e6.

Let us first take a look at a sacrificial idea that often occurs when White has his king's bishop on b3 (diagram 69).

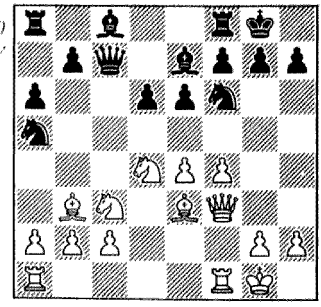
Black has made the mistake of developing his queen at the wrong moment. Had he castled instead,

69
W



Stein-Chistiakov
USSR Team Ch 1960

70
W



Heuer-Pasman
Latvian Ch 1961

the following sacrifices would not be possible. **11 ♗xe6!** White gets three pawns for the bishop and Black's king is exposed to the wrath of White's attacking forces. **11 ... fe 12 ♘xe6 ♕a5 13 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 14 ♘e6+ ♔g8 15 ♕h5 ♘f8 16 ♘xf8** In general exchanges help to take the pressure off the defending player but here Black's king becomes more exposed with each exchange. **16 ... ♗xf8 17 ♗d2 ♗e6 18 ♘d5 ♗xd5 19 ♗xa5 ♗f7 20 ♕g4 ♘xa5 21 0-0-0 ♖e8 22 ♖he1 ♘c6 23 h4 ♗e6 24 ♕g3 ♗f7 25 ♕g4 ♗e6 26 ♕f3** Now 26 ... ♗f7 can be met by 27 h5. **26 ... ♖c8 27 a3 h5 28 ♕g3 ♘a5 29 ♔b1 ♗g4 30 ♖d5 ♘c4 31 f5 ♖h7 32 g6 ♖hc7 33 f6 ♗h6 34 ♖xd6 ♘d2+ 35 ♖xd2 ♗xd2 36 ♖f1 ♖xc2 37 ♕b3+ ♔h8 38 ♕f7 ♖2c7 39 g7+** 1-0

Diagram 70: here we see another danger that should be avoided by players of Black. It looks very tempting to exchange off White's b3 bishop but in executing this plan Black sometimes wastes valuable time while White is attacking on the other side of the board. **12 f5** The thematic idea behind ♗c4 – White increases his pressure on e6. **12 ... ♘xb3 13 cb ♕a5 14 g4 e5 15 ♘de2 d5** Black sacrifices a pawn in an attempt to free himself. Against other moves White would continue g5 followed by ♘d5 and f6 with a winning attack. **16 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 17 ed ♖d8 18 ♘c3 ♗d7 19 f6 gf 20 d6 ♗xd6 21 ♕xf6 ♗e6 22 ♗h6 ♕c5+ 23 ♖f2 ♗f8 24 ♕g5+ ♔h8 25 ♘e4 ♗xh6** Otherwise 26 ♘f6 forces a quick mate. **26 ♕f6+ ♗g7 27 ♕xd8+ ♖xd8 28 ♘xc5 ♗xg4 29 ♖xf7 ♗h6 30 ♖e1 ♗f4 31 ♘e4 ♗h5 32 ♖xb7 ♖g8+ 33 ♔f2 ♖f8 34 ♔g2 ♖g8+ 35 ♘g3 ♗g4 36 ♖e7 h5 37 ♖1xe5 ♗xe5 38 ♖xe5 h4 39 ♘e4 ♖c8 40 ♘c3 ♖d8 41 ♘d5 ♗c8 42 ♔f2 ♔g7** and Black

resigned. The ending is hopeless.

The correct way for Black to treat variations of this type is to adopt an accurate move order in the opening so that White's centre is kept under constant pressure and it proves impossible for White to launch an early attack. The following game is an excellent illustration of this theme.

R.Byrne-Fischer
Sousse Interzonal 1967

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 The first essential – blunting the power of White's c4 bishop. **7 ♗b3 b5** Already White's centre is under pressure because of the threat of ... b4 at an opportune moment, winning the e-pawn. **8 f4 ♗b7** Black can grab the e-pawn by 8 ... b4 9 ♘a4 ♘xe4 but after 10 0-0 White has quite a lot of play for the pawn and a big lead in development. **9 f5** Putting pressure on e6. If now 9 ... b4 then 10 fe bc 11 ef+ gives White a devastating attack for the piece. It is always advisable to watch out for sacrificial possibilities that strand Black's king in the centre, since if White is well developed he will usually be able to unleash a decisive attack against the enemy monarch. **9 ... e5** At first sight it appears that White has succeeded in increasing the power of his b3 bishop but there is nothing much for this bishop to do since Black has d5 well under control. **10 ♘de2 ♘bd7** Once again Black could grab the e-pawn but to do so would give White a dangerous initiative: 10 ... ♘xe4 11 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 12 0-0 followed by ♘g3 and ♘h5. **11 ♗g5** Since White is obviously not going to be able to launch an attack with his pawns on the kingside, he follows a plan designed to take advantage of the "hole" on d5. The idea is to exchange off both of Black's knights, one of them for White's bishop and the other for the knight which travels from e2 via g3 to h5. When this task has been accomplished Black will be left with a bad dark-squared bishop and a hole at d5 which will be ripe for occupation by one of White's minor pieces. **11 ... ♗e7 12 ♘g3 ♖c8** Keeping up the pressure in the centre by introducing the possibility of ... ♖xc3 followed by ... ♘xe4, when Black will have ample compensation of the exchange. **13 0-0?** A natural looking move but a mistake. Also incorrect is 13 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 14 ♘h5 (all part of White's plan) because of 14 ... ♖xc3! 15 bc ♘xe4, when Black has a tremendous game for the exchange and 16 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 17 ♕h5 ♔xg7 18 ♕xf7+ ♔h6 leaves White facing the threat of 19 ...

♘g5, trapping his queen. White should play 13 h4 at once, with roughly equal chances. **13 ... h5!** This move is possible only because Black was very careful about the order of his moves and did not castle too soon. Knowing when to castle is very important and it is not something that is easily taught. The best axiom that we can suggest to the reader is: castle because you want to, not because you can. This rule applies throughout chess and not only in the Sicilian Defence. Now Black threatens 14 ... h4, winning the e-pawn. **14 h4 b4 15 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 16 ♘d5 ♗xh4 17 ♘xh5 ♕g5 18 f6 g6!** Incarcerating White's knight, but if 18 ... ♕xh5? 19 fg or if 18 ... ♖xh5? 19 ♖f5. **19 ♘g7+ ♔d8 20 ♖f3 ♗g3 21 ♕d3 ♗h2+ 22 ♔f1 ♘c5 23 ♖h3 ♖h4 24 ♕f3 ♘xb3 25 ab ♖xh3 26 ♕xh3 ♗xd5 27 ed ♕xf6+ 28 ♔e1 ♕f4** 1-0. A model display by Fischer of how to refute the Fischer Variation. White was always tied to the defence of his e-pawn and could never mount a serious offensive on the kingside.

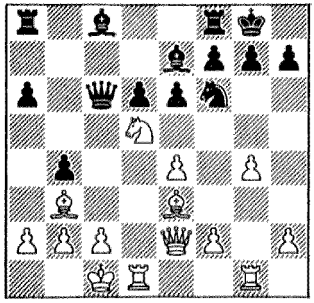
So far all the examples that we have examined in this chapter stem from the Najdorf Variation of the Sicilian. If Black plays ... ♘c6 before ... a6 we reach a different type of position. The following game illustrates the most important features of the variation.

Ostapenko-Zhartsev
USSR 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 Fischer used to favour 7 ♗b3 ♗e7 8 ♗e3 0-0 9 0-0 (9 f4 is premature and should be met by 9 ... ♘xd4 10 ♗xd4 b5!) but in the fourth game of his match with Spassky he discovered that Black has adequate counterplay: 9 ... a6 10 f4 ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 b5 12 a3 (necessary, to prevent ... b4) 12 ... ♗b7 13 ♕d3 a5. Black threatens ... b4 and if White plays 14 e5 de 15 de ♘d7 16 ♘xb5, as in the Fischer-Spassky game, Black has excellent compensation for the pawn after 16 ... ♘c5 17 ♗xc5 ♗xc5+ 18 ♔h1 ♕g5. Because of the idea of ... ♘xd4 in conjunction with ... a6 and ... b5, the system with kingside castling for White has virtually disappeared from master chess since 1972. **7 ... ♗e7 8 ♕e2** An aggressive system of development pioneered by the Yugoslav grandmaster Velimirović. White castles queenside and then attacks along the kingside files. **8 ... 0-0 9 0-0-0 a6** Now that White's king is committed to the queenside Black commences his queenside counterplay at once. **10 ♗b3** This move will be necessary sooner or later because of ... ♕c7, ... b5, ... d5 or the threat of ... ♘xe4; ♘xe4 d5. By

playing ♗b3 at once White encourages his opponent to commit himself. **10 ... ♕c7 11 ♖hg1** A natural attacking move. White's plan is quite crude but rather dangerous: g4-g5 driving back the f6 knight, then ♖g3, ♕h5, ♖h3 and mate at h7. The immediate 11 g4 is also quite playable with the same plan in mind. **11 ... b5 12 g4 b4?!** The move 12 ... ♘d7, intending to reinforce the queenside counterattack by ... ♘c5, has been played with success in similar positions. Here, however, it allows one of the many tactical resources that abound in this sharp variation: (12 ... ♘d7?) 13 ♘d5! ed 14 ♘xc6 and if 14 ... ♕xc6 15 ♗xd5 wins the exchange; or 14 ... ♘e5 15 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 16 ♗xd5 and White is a pawn ahead with the better game. *Always beware of the sacrifice* ♘d5.

Best is 12 ... ♘a5 13 g5 ♘xb3+ 14 ab ♘d7, with chances for both sides. **13 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 14 ♘d5!** *(71)*



71 B

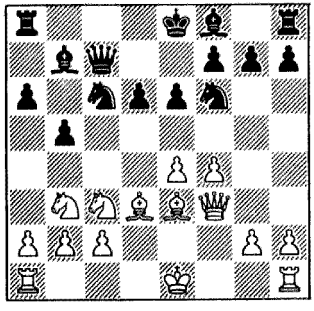
The thematic sacrifice mentioned in the note to move 12. **14 ... ed 15 g5** With the idea that if the knight moves 16 ♗xd5 will pick up the black queen's rook. **15 ... de 16 gf ♗xf6 17 ♗d5! ♕a4 18 ♕h5!** 18 ♗xa8 ♗e6 19 ♗d4 is the logical culmination of White's sacrifice, winning the exchange and eventually the game. The text move illustrates White's attacking possibilities on the kingside and leads to a far more spectacular finish. **18 ... ♗e6 19 ♖xg7+!! ♗xg7 20 ♖g1 ♖fc8** Hoping to escape with his king via f8. **21 ♖xg7+! ♔xg7 22 ♕h6+ ♔g8 23 ♗xe4** Preventing mate at c2 and threatening mate in three. **23 ... b3 24 ♗xh7+ ♔h8 25 ♗f5+ ♔g8 26 ♕h7+ ♔f8 27 ♗h6+ ♔e8 28 ♕g8+ ♔e7 29 ♗g5+ ♔d7 30 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 31 ♗xe6 ♔b6 32 ♗e3+ ♔a5 33 ♗xc8 ♖xc8 34 ♕f5+ ♖c5 35 ♗xc5 ♕b5 36 ♗b4+ ♔xb4 37 a3+ ♔c4 38 ♕xb5+ ab 39 cb+ ♔d3 40 ♔d1** 1-0.

Conclusion

Positions in which White's king's bishop goes to the a2-g8 diagonal lead to very lively play in which accuracy is at a premium. Black must keep up the pressure (direct or indirect) on White's e-pawn during the opening so that White will not have sufficient freedom to mount a decisive kingside attack.

White's King's Bishop Goes to d3

The aggressive nature of White's d3 bishop can be readily appreciated by examining the following typical position.



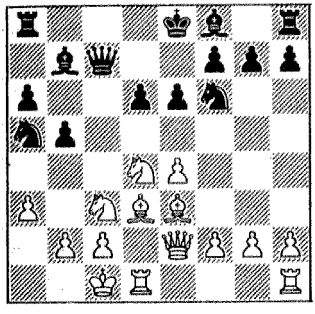
Fischer-Soos
Skopje 1967

White's attacking plan is plain to see – he will advance his g-pawn to g5 and then continue his kingside attack with f5 in conjunction with ♕h5 and/or ♖hg1 as appropriate. Meanwhile his own king will be safe on the queenside. The bishop on d3 supports the advance f5 and casts an eye on the potential mating square h7.

The game continued: **11 g4 ♗e7 12 0-0-0 ♘b4?** A natural-looking move but a mistake. Although Black will succeed in exchanging off White's d3 bishop he does so at the cost of strengthening White's centre. Also, it sometimes happens that after the manoeuvre ... ♘b4 (or e5) and ... ♘xd3, White can himself make use of the c-file by means of ♔b1 and ♖c1. **13 g5 ♘d7 14 ♔b1 ♖c8 15 a3** This move is not played with the idea of forcing the exchange of Black's knight for White's d3 bishop but to prevent Black from following up with ... b4. **15 ... ♘xd3 16 cd ♘c5** With White's attack so far advanced it would obviously be fatal for Black to castle kingside. **17 ♘d4 ♗a8 18 f5 e5 19 ♘de2 ♗d8** So that f6 can be met by ... g6, congealing White's kingside attack. **20 ♖hg1 ♕b8 21 g6** A common type of breakthrough move – Black cannot avoid opening up lines on the kingside. **21 ... hg 22 fg ♖c7 23 d4!** Another reason why the exchange on d3 helps White: d4 is even stronger now than it was at move 3. **23 ... ed 24 ♖xd4 ♖d7 25 ♘d5 ♘e6 26 ♖d2 fg 27 ♖xg6 ♘f8 28 ♖g4 ♖f7 29 ♕g2 ♕b7 30 ♗g5** With Black's king so exposed the exchange of minor pieces only adds to his problems by reducing the number of pieces available for his defence. This type of situation is the principal counter-example to the axiom that exchanges usually help the defending side. **30 ... ♗xg5 31 ♖xg5 ♖h6 32 ♘d4 ♘e6 33 ♘xe6 ♖xe6 34 ♕g4 ♖h6 35 ♖c2** At last White is able to make use of the c-file which was so kindly opened by Black more than

twenty moves ago. **35 ... ♔d8 36 ♖f5 ♖xf5 37 ♕xf5 ♖h8 38 ♕g5+ ♔e8 39 ♖c8+** 1-0.

If ... d5 is mistimed, it may merely leave the black king wandering in the wilderness.

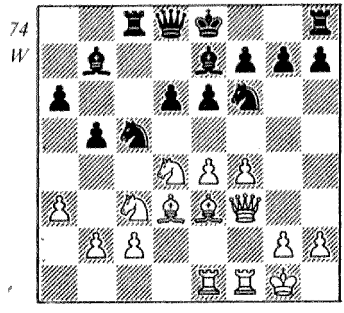


73
W

Nunn-Sosonko
Thessaloniki Olympiad 1984

12 g4 d5?! 12 ... ♗e7 is probably better. **13 ed ♘xd5 14 ♘dxb5!** A good example of this typical Sicilian sacrifice. **14 ... ab?** Black would have done better with either 14 ... ♕b8 or 14 ... ♕e5. **15 ♗xb5+ ♔d8** 15 ... ♗c6 fails to 16 ♘xd5 ed 17 ♗b6+ ♕e7 18 ♗xa5 ♕xe2 19 ♗xc6+ ♔e7 20 ♖he1. **16 ♘xd5 ed** After 16 ... ♗xd5 17 ♖xd5+ ed 18 ♖d1 wins. **17 ♖d3 ♘c4 18 ♖c3 ♗b4 19 ♖xc4 dc 20 ♖d1+ ♔c8 21 ♖d4! ♗d5** Or 21 ... ♔b8 22 ♗f4 while 21 ... ♕e7 fails to 22 ♖xc4+ ♔b8 23 ♖xb4. **22 ♖xd5 ♗d6 23 ♖d4** 1-0.

It is naturally much easier for White to rush his kingside pawns up the board if his king is safely tucked away on the queenside, but it is not entirely out of the question for White to be able to launch a kingside attack after he has just put his own king on the kingside.



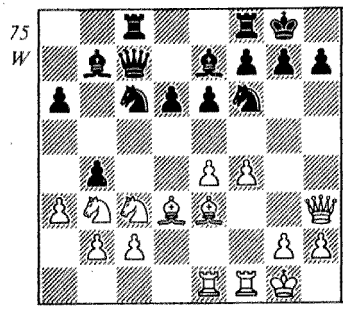
74
W

Smyslov-Tan
Hastings 1962-3

13 g4 The critical point in the opening. White threatens 14 g5 ♘fd7 15 f5! and if 15 ... ♗xg5 16 fe or if 15 ... ♘e5 16 ♕g3 with the threat of fe. **13 ... g6!** Reinforcing Black's defences. Were White's king on the other flank the text move would invite h4-h5, but since every kingside pawn move further exposes the white king it is possible for Black to take certain liberties. **14 g5 ♘fd7 15 ♕g3** 15 f5 could be met by 15 ... gf since the white e-pawn is pinned. But now f5 cannot be prevented and so Black takes the initiative. **15 ... e5 16 ♘f3 0-0 17 f5 ♖e8** Creating a retreat square for the bishop. **18 ♘h4 d5!** The logical reaction to

White's flank attack – Black opens up the centre in order to try to take advantage of the exposed position of White's king. **19 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 20 ed ♘xd3 21 cd ♘c5 22 ♕f3 ♖f8 23 f6 ♗d6 24 d4 ♘d3 25 ♖e2 ♖e8** Now that the f-file has been sealed it is quite safe for this rook to leave f8. **26 ♗d2 ♘xb2 27 de ♖xe5 28 ♖xe5 ♗xe5** Black has regained the sacrificed pawn and emerged with a clear advantage. His pieces are more active than White's, his king is much safer than White's and his pawns are not so vulnerable to attack.

Another attacking idea involves the sacrifice of White's c3 knight on d5. We have mentioned this sacrifice more than once before in different types of position. Here the manoeuvre has the added point that after ed; ed, White's d3 bishop will be bearing directly on h7.



75
W

Kupreichik-Tal
Sochi 1970

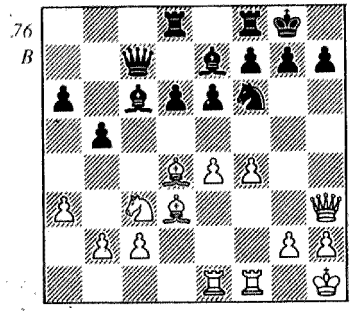
We have seen that if Black manoeuvres his c6 knight to b4 (or e5) and then exchanges it for White's d3 bishop, the resulting positions tend to favour White. Here, however, if White were to play 16 ab ♘xb4, Black *would* be able to gain the upper hand by exchanging on d3 because he will later be able to put one of his major pieces on the b-file with the important difference that White's b3 knight would come under immediate attack and if it were to move then the b-pawn would be vulnerable.

Since White cannot afford to play 16 ab he is virtually forced to sacrifice his knight on d5, but that was all part of his attacking plan. **16 ♘d5 ed 17 ed** White's d3 bishop is now staring at h7. **17 ... ♘b8 18 ♗d4** Threatening simply 19 ♗xf6 and 19 ♕xh7 mate. **18 ... g6** Forced, since 18 ... h6 loses to 19 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 20 ♕f5 etc. But now Black has dark square weaknesses all around his king and he must defend against the threat of ♕h6 in conjunction with bringing a rook to h3 via e3 or f3. His defensive task is made all the more difficult by the barrier of pieces on the d-file which hinder Black's queenside pieces from coming to the aid of his king. **19 ♖f3?** 19 ♖e3! is correct, so that 19 ... ♗xd5 can be met by 20 ♕h4. **19 ... ♗xd5 20**

♖fe3 ♗d8 Now Black's army is completely split in two. **21 ♕h4** Black was threatening ... ♘c6 which would drive away White's powerful d4 bishop, but now Black must come to the defence of his king's knight. **21 ... ♘bd7 22 ♕h6 ♕b7 23 ♖g3 ♘c5?** The point of Black's previous move was that he intended 23 ... ♗b6, exchanging off one of White's active pieces, but when he reached this position Tal had a hallucination and thought that 23 ... ♗b6 lost to 24 ♖e7 ♗xb3 25 ♗xg6 ♗xd4+ 26 ♔h1 ♔h8 27 ♗xf7. Now, however, Black can play 27 ... ♘g4! 28 ♗g6 ♘f2+ drawing. **24 ♘xc5 bc 25 f5! cd 26 fg fg 27 ♗xg6 ♔h8 28 ♕xf8+ ♘g8 29 ♗f5 ♖b8 30 ♖e8 ♕f7 31 ♖h3!** 1-0.

These four examples show that when White develops his king's bishop on d3 his basic idea is simply to play for mate. If White fails to achieve this aim he will usually have compromised his position to such an extent that he will quickly fall prey to Black's counter-attack.

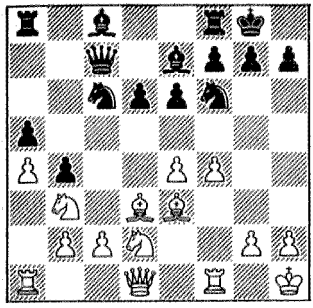
Black's handling of these positions is somewhat more subtle. He must avoid weakening his kingside pawns unnecessarily but he must be prepared to play ... g6 at the right time. He must try to provoke the move a3 by White so that his ... b4 will have added force to it but he must not play ... ♘b4 (or e5) followed by ... ♘xd3 unless he has already exchanged White's a-pawn for his own b-pawn. Most important of all, and this point was made in the Smyslov-Tan game, Black should look for opportunities to play ... e5 in order to neutralise the white bishop on d3. Here are two more examples of that theme which show how quickly White's attack can be stopped dead by a timely ... e5.



Novopashin-Korchnoi
USSR 1962

White threatens e5, driving the black knight from its defence of h7, so now the time is ripe for **16 ... e5! 17 fe de 18 ♘d5 ♗xd5 19 ♗xe5 ♕xe5 20 ed ♕xb2 21 ♖xf6** If 21 ♖xe7 g6 22 ♕h4 ♔g7, threatening 23 ... ♘xd5, but not 22 ... ♘xd5 (with the king still on g8) because of 23 ♖exf7 ♖xf7 24 ♕d8+ **21 ... g6** Black has repulsed the attack and the chances are equal.

77
B



F.Olafsson-Stein
Moscow 1971

15 ... e5 16 f5 d5 With two quick blows at White's centre Black has snatched the initiative. **17 ♕f3 ♖d8 18 ♕g3?!** White should have consolidated with ♖ae1 before continuing with the attack. **18 ... ♔h8 19 ♖ae1 ♗a6!** Threatening ... de. **20 ♗xa6 ♖xa6 21 ♗g5 ♘h5** This decentralising move is a standard resource in positions in which White has played ♕g3. On h5 the knight defends g7 and attacks the white queen, giving Black sufficient dynamic possibilities to outweigh the apparent misplacement of the knight. **22 ♕d3 ♖aa8 23 ♗xe7 ♘xe7 24 ed ♖xd5 25 ♕e2 ♘f6 26 ♘c4 ♘c6** Black has the more active game and White's kingside attack is over (or rather it never really got moving).

Conclusion

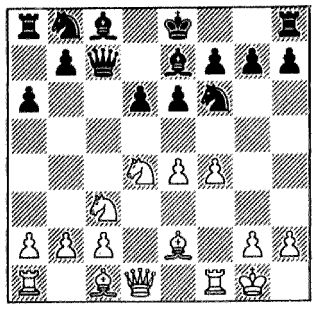
If White is allowed to increase the scope of his d3 bishop by a timely e5 he will probably be able to launch a decisive attack based on his pressure against h7. Black should therefore play ... e5 at an opportune moment, restraining the white bishop. Black should not play ... ♘b4 (e5) and ... ♘xd3 unless the b-file has been half-opened for an attack on White's b-pawn.

White's King's Bishop Goes to e2

e2 is the most flexible square for White's king's bishop in the Sicilian Defence because from e2 it casts its influence over both flanks. Later in the game it can move to d3 or even c4 in order to take part in the type of attack that has been discussed earlier in this chapter. Or it may be required on f3, to put pressure on the long diagonal and in particular to inhibit the advance ... d5. One major disadvantage of having his bishop on e2 is that White will not be able to bring his queen to the kingside so easily (or so quickly) as he does when the bishop is on b3, or d3. In each of those systems of development the white queen often moves to f3 at an early stage, in order to make way for queenside castling, or it is ready to advance to h5 once Black's king's knight has been driven away by g4-g5. Here, with the bishop on e2, White's queen

can only reach the kingside by ♕e1 (after 0-0) and ♕g3. Since this process takes one move longer than either ♕f3 or ♕h5, and since White's king's bishop is less aggressively placed on e2 than on d3 or b3, it follows that when White develops his king's bishop on e2 the game often takes on a more positional character.

Before we investigate what *usually* happens when White's king's bishop is played to e2, let us first examine ♗e2 in conjunction with a kingside pawn storm.



78
W

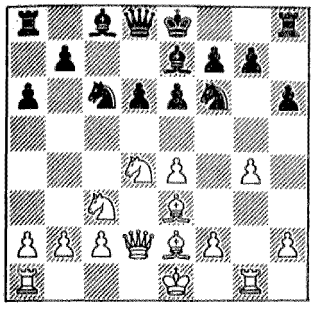
Kholmov-Spassky
USSR 1964

9 ♗e3 9 g4 at once is also possible, and if 9 ... d5 (the natural response) 10 ed ♘xd5 11 ♘e4 or 11 ♘xd5 ed 12 c3. In each case White has a slight advantage. **9 ... 0-0 10 g4 ♘c6** Again 10 ... d5 is note quite playable, this time because of 11 ed ♘xd5 12 ♘xd5 ed 13 ♗f3 ♖d8 14 ♕d2, with pressure against Black's isolated d-pawn. **11 g5 ♘d7 12 f5 ♘de5 13 f6 ♗d8 14 fg ♖e8** It is normal in such positions for Black to avoid recapturing the pawn if at all possible. The reason is that on g7 White's pawn offers a certain amount of protection to the black king and it is not going to escape eventual capture, so Black might as well use the move to better effect than making an unncecessary recapture. **15 ♕d2 b5 16 ♗h5 ♘e7** If 16 ... ♘c4 17 ♕f2 and Black cannot play 17 ... ♘xe3 because of the threat to his f-pawn. **17 b3!** The soundest move, depriving Black of any counterplay based on the occupation of the c4 square. An interesting alternative was the sacrifice of a knight for three pawns on b5: 17 ♘dxb5 ab 18 ♘xb5 ♕c6 19 ♘xd6, but then comes 19 ... ♗b7 and after White captures the exchange he must face a dangerous counter-attack. After the text move White has the more active game.

In contrast to the previous example let us now look at the position in which Black has already played ... ♘c6 when White advances g4 (diagram 79).

10 ... ♘xd4! This exchange, in conjunction with ... e5, relieves all the pressure on Black's position and enables him to complete his development in a satisfactory manner. **11 ♕xd4 e5 12 ♕d2 ♗e6 13**

79
B

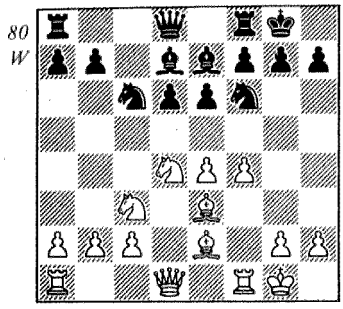


Karpov-Timman
Mar del Plata 1982

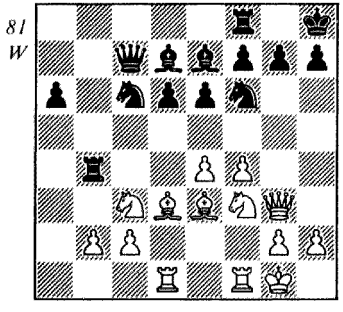
♗f3 ♘d7! 14 ♘d5 ♗g5 15 0-0-0 ♖c8 16 ♔b1 ♗xd5 17 ed Unfortunately for White 17 ♕xd5 ♗xe3 18 fe ♖c6 is good for Black. **17 ... ♘c5 18 ♖h1 ♕f6 19 ♗g2 ♗xe3 20 fe ♕h4 21 ♗f3 0-0 22 ♕e1** 22 e4, to be followed by ♖dg1 and g5, would be more in keeping with the position. **22 ... ♕d8 23 e4 ♕b6 24 ♕e3 ♕b5 25 h4** Karpov suggested moving a rook to g1 followed by ♖g2 to combine defence of the queenside with kingside counterplay. **25 ... ♘a4 26 ♕b3 ♖c5** White's kingside pawn advance is finally under way, but Black has been able to switch all his pieces to the queenside with excellent counterplay. **27 ♖h3** 27 g5 does not seem to be any better: 27 ... ♖fc8 28 c3 ♕a5 29 ♗e2 and Black can choose between the thematic 29 ... h5 and the dashing 29 ... ♖xc3. **27 ... ♖fc8 28 c3 ♖8c7 29 ♔a1** This is weak, but there is nothing obviously better. **29 ... ♕d7! 30 ♗e2 b5 31 a3 a5 32 ♔b1 ♖b7 33 ♖g3 g6!** This completely halts White's kingside disturbance. **34 g5 h5 35 ♗f1 ♖cc7 36 ♕c2 b4 37 ab ab 38 c4 b3! 39 ♕g2 ♖b4 40 ♕h3 ♕xh3 41 ♖xh3 ♘c5 42 ♔c1** 42 ♖e3 ♖a4 43 ♔c1 ♖a2 (to be followed by ... ♖ca7) also wins easily. **42 ... ♘xe4 43 ♖e3 ♘c5 44 ♔d2 ♘a4 45 ♖c1 ♘xb2 46 c5 ♖d4+ 47 ♔e2 ♖xc5 48 ♖xc5 dc 49 ♖xb3 ♘c4 50 ♖c3 ♖xh4 51 ♔e1** 0-1.

The difference between these two examples is quite plain to see. When Black has his queen's knight on c6 he is much better prepared to cope with the advance of White's g-pawn. It is therefore important for Black to choose his move order with some care and the old rule of "knights before bishops" might be extended to "knights before other pieces".

We shall now take a look at what happens when White proceeds in a more sedate manner. Our examples all come from the Scheveningen Variation of the Sicilian, which is the most frequently occurring variation in which White plays ♗e2 against the little centre. The main line of the Scheveningen usually begins as follows: 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e6 6 ♗e2 ♘c6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 0-0 0-0 9 f4 ♗d7.



The position is typical of the little centre defending against white bishops on e2 and e3. White plans to attack on the kingside (beginning with ♕e1 and ♕g3) while at the same time keeping the centre under control. Black will react in the usual way, exerting pressure in the centre and creating counterplay on the queenside.

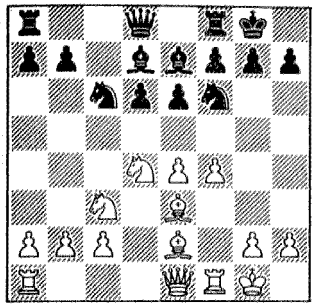


Gligorić-Ostojić
Yugoslav Championship 1965

Here we see what happens when Black fails to exert sufficient pressure on the centre (his efforts in this instance have been devoted entirely to his queenside counter-attack). White has been able to consolidate in the centre and regroup his pieces in preparation for a breakthrough on the kingside. He has even had time to move his e2 bishop to the more active post d3. **17 e5!** Driving Black's king's knight from its defence of h7 and at the same time opening up a line of attack for the d3 bishop. **17 ... de 18 fe ♘h5 19 ♕h3 g6 20 ♗h6 ♘f4 21 ♗xf4 ♖xf4 22 ♕h6 ♖g4 23 ♘e4** Once Black has been compelled to play ... g6 he must always be alert to the possibility of White's invading the hole at f6. Here, however, there is no satisfactory defence. **23 ... ♘xe5 24 ♘fg5 ♖xg5 25 ♘xg5 ♕c5+ 26 ♔h1 ♗xg5** This was not possible when Black's f8 rook was left undefended. **27 ♕xg5 ♘xd3** Black's hopes had been pinned on the variation 28 ♕xc5 ♘xc5 29 b4 ♗b5, but White has a simple intermediate move. **28 ♕f6+ ♔g8 29 ♖xd3 ♗b5 30 ♖c3 ♕d5 31 ♖e1 ♕d2 32 ♖g1 ♕d7 33 h4 h5 34 ♖e1 ♖c8 35 ♖xc8+ ♕xc8 36 ♖d1** 1-0.

The correct way for Black to react to White's ♕e1 is to exchange knights in the centre and then play ... ♗c6. This puts immediate pressure on White's e-pawn and thereby hinders White's aggressive plans on the kingside.

82
B



Zhdanov-Kapengut
USSR 1966

White has just played 10 ♕e1, preparing for ♕g3. **10 ... ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♗c6** Because of the threat to White's e-pawn Black has assumed the initiative. **12 ♕g3** Indirectly defending the e-pawn because of the mate at g7. **12 ... g6!** Now the e-pawn is again under attack. **13 ♗d3 ♘h5 14 ♕f2 ♘xf4 15 ♕xf4 e5 16 ♕f2** 16 ♗xe5 is met by 16 ... ♗g5 17 ♕g3 ♗h4 18 ♕f4 ♗g5, with a draw by repetition. **16 ... ed 17 ♕xd4 ♕a5 18 ♔h1** Black was threatening 18 ... d5! followed by ... ♗c5, winning the queen. **18 ... ♕e5** Black has now achieved full equality.

Let us return to the previous diagram and examine the position after **10 ... ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♗c6** White can defend his e-pawn in a more direct manner by **12 ♗d3** and this move adds weight to his kingside attack. But now White has no immediate threat along the g-file (compare the position after 12 ♕g3) and so Black has time for **12 ... ♘d7** preparing for ... e5. **13 ♖d1** 13 ♕g3 can also be met by 13 ... e5 and if 14 fe de with counterplay along the a7-g1 diagonal, e.g. 15 ♗e3 ♗c5, forcing the exchange of bishops, or 15 ♗xe5 ♘xe5 16 ♕xe5 ♕b6+ and 17 ... ♕xb2. In each case the chances are equal. **13 ... e5 14 fe de** Black may also recapture with the knight since a well posted knight on e5 normally compensates for an isolated d-pawn. **15 ♗f2 ♗c5** The same theme as in the note to White's 13th move. In many variations of the Sicilian White plays f4 in conjunction with kingside castling and he must always be on the lookout for ways that Black can use the a7-g1 diagonal. **16 ♗c4 ♕b6** One of the important tactical motifs based on the open a7-g1 diagonal – from b6 the black queen increases the pressure along the diagonal and attacks the white b-pawn. **17 ♗b3 ♘f6** The chances are equally balanced. White has some pressure against Black's kingside but Black has play along the a7-g1 diagonal and pressure on White's e-pawn.

These two examples should convince the reader that the development of White's king's bishop on e2 is not to be feared, provided that Black keeps up the pressure

on White's e-pawn and plays ... e5 at the correct moment.

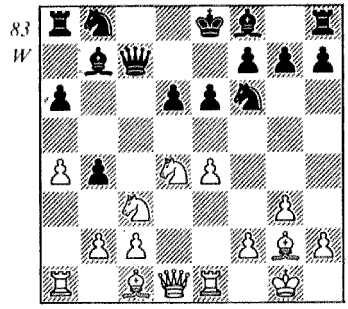
Conclusion

The less aggressive development of the king's bishop on e7 gives Black more flexibility than ♗c4 or ♗d3; he should keep up pressure in the centre by ... ♘xd4 followed by ... ♗c6 (pressure on e4) in conjunction with a later ... e5 (pressure on d4).

White's King's Bishop Goes to g2

In Chapter 7 (Closed Positions) we shall see how White can build up his kingside attack very slowly when the position is closed (i.e. when he has not played d4). In most of the positions discussed in Chapter 7 White plays his king's bishop to g2 and there is little doubt that the fianchetto of the king's bishop is White's best course since positions with ♗c4 and ♗b5 do not seem to cause Black serious difficulties. When the position has been opened up in the centre by White's d4 and the subsequent exchange of pawns, the situation is completely different. Then White tries to build his kingside attack more quickly and his king's bishop is at its most active on b3 or d3, while on c2 it assumes a flexible role and can later be moved to c4 or d3 if necessary. On g2, however, White's bishop does not have an important attacking role.

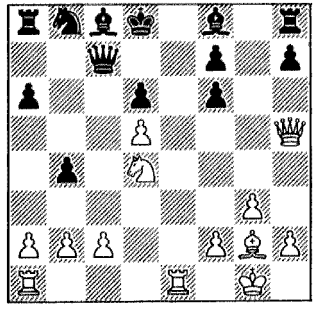
Various systems involving the fianchetto of White's king's bishop became popular around the late 1960s and early 1970s. This was largely due to the number of points scored by White as a result of one or two sacrificial ideas. So long as Black does not fall foul of either of these sacrifices he should have nothing to fear.



Quinones-Higashi
Siegen Olympiad 1970

11 ♘d5! The most ubiquitous sacrifice in the Sicilian Defence. Here the bishop on g2 assumes the role of protector, defending the white e-pawn as it progresses to d5. **11 ... ed** After 11 ... ♘xd5 12 ed e5 13 a5, White is well ahead in development and it will be only a matter of time before Black's b-pawn falls. **12 ed+ ♔d8 13 ♗g5** The move ♗g5 often forms an essential part of White's plans when he sacrifices his knight on

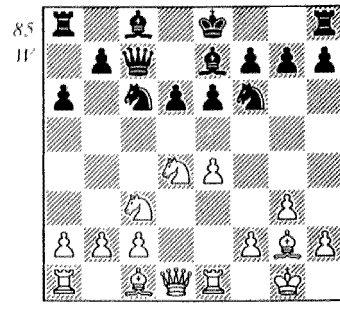
d5. The bishop pins the black knight and thereby increases the pressure on Black's position. The immediate threat is 14 ♕e2 and 15 ♕e8 mate. **13 ... ♗c8** If 13 ... ♗e7 14 ♘f5 ♖e8 15 ♘xg7 ♖g8 16 ♕d4, with complete control of the board. **14 ♗xf6+ gf 15 ♕h5** Preparing to double rooks.



15 ... ♖a7 16 ♖e4 ♗g7 17 ♖ae1 ♕c5 18 ♕e2 ♗d7 19 ♘b3 ♕b6 20 a5 ♕b5 21 ♕e3 ♖c7 If 21 ... ♕b7 22 ♕f4 ♕c7 23 ♖c4 when Black loses two more pawns at once. **22 ♕f4 ♖e8 23 ♕xd6 ♖xe4 24 ♖xe4 ♔c8 25 ♗f1 ♕a4 26 ♖xb4 ♕a2 27 ♘c5 ♕a1 28 ♖xb8+ ♔xb8 29 ♘xa6+** Black resigns.

The other sacrifice that Black must be careful to avoid is somewhat less spectacular but almost as dangerous. From diagram 85:

10 ♘xc6 In the Sicilian Defence one of the most important rules to remember is that White's d4 knight should not be exchanged on c6 if Black can recapture with

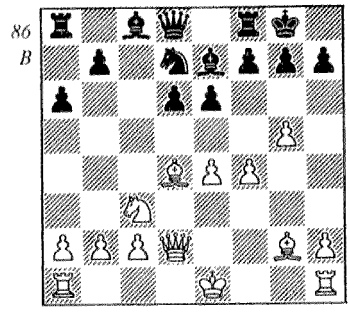


Browne-Langeweg
Amsterdam 1972

the b-pawn. The reason is that the recapture ... bc strengthens Black's centre and makes it virtually certain that he will be able to play ... d5 at will. The exception to this rule arises when White has some immediate method of taking the initiative so that Black cannot make any use of his newly acquired centre control. This is one such position. **10 ... bc 11 e5! de 12 ♖xe5!** The real point – if Black captures the rook he will soon be a pawn down for nothing. The result of the operation is that Black's queenside pawns are split and White has a pawn majority on that wing. Also, White has increased the scope of his fianchettoed bishop. **12 ... ♗b7 13 ♗f4 ♗d6 14 ♖xe6+!** Sacrificing the exchange for a pawn and strong pressure. **14 ... fe 15 ♗xd6 ♕d7 16 ♗c5!** Surprisingly White retains the upper hand even after the exchange

of queens. **16 ... ♕xd1+ 17 ♖xd1 ♖d8 18 ♖e1 ♔f7 19 ♘e4 ♘xe4 20 ♗xe4 ♖he8 21 ♖e3 ♖d7 22 ♖f3+ ♔g8 23 ♖b3 ♖ed8 24 ♖b6 ♖c7 25 ♗d3 ♖d5 26 b4 ♖xc5** If Black does nothing White will advance his a-pawn to a5 and then play ♗xa6. With two pawns for the exchange and a passed a-pawn which can be supported on a7 by the bishop, White would then have an easily won ending. **27 bc** White is a pawn up with a bind on the queenside. The opposite coloured bishops did not enable Black to save the game.

Sometimes White's king's bishop is developed at g2 in conjunction with a kingside pawn storm. This usually arises only when White has advanced his pawns at a very early stage of the game and then developed his king's bishop, and this theme is almost unique to the Keres Attack: 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 g4. White later advances his pawn to g5, possibly in conjunction with f4 and/or h4, and then plays ♗g2. We then see a position of the type shown in the following diagram.



Minić-Udović
Zagreb 1965

White has just played 12 ♗g2. **12 ... ♖e8 13 0-0-0** With his kingside pawns rushing up the board to attack, White must clearly put his king on the opposite wing. **13 ... ♘b6 14 ♕e2 ♕c7 15 ♖d3** White is playing for mate by ♖h3 and ♕h5 etc. **15 ... e5!** Slowing down White's attack, partly by creating play in the centre and partly by putting h3 under attack from the queen's bishop. **16 ♗xb6** The only way to keep the initiative. **16 ... ♕xb6 17 ♗h3 ef 18 ♗xc8** White must play this move in order to free his rook from its defence of the bishop and to allow the h-pawn to advance. But now Black has good counter-play on the queenside. **18 ... ♖axc8 19 h4 ♕a5 20 ♖f1 d5** Now 21 ... ♗b4 is a serious threat to the safety of White's king. **21 ♔b1 f6 22 g6** Not 22 gf? ♗xf6 when Black has too many threats. **22 ... hg 23 ♕g4 ♗f8 24 ♕xg6 ♕c7** Threatening to capture on e4, since White's knight is pinned. **25 ♖d2 ♕f7** Agreed Drawn. After 26 ♕xf7+ ♔xf7 27 ed b5 (or 27 ... ♗b4) the ending is a draw.

It should be apparent from this

example that White's g2 bishop has no real role to play in a kingside pawn storm. The point of advancing the kingside pawns is to conduct a direct attack on the black king culminating in mate on h7 (or some adjacent square). We have seen from some of the earlier examples that this strategy works best when White's king's bishop is on d3, or possibly b3, whereas on g2 the bishop has no active part to play in the attack and furthermore it obstructs the g-file along which White might wish to attack with one or more of his major pieces.

Conclusion

With his king's bishop in fianchetto, White's chances for mounting a kingside attack are rather remote and his extra pressure in the centre is not quite sufficient to compensate for this lack of attacking prospects. If Black is careful not to allow a successful sacrifice on his fourth rank, he can obtain a satisfactory game by following the general principles of the Sicilian.

The Golden Rules of Little Centre Positions

White's king's bishop goes to c4 and b3:

1) Think carefully about the order of moves in the opening as Black in order to keep up the maximum pressure on White's e-pawn.

2) Do not play ... ♘a5 and ... ♘xb3 automatically. It might be a good idea but it might also waste time and strengthen White's queenside.

3) Both sides should be alert to the possibilities of sacrifices on d5, e6 and c6.

White's king's bishop goes to d3:

4) Do not play ... ♘b4 (or e5) and ... ♘xd3 as Black unless the b-file has already been half opened by the exchange of Black's b-pawn for White's a-pawn (this usually happens after White has played a3 and Black has advanced ... b4).

5) Black should play to blunt the power of the d3 bishop by ... e5.

6) Both sides should be alert to the possibility of the sacrifice of White's knight on d5.

White's king's bishop goes to e2:

7) Black should play ... ♘xd4 followed by ♗c6 in order to put pressure on White's e-pawn.

8) Black should play for ... e5.

White's king's bishop goes to g2:

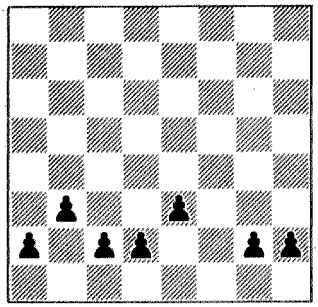
9) Both sides should be alert to the possibility of a sacrifice of White's knight on d5 and the idea of e5 by White (in conjunction with the follow-up sacrifice ... de; ♖xe5) in order to split Black's pawns.

10) When White launches a kingside pawn storm his king's bishop should be on a more active square than g2 from where it usually gets in the way of his attack.

5 Dragon Positions

Amongst the most popular variations of the Sicilian Defence are those in which Black carries out an early fianchetto of his king's bishop. The most frequently seen of these systems is the one beginning with the moves 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 g6, which because of the shape of Black's pawn structure, is called the Dragon Variation.

87



Other forms of the Dragon are the Accelerated Dragon (1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 g6), the Semi-Accelerated Dragon (1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 g6) and the Hyper-Accelerated Dragon (1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 g6).

Black's fianchettoed king's bishop serves a dual role in all of the Dragon systems. The fianchetto structure itself, together with the stationing of Black's king's knight on f6, provides a safe haven for the black king, in anticipation of White's traditional kingside attack. In addition, the bishop on g7 frequently assumes an offensive role, raging down the h8-a1 diagonal to plunder whatever is left in its path.

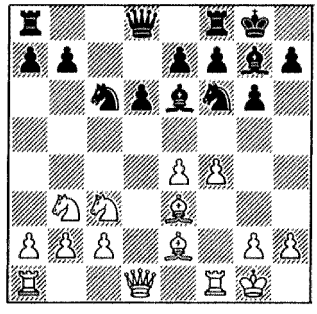
There are three entirely different strategies that White can adopt against Dragon formations. One of these, the Maroczy Bind, was discussed in Chapter 2, and the others, the Classical/Neo-Classical strategy and the Yugoslav Attack, are examined here.

The Classical/Neo-Classical Strategy

The principal difference between White's two main anti-Dragon strategies lies in the fact that in the Yugoslav Attack White will almost invariably castle queenside, aiming

for a quick knockout against Black's king, while in the more classical approach White usually castles kingside. The most popular variation in the classical Dragon provides an excellent illustration of the basic strategies for each player: 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 g6 6 ♗e3 ♗g7 7 ♗e2 ♘c6 8 0-0 0-0 9 ♘b3 ♗e6 10 f4

88
B



Both sides have completed their development. White has placed his bishops on the classical squares e2 and e3 from where they exert their influence on both flanks. White's f-pawn is ready to advance to f5, driving away Black's e6 bishop and paving the way for g4-g5 and an eventual f6, all of which will form part of White's attacking plan on the kingside. Whether or not this plan will be successful depends on how Black reacts on the queenside and in the centre.

White's Basic Strategy

a) To prevent Black from playing the freeing move ... d5;
b) To contain Black's queenside counterplay;
c) To anticipate the possibility of the exchange sacrifice on c3;
d) Ultimately, to launch a kingside attack.

Black's Basic Strategy

Try to create *immediate* counterplay, which means:
a) Always be on the lookout for an opportunity to play ... d5;
b) Play as actively as possible on the queenside;
c) Ultimately, to take over the initiative so that White will not be able to launch a kingside attack and then to press home the counterattack on the queenside.

Let us now take a look at two games in order to see the white and black strategies working to their optimum effect. In each case we shall start with the position shown in diagram 88.

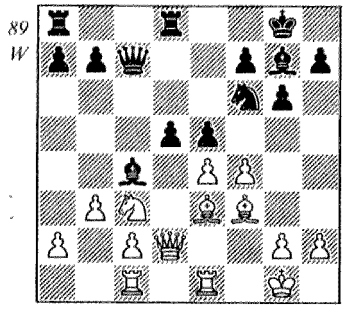
Estrin-Fridstein
Moscow 1945

10 ... ♘a5 11 f5 ♗c4 12 ♘xa5 ♗xe2 13 ♕xe2 ♕xa5 14 g4 The key to White's attacking plan. If the idea does not work Black's counterattack will be all the more virulent because of the exposed

situation of White's king. **14 ... ♕b4?** Too slow. Black must react quickly with 14 ... ♖ac8! intending to disrupt White's plan by means of a timely exchange sacrifice on c3. See diagram 93, p.73. **15 g5 ♘h5 16 a3 ♕xb2** Now that Black's queen has been lured away from its attack on White's e-pawn the white knight is free to join in the attack. **17 ♘d5 ♖ae8** If Black tries to defend the e-pawn with his queen (17 ... ♕e5) he may find his queen being trapped in mid board, e.g. 18 ♕d3 ♘g3 19 c3! threatening 20 ♗d4. **18 ♕f2! ♕e5** If Black grabs the two rooks for the queen he will get his bishop trapped by c3 **19 f6 ef 20 gf ♗h8 21 ♖ae1! ♖e6 22 ♗d4 ♕g5+ 23 ♔h1 ♖fe8 24 ♖g1 ♕h6 25 ♕h4** White has an overwhelming position.

Rauzer-Botvinnik
USSR Championship 1933

10 ... ♘a5 11 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 12 ♗f3 ♗c4 The best square for the queen's bishop. **13 ♖e1 ♖fd8 14 ♕d2 ♕c7** Otherwise White might be able to play ♘d5 in some positions, forcing the exchange of queens. **15 ♖ac1?** A passive move, after which Black's initiative becomes rather dangerous. **15 ... e5 16 b3** If this move is really necessary in the Classical Dragon it is a sign that things are not going well for White. The move weakens White's queenside and in particular it increases the scope of Black's "Dragon bishop". (Also, in this specific instance, it allows a very strong tactical stroke.) Correct was 16 fe de 17 ♕f2 with equal chances. **16 ... d5!!** *(89)*



17 ed e4! 18 bc ef 19 c5 ♕a5 20 ♖ed1? Correct is 20 ♕d3 ♘g4 21 ♘e4, when White has good chances of being able to hold the game, but in such positions it is usually more difficult for White to find the right continuation than it is for Black, simply because White's king is the more exposed and his pieces are the less active. **20 ... ♘g4! 21 ♗d4 f2+ 22 ♔f1** If 22 ♔h1 ♖xd5 23 ♘xd5 f1♕+. **22 ... ♕a6+ 23 ♕e2 ♗xd4 24 ♖xd4 ♕f6! 25 ♖cd1 ♕h4 26 ♕d3 ♖e8 27 ♖e4 f5 28 ♖e6 ♘xh2+ 29 ♔e2 ♕xf4** 0-1.

We shall now examine the main ideas for both sides in a typical classical Dragon position. The material is divided into:

Ideas for White

White consolidates in the centre. White plays for an immediate kingside attack.

Ideas for Black

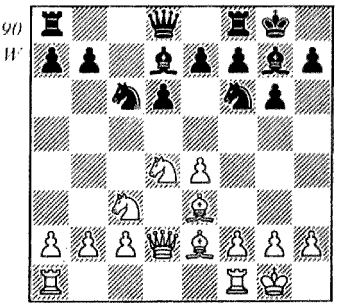
Black plays for an early ... d5.
Black creates piece play on the queenside and prepares the exchange sacrifice ... ♖xc3.
Black provokes a queenside weakness and then creates piece play.

We will first examine White's ideas to see what happens when they go unopposed. This will lead us to a grater appreciation of how important it is for Black to play actively.

Ideas for White

The soundness of the Sicilian Defence in general and the Dragon Variation (amongst others) in particular is very much linked to the success or failure of White's kingside attack. Sometimes White will launch an all-out attack against the black king at the first available opportunity, hoping that by the time Black's counterplay has got moving on the queenside (and/or in the centre) the result of the game will already have been determined on the kingside. This is all very well if Black's counterplay is mishandled or if, for some reason, Black has played passively during the early stages of the game, but a correctly handled counterattack can very often prove to be more dangerous than White's kingside attack because if the kingside attack fails to lead to mate or a decisive gain of material, White will have to rush back to the queenside to try to save himself from being annihilated on that half of the board. For this reason it is not uncommon for White to try to consolidate in the centre so that Black will not find it so easy to create counterplay, and only when Black's counterplay has been stifled will White turn his attention to the kingside and the possibilities of a mating attack.

White Consolidates in the Centre



Unzicker-Eliskases
Stockholm Interzonal 1952

10 f4 a6 11 ♖ad1 ♖c8 12 h3 A normal move, preventing the simplifying possibilities ... ♘g4 and ...

♗g4. **12 ... b5 13 a3 ♕c7 14 ♘b3 ♖fd8 15 ♗f3 ♗e8 16 ♕f2 ♖b8 17 ♘d5 ♘xd5 18 ed ♘a5 19 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 20 c3 ♕c7** The situation in the centre and on the queenside has crystallised with Black having no play in the centre but some queenside counterplay based on the advance of the a-pawn and b-pawn. Unzicker now decides that the time is right for a kingside attack but there have been too many exchanges for the attack to have a great chance of success. **21 ♗d4** An essential part of every anti-Dragon attack – White exchanges off the "Dragon bishop". **21 ... a5 22 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 23 ♖d4 ♕c5 24 ♖e1 ♖d7 25 ♕d2 ♖c7 26 ♔h1** The plan is to play f5 ♖h4 and then mate by ♕h6+ etc. **26 ... f6** Now f5 can be met by ... g5, and so **27 h4 ♗f7! 28 h5 gh 29 ♖e3 b4** Just in time. Against other moves f5 followed by ♖h4 would be too strong. **30 ab ab 31 cb ♕c1+ 32 ♕xc1 ♖xc1+ 33 ♔h2 ♖c7 34 ♗e2 ♖cb7 35 ♖b3 f5 36 ♔g3 ♔f6 37 ♔h4 ♖b6 38 ♗xh5 e5! 39 de ♗xe6 40 ♖bd3 ♖xb4 41 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 42 ♖xd6 ♖xf4+ 43 ♔g3 ♖b4 44 ♖d2 ♔g5 45 ♗f3** ½-½.

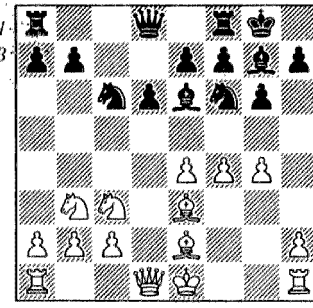
Black was able to keep the balance in this game by methodical preparation for the thrust ... b4. Remember, it is always useful when playing the black side of the Sicilian to encourage White to move his queenside pawns because once moved they become targets for Black's queenside counterplay.

Conclusion

Consolidation is too slow a policy to adopt in a variation as sharp as the Dragon. Black is not set enough problems and can proceed with his queenside play.

White Plays for an Immediate Kingside Attack

The Estrin-Fridstein game (p.67) is one example of a kingside attack being launched without any consolidating measures being taken in the centre. Here is a further example in which White's attack is initiated at an even earlier stage of the game. (For a pathetic illustration of an utterly premature attack see the example on p.7).



Fischer-Reshevsky
2nd Match Game 1961

10 .. d5?! It is true that the correct answer to an attack on the

flank is often a thrust in the centre, but in this particular position the complications favour White. Correct is 10 ... ♘a5. **11 f5 ♗c8 12 ed ♘b4 13 ♗f3!** One of the most famous Sicilians of all time, the game Alekhine-Botvinnik, Nottingham 1936, went 13 d6 ♕xd6 14 ♗c5 ♕f4 15 ♖f1 ♕xh2 16 ♗xb4 ♘xg4 17 ♗xg4 ♕g3+ 18 ♖f2 ♕g1+ 19 ♖f1 ♕g3+ with a draw. **13 ... gf 14 a3 fg 15 ♗g2 ♘a6 16 ♕d3! e6 17 0-0-0** With Black having absolutely no queenside counterplay it is quite safe for White to castle long in preparation for the mating attack on the other wing. **17 ... ♘xd5 18 h3 g3 19 ♖hg1 ♕d6 20 ♗xd5 ed 21 ♘xd5?** 21 ♗d4 is much stronger: 21 ... ♗xd4 22 ♖xg3+ ♗g7 23 ♖dg1 ♕h6+ 24 ♔b1 ♗e6 25 ♖xg7+ ♕xg7 26 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 27 ♕g3+ ♔h8 28 ♕e5+ and White is well on top. Analysis by Fischer. **21 ... ♔h8 22 ♗f4 ♕g6 23 ♕d2 ♗xh3 24 ♖xg3 ♗g4 25 ♖h1 ♖fe8 26 ♘e3 ♕e4?** A time trouble error. 26 ... f5 27 ♕h2 ♔g8 holds the balance. **27 ♕h2 ♗e6 28 ♖xg7** 28 ♘d2 leads to a quicker win. **28 ... ♔xg7 29 ♕h6+ ♔g8 30 ♖g1+ ♕g6 31 ♖xg6+ fg 32 ♘d4 ♖ad8 33 ♗e5 ♖d7 34 ♘xe6 ♖xe6 35 ♘g4 ♖f7 36 ♕g5 ♖f1+ 37 ♔d2 h5 38 ♕d8+** Black resigns.

Conclusion

If Black does not react quickly on the queenside, he will be swamped by White's kingside pawn storm.

Ideas for Black

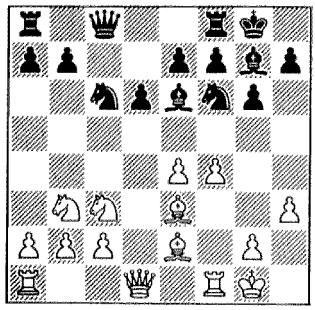
By now it should be apparent that Black must react quickly and accurately if he is to prevent White from building up a devastating kingside attack. Against the classical system of development he can do this in three ways, which one he chooses being largely a matter of taste.

Black Plays for an Early ... d5

This thematic move often makes it possible for Black to punish premature or inexact play by his oppponent. If White replies ed Black will either recapture at once with his f6 knight or play ... ♘b4 and then recapture on d5. If White advances e5 then Black will either retreat his knight to d7 or e8 and hit at White's e-pawn with an eventual ... f6, or he will jump into e4 with his knight.

A simple example of ... d5 in the Dragon was given in the introduction (see p.7) and the Rauzer-Botvinnik game showed us how Black can sometimes combine piece play on the queenside with ... d5 coming at a crucial moment in the middle game. Let us now examine a game in which Black aims for ... d5 right from the end of the opening.

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B



Rolland-Larsen
Le Havre 1966

11 ... ♖d8 Threatening ... d5. **12 ♗f3** The most effective way of delaying ... d5. If White ignores the threat and launches a kingside attack at once he quickly loses the initiative: 12 g4? d5 13 e5 ♘e4 14 ♘xe4 de 15 ♕e1 f6! and Black has the advantage. **12 ... ♗c4** Now that White has vacated the e2 square it would be premature to play 12 ... d5 because after 13 e5 ♘e4, White can play 14 ♘e2 followed by an eventual ♘ed4. **13 ♖f2 e5!** Again Black cannot quite play the immediate ... d5, this time because of 14 ed ♘xd5 15 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♗xd5 e6 17 ♖d2 ♖xd5 18 ♖xd5 ed 19 c3, followed by ♕f3 and ♖d8 with pressure against the isolated d-pawn. This variation, and the one in the previous note, show that Black should not play ... d5 blindly but should calculate its consequences with great care. When it is good it is very very good but when it is bad it is often quite horrid. **14 ♖d2 ♕e6** Defending the d-pawn and preparing for ... ♖d7, ... ♖ad8 and then ... d5. Rather than sit back and wait for this plan to be executed, White decides to take the initiative and sacrifice a pawn. **15 ♘d5 ef 16 ♘d4** Not 16 ♘c7?? ♕e5 17 ♘xa8 fe, and Black wins material. **16 ... ♘xd4 17 ♗xd4 ♗xd5 18 ed ♕f5** Although Black's extra pawn is a doubled pawn it is still a useful asset. The f4 pawn dominates two useful squares and in the endgame Black's 4:2 kingside pawn majority will be a useful weapon. **19 ♖e2 h5 20 ♖e7 ♘d7 21 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 22 ♕d4+ ♕f6 23 ♖e4 ♖dc8 24 c3 ♕xd4+ 25 ♖xd4 ♘e5 26 ♗e2 ♖c5 27 ♖ad1 g5 28 ♗xh5 ♘c4 29 ♖e1 ♘e3 30 ♗d1 ♖xd5 31 ♖xd5 ♘xd5 32 ♗f3 ♘e3 33 ♖e2 d5!** At last. **34 c4 dc 35 ♖d2 ♖c8 36 ♗xb7 c3 37 bc ♖xc3 38 ♔f2 f5 39 a4 a5 40 h4?** This move does not change the result but it does hasten the end. **40 ... g4 41 ♖d4** 0-1.

This game illustrates the axiom "A threat is more powerful than its execution". Black was building up quite methodically to d5 when White, afraid of the consequences of that move, gave up a pawn. After White's pawn sacrifice Black had only to play carefully to ensure himself of the win.

Conclusion

Black's position is fundamentally sound and so, if he progresses methodically with his thematic idea of forcing ... d5, he should be able to achieve a satisfactory position.

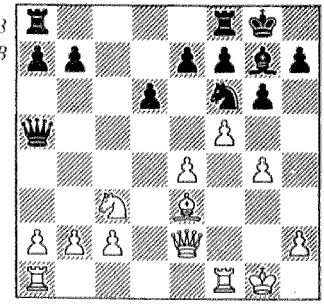
Black Creates Piece Play on the Queenside and Prepares the Exchange Sacrifice ... ♖xc3

The theme of the exchange sacrifice on c3 recurs time and again in the Sicilian Defence but never so often as in the Dragon Variation. The principal reason why this exchange sacrifice is so prevalent in the Dragon is that Black's g7 bishop bears down on the c3 square so that often, after Black has played ... ♖xc3 and White has recaptured on c3, Black will be able to win the pawn on c3 almost at once, thereby reducing his material deficit to a minimum.

In the Estrin-Fridstein game we saw how slow play by Black can result in White getting an overwhelming kingside attack within a few moves. Let us return to the position after White's fourteenth move and follow another game, this time one in which Black plays more actively. From diagram 93:

14 ... ♖ac8! This natural move, bringing the rook into play along the half-open file, is more active

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B



Filipowicz-Hollis
Student Olympiad
Marianske Lazne 1962

than the 14 ... ♕b4 of the Estrin-Fristein game. **15 g5 ♖xc3!** Suddenly it is Black who has the initiative; if 16 bc ♘xe4 followed by ... ♘xc3 with a clear advantage for Black. **16 gf ♖xe3 17 ♕xe3 ♗xf6** Black has a pawn for the exchange, White's queenside is under pressure and his king is rather exposed. All in all Black has ample compensation for the sacrificed material and White must be careful if he is going to avoid defeat. **18 c3 ♖c8 19 a3** Attacking on the kingside would be to overextend White's position, e.g. 19 ♖f3 b5 20 ♔h1 ♖c4 21 ♖h3 ♗g7, and White's position is ready to collapse. **19 ... ♖c4 20 ♖ae1 b5!** As in the Unzicker-Eliskases game (p.69) Black creates a minority attack on the queenside. **21 ♖f3 ♕c7 22 fg hg 23 ♖h3 a5! 24 ♖f1 ♕c5 25 ♕xc5 ♖xc5 26 ♖d3 ♖c4 27 ♖xf6**

Now White is fighting to draw. If he tries to keep his material advantage by 27 ♖e1, Black continues with his minority attack and White ends up with too many weak pawns: 27 ... b4 28 ab ab 29 cb ♗xb2 30 ♖b3 ♗c3! 31 ♖eb1 ♗d4+ 32 ♔h1 ♗b6 33 ♖e1 ♔g7 and White will probably lose one of his isolated pawns. When that happens Black will have two pawns for the exchange and excellent winning chances. **27 ... ef 28 ♖xd6 ♖xe4 29 ♖xf6 ♔g7 30 ♖b6 ♖e5 31 ♔f2 g5 32 ♖a6 a4 33 c4 ♖c5 34 cb ♖xb5 35 ♖xa4 ♖xb2+ 36 ♔g3** ½-½

Black's exchange sacrifice netted him one pawn as immediate compensation and sufficient pressure to maintain the balance. In the ending Black's queenside minority attack created unpleasant threats and White was unable to keep his material advantage. In practice the slight advantage of the exchange for a pawn often proves to be of no real value in the Dragon, since the fighting power of Black's minor pieces is usually greater than that of White's rooks which lack open files.

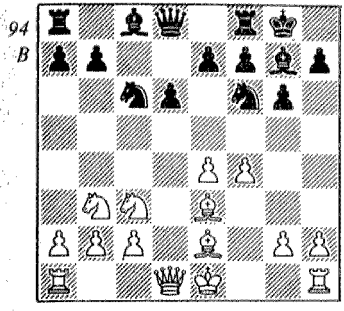
Conclusion

Active queenside piece play, in conjunction with the sacrifice of the exchange on c3, normally distracts White from his kingside attack and allows Black to take the initiative. This, together with one or two pawns, provides sufficient compensation for the exchange and offers Black the better practical chances.

Black Provokes a Queenside Weakness and then Creates Piece Play on the Queenside

In the Sicilian Defence White normally refrains from moving his queenside pawns unless he has a good reason for doing so. The reason is that pawn moves create weaknesses and since Black's counterplay in the Sicilian lies on the queenside it is natural for White to try to preserve his queenside pawn structure. In the Classical Dragon White often plays his knight from d4 to b3. This provides a target for Black's a-pawn, and after the move ... a5, threatening ... a4 and ... a3, White usually finds it necessary to play a4 himself. This move creates a weak square at b4 from where Black's queen's knight can exert its influence without fearing the move a3. Diagram 94 is an example.

9 ... a5! 10 a4 If 10 a3 a4 11 ♘d4 d5, and now 12 e5 ♘e4 gives Black the more active game. **10 ... ♗e6 11 0-0** The premature advance 11 g4 would be met by 11 ... d5, e.g. 12 f5 ♗c8 13 ed ♘b4 14 fg hg and Black will win back the d-pawn



Janoševič-Vasyukov
Belgrade 1961

with advantage. The interpolation of the moves ... a5 and a4 has given Black a secure post for his knight on b4. **11 ... ♕c8 12 ♗f3 ♘b4** Once again we see how the advance of the a-pawns has helped Black's knight. **13 ♘d4 ♗c4 14 ♖f2 ♖d8** Now White cannot prevent ... d5. **15 f5 d5 16 e5 ♘e4 17 fg hg 18 ♘xe4 de 19 ♗g4 ♕c5 20 b3 ♗xe5 21 ♖d2** 21 bc ♗xd4 22 ♗xd4 ♖xd4 and 23 ... ♖xc4 would be equally hopeless for White. **21 ... ♘d5 22 ♘f5 ♘xe3 23 ♖xd8+ ♔h7** 0-1. Every one of White's pieces is under attack.

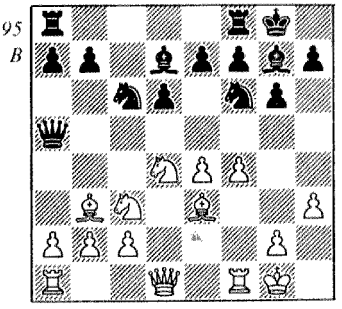
Conclusion

If Black can provoke the advance of White's a-pawn to a4 and *then* initiate his queenside counter-attack, he will be even better off than in the corresponding positions with the white a-pawn on its home square.

The Neo-Classical Dragon

We have given the name "Neo-Classical" to those lines in which White castles kingside, as in the Classical Dragon, but develops his king's bishop on b3 (via c4) rather than e2. This set-up often arises from the Accelerated Dragon, though recently there have been attempts by players of the white pieces to side step the Dragon proper and force Black into the variations of the Accelerated Dragon in which ♗c4 is a popular choice for White.

A typical Neo-Classical position is shown in the following diagram.



White's b3 bishop strengthens his hold on the key square d5 and casts an eye on f7, thereby enhancing the prospect of a kingside attack, should Black play too slowly. For example:

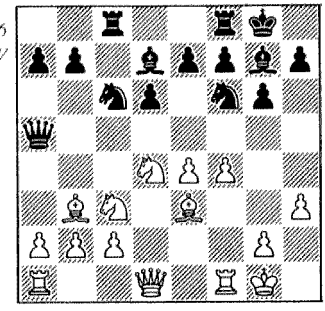
Kurajica-Hübner, Barcelona 1965. **11 ... ♖ad8** Too slow. White has too much control of the d5 square

for ... d5 to be a real possibility. **12** ♘f3 Removing the option of ... ♘xd4; ♗xd4 ♗c6, which is a frequently seen plan in positions of this type. **12 ... b5 13 a3 a6** So that the queen will be free to move. **14 ♕e1 ♕c7 15 ♕h4 ♕b8** Black is now ready to continue with his minority attack but he has wasted so much time preparing it that White now has an overwhelming initiative on the kingside. **16 g4 a5 17 f5 gf** Otherwise White would play g5, driving away the f6 knight, followed by ♘d5. **18 ef a4 19 ♗a2 b4 20 ♘d5** 20 ab ♘xb4 21 g5 is probably a more convincing way of continuing the attack. **20 ... b3 21 ♗h6 ♗xh6 22 ♘xf6+ ef 23 ♕xh6 ba 24 ♘g5 ♗xf5 25 gf ♕a7+ 26 ♔h1 ♖fe8 27 ♘xh7** 1-0. Yet another lesson for those who play the black side of the Sicilian with kid gloves on.

Let us now look at a more active approach to the position in the previous diagram. Instead of placing his queen's rook on the somewhat useless square d8, Black plays **11 ... ♖ac8**, a far more logical rook move (diagram 96).

12 ♕f3 ♕h5 13 ♕f2 White should not allow the exchange of queens in the Sicilian as long as Black has an active position. The reason for this is that Black's play along the semi-open c-file and the possibility of launching a minority

96 W



Popovych-Sherwin
USA 1968

attack on the queenside give him the better endgame prospects. If White plays 13 g4? he quickly succumbs to the sacrifice 13 ... **♗xg4! 14 hg ♘xg4 15 ♖fd1 ♕h2+** 16 ♔f1 ♘xe3+ 17 ♕xe3 ♘xd4 18 ♖xd4 ♕h1+ winning. Resources such as this one abound in the sharp variations of the Sicilian, particularly the Dragon. **13 ... b5!** Making the maximum use of his queenside potential. **14 ♘dxb5** Other moves leave Black with much the more active position. **14 ... ♘xe4 15 ♘xe4 ♕xb5** Black has won a central pawn for a wing pawn and so he has the better centre control. **16 ♘g3 a5 17 a4 ♕b4** This time the moves ... a5 and a4 have allowed Black's queen to take up a safe stance on b4. **18 f5 ♔h8 19 ♖ad1 ♕h4 20 ♖d3 ♗e5! 21 ♗f4 gf 22 ♗xe5+ ♘xe5 23 ♖d4 ♕f6 24 ♖d5?** White already had a bad game because his bishop is

worse than Black's knight and Black has the lion's share of the centre (and a passed e-pawn), but the text move enables Black to finish the game almost at once. Relatively best was 24 ♖fd1. **24 ... ♖g8 25 ♖xa5 ♕g5 26 ♘e2 ♗c6 27 ♘f4 ♘f3+ 28 ♔h1 ♕xf4 29 gf ♖g3 30 ♗d5 ♖xh3+** 0-1.

Compare the performances of Black's armies in these two games. In the Kurajica-Hübner game Black fiddled around on the queenside for so long that by the time his counterplay got moving it was already too late for it to be of any effect. In the second game, however, Black played much more dynamically and within a very few moves White's position was looking rickety.

The Yugoslav Attack

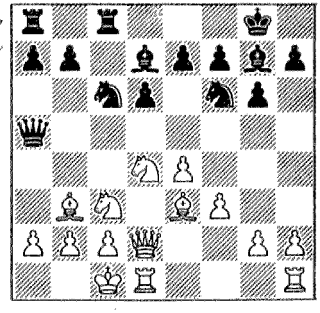
White's plan in the Yugoslav Attack is explained quite simply: He castles queenside and launches an all out attack against the black king. If this strategy is successful Black might well get mated by move 25 or even earlier, but experience has shown that Black's position is full of resources and that with accurate play it should be possible for Black to hold the balance.

White's Basic Strategy

1) To open the h-file by advancing his h-pawn to the fifth rank (sometimes supported by g4) and then exchanging on g6;
2) To exchange dark squared bishops at the appropriate moment by playing ♗h6, or, in some cases, ♗d4 followed by ♘d5;
3) To mount an attack on h7 with his queen and rook, and then to remove Black's f6 knight which is the most important defensive piece;
4) Ultimately, to give mate on h7 or h8.

Black's Basic Strategy

Try to create immediate counterplay, which means:
1) Bring a rook to the c-file;
2) Manoeuvre a knight to c4, attacking White's queen on d2 and the queen's bishop on e3 so that White's light squared bishop will be exchanged for this knight;
3) Play for the exchange sacrifice on c3 which often disrupts White's game completely.



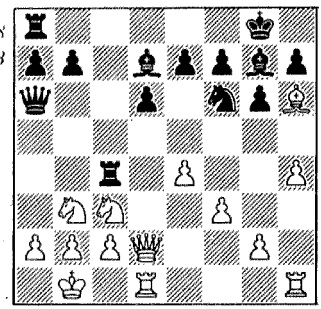
Drimer-Levy
Hastings 1969-70

This position is typical of the Yugoslav Attack. White does not always develop his king's bishop to c4 and then b3, as in this case, but practice has shown that this system causes Black the greatest problems. This is mainly because if White is allowed to play h4-h5 and hg with a white bishop sitting unhindered on b3 Black will be forced to recapture on g6 with his h-pawn, thereby opening up the h-file and giving White two possible mating squares, h7 and h8. If Black can arrange things so that he can capture on g6 with his f-pawn he will only have to worry about defending the h7 square, and in positions in which his queen's rook is on c8 rather than his king's rook, Black will be able to reinforce his defence of the second rank by the move ... ♖f7 at some stage.

We shall now examine some of the most important possibilities for each side. From diagram 97:

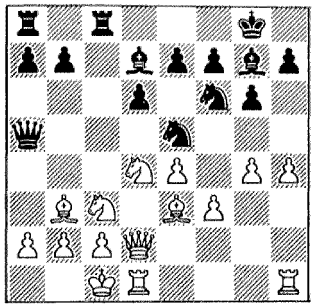
12 ♔b1! A useful waiting move. White nearly always finds it necessary to play ♔b1 at some stage or other (one of the reasons is that his a-pawn sometimes requires protection) and by playing this move immediately he compels Black to commit himself. **12 ... ♘e5** Heading for c4. **13 h4 ♘c4 14 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 15 ♘b3** Consolidating his queenside and preparing for ♗h6 (15 ♗h6 at once would lose to 15 ... ♖xd4 16 ♕xd4 ♗xh6 – this theme occurs quite often in similar positions so always be alert when considering the possibility of ♗h6 by White). One important aspect of ♘b3 is that it drives Black's queen to a square from which it no longer attacks c3, so that after an eventual exchange sacrifice on that square Black will not be so well placed to capture White's c3 pawn. **15 ... ♕a6 16 ♗h6!** *(98)*

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B



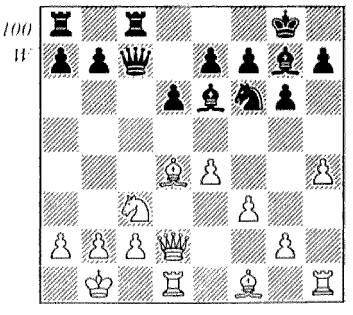
16 ... ♗xh6 If 16 ... ♖ac8 17 g4, followed by h5, the exchange of bishops on g7, the exchange of pawns and then ♕h6+ and ♘d5. This is the standard mating procedure in situations where Black has insufficient counterplay. **17 ♕xh6 ♖ac8 18 h5 ♖xc3** If 18 ... ♘xh5 19 g4 ♘f6 20 ♘d5! , yet another reason for White's 12 ♔b1; if Black meets ♘d5! with ... ♖xc2 it is not check. **19 bc ♗e6** ... ♘xh5 is still not possible, this time because of 20 g4 ♘f6 21 e5 de 22

♖xd7! when Black's knight finds itself overworked. **20 hg fg 21 ♕e3** White is the exchange up for nothing and won the ending without difficulty.



Bokor-Sapi
Hungarian Ch 1967

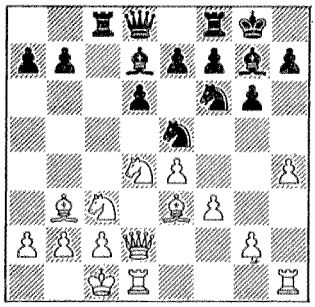
Here White has adopted a slightly different plan, playing g4 instead of ♔b1 as in the previous example. Black can continue as before with ... ♘c4, but another possibility is **13 ... b5** This advance of a queenside pawn is perfectly logical, and with correct play should lead to a satisfactory game for Black. **14 h5 b4** An interesting alternative is 14 ... ♘c4 15 ♗xc4 and now 15 ... bc. Recapturing with the pawn may appear to be illogical since Black's counterplay is nearly always along the c-file, but in blocking the c-file Black is opening up the b-file which can provide him with excellent attacking prospects against b2. **15 ♘ce2 ♘c4 16 ♕d3** Not the best move. White should play 16 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 17 ♔b1 (see how this move is necessary so often) followed by 18 b3, when Black has very little counterplay. **16 ... ♘xe3 17 ♕xe3 e5?** White's d4 knight is trapped in mid-board but its loss only helps White to continue his attack. Black should keep his attention on the queenside, e.g. 17 ... ♕b6, followed by ... a5-a4. **18 hg hg 19 ♘f5 gf** In positions like this it is usually better to capture with the bishop, thereby keeping the g-file closed, but here, after 19 ... ♗xf5 20 gf White would be threatening to capture on g6 since Black's f-pawn is pinned by White's bishop. It is for reasons such as this that Black should always be looking for ways to neutralise White's light squared bishop in the Yugoslav Attack. **20 gf ♗a4 21 ♖dg1 ♘e8 22 ♖xg7+ ♘xg7 23 ♕h6 ♔f8 24 ♕f6 ♔e8 25 ♕xd6 ♖xc2+ 26 ♗xc2 f6 27 ♖h8+ ♔f7 27 ♖xa8** 1-0.



Van der Wiel-Sax
Plovdiv 1983

13 h5 ♕a5 14 hg hg 15 a3 ♖ab8 16 ♗d3! White piles up on the black king's defences. **16 ... b5 17 ♕g5 ♕c7 18 e5 de 19 ♗xe5 ♕c5 20 f4 ♖b7 21 ♗xg6! fg** Black's queenside counterplay is insufficient: 21 ... b4 22 ♖h7! bc 23 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 24 ♗e4+ ♔f8 25 ♕h6+. **22 ♕xg6 ♗f7 23 ♖h8+!** 1-0. The end comes after 23 ... ♔xh8 24 ♕xf7 ♖g8 25 ♖h1+ ♘h7 26 ♕h5.

In all of these examples Black's counterplay was sadly lacking and in an opening as sharp as the Sicilian Defence a player without counterplay is almost as badly off as a chicken without a head. The three examples which follow show some of the resources at Black's disposal. For a further illustration of the sacrificial ideas inherent in the Dragon the reader should re-examine the position on page 9 in the introduction.



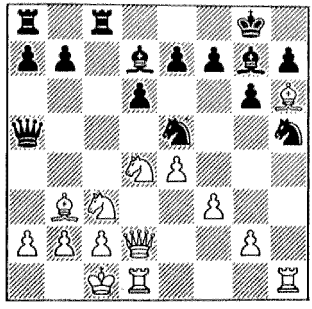
Bednarski-Szpotanski
Poland 1966

A tempting move in this position is 12 ... a5, which forces White to weaken his queenside by 13 a4, but after 13 ... ♘c4 14 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 15 b3! ♖c8 16 ♘db5 it is easy to see that although White does have some weak squares on the queenside Black as no way of taking advantage of them. Black is therefore left without counterplay and his kingside will be dissected at White's will.

The correct continuation is **12 ... ♘c4 13 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 14 h5 ♘xh5 15 g4 ♘f6 16 ♗h6** For many years this was considered to be White's best move here, but, as the reader will soon see, Black has sufficient resources to save himself from an unpleasant fate on the kingside. Recently the move 16 ♘de2 has become popular, supporting the c3 knight so that Black does not achieve anything with the traditional exchange sacrifice on c3. **16 ... ♘xe4 17 ♘xe4** The alternatives are varied and extremely complex, e.g. if 17 fe then 17 ... ♖xd4 or if 17 ♕e3 ♖xc3 18 bc ♘f6. **17 ... ♖xd4 18 ♕h2 ♗e5!** Preventing 19 ♗xg7 while keeping the initiative. **19 ♕h4** 19 f4 looks more aggressive, but after 19 ... ♖xd1+ 20 ♖xd1 ♗h8 21 ♗xf8 ♕b6 it is difficult to see how White can save himself. **19 ... ♖xe4! 20 fe ♕b6** Black's initiative has suddenly become overwhelming, a natural consequence of the fact that White

has failed to exchange the dark squared bishops. **21** c3 ♖c8 22 ♗d2 ♗e6 23 ♕xe7 ♗xa2 24 ♕d7 ♗e6 25 ♕a4 ♗b3 26 ♕d7 ♖d8 27 ♕e7 ♕a5 0-1.

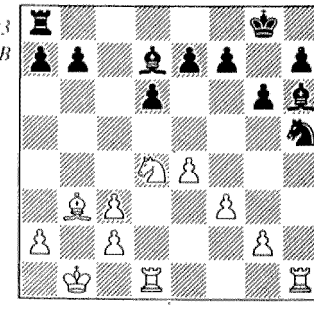
102
B



Hartston-Westerinen
Havana Olympiad 1966

Here Black has two distinct ways of disrupting White's attacking plans. The simplest is to decoy White's queen from her defence of c3 and then sacrifice the exchange on that square: 14 ... ♗xh6 15 ♕xh6 ♖xc3! 16 bc ♖c8, when White must play carefully to hold the balance. Another, more spectacular, idea is **14 ... ♘d3+! 15 ♕xd3** 15 ♔b1 leads to great complications which seem to favour Black. **15 .. ♗xh6+ 16 ♔b1 ♖xc3!** The thematic exchange sacrifice. If White recaptures with the pawn Black has good attacking chances because of the presence of queens on the board. **17 ♕xc3 ♕xc3 18 bc**

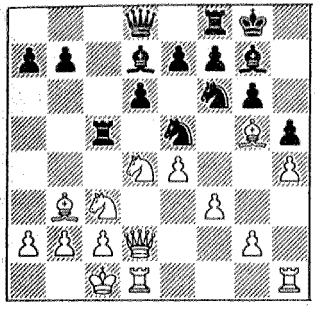
103
B



A typical Dragon ending. Black is the exchange for a pawn down but he actually has the advantage because White has no real counterplay. **18 ... ♗g7 19 ♖he1 a5 20 a4 ♖c8 21 ♔b2 ♘f4 22 g3 ♘e6 23 ♖e3 ♘c5 24 ♔a3 ♗h6 25 f4 e5** Every one of Black's moves is a threat. **26 ♘e2 ♗c6 27 ♗d5 ♗xa4 28 ♖f3 ♗xc2 29 ♖h1 ♗f8 30 fe ♗xe4 31 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 32 ed ♗xd6+ 33 ♔a4 ♖c4+ 34 ♔b5 ♖c5+ 35 ♔b6 ♗c7+ 36 ♔xb7 ♘d6+ 37 ♔a8 a4** 0-1. An excellent illustration of how active minor pieces can dominate passive rooks. In this type of ending White has no open lines for his rooks and so the advantage of the exchange is purely illusory.

Diagram 104: Black has thrown in an early ... h5, trying to hold up White's kingside pawns whilst pushing ahead with counterplay on the other flank. **14 f4 ♘e4 15 ♕d3 b5 16 e5** An earlier game, Ivanović-Miles, Vrbas 1980, saw Black's counterplay triumph after

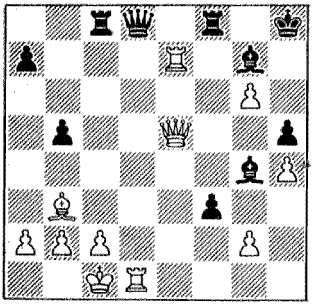
104
W



Ljubojević-Miles
Malta Olympiad 1980

16 f5 ♘e5 17 ♕e3 a5 18 fg ♘xg6 19 a3 b4 20 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 21 ♘a4 ♗xa4 22 ♗xa4 ♕b6 23 ♖h3 ba 24 ♕xa3 ♗xd4 25 ♖xd4 ♖xc2+ 26 ♔xc2 ♕xd4. **16 ... ♘g4 17 ♘e4 ♖c8! 18 ed f6 19 ♖he1 ed** Not 19 ... fg? 20 ♘xg5 ed 21 ♕xg6. **20 ♘xd6 ♔h7! 21 f5** 21 ♘xc8? ♘f2. **21 ... ♘xd6 22 fg+ ♔h8 23 ♗f4 ♘e5** Black has weathered the storm. **24 ♗xe5 fe 25 ♘f3** Or 25 ♘e6 ♗xe6 26 ♗xe6 ♕f6! 27 ♕xd6 e4! with a winning attack. **25 ... e4 26 ♕xd6 ef 27 ♖e7 ♗g4! 28 ♕e5** *(105)*

105
B



28 ... ♕xd1+! 29 ♔xd1 fg+ 30 ♔d2 ♖fd8+ 31 ♗d5 ♖xd5+ 0-1. A beautiful finish to the game and this chapter.

The Golden Rules of Dragon Positions

1) If Black remains passive he will be mated by a direct attack along the h-file.

2) White should always try to keep control of the d5 square.

3) Black should always be willing to sacrifice the exchange on c3 provided that he can get (or already has) at least one pawn for it.

4) In the Classical Dragon, if Black plays ... d5 and White replies e5, Black should quickly build up pressure on White's e-pawn.

5) If White launches a kingside attack with his pawns before he has castled, it will often be best for Black to reply ... d5.

6) In the Yugoslav Attack White must play for the exchange of dark squared bishops, but not at the cost of having his queen decoyed away so that a successful exchange sacrifice is possible.

7) In the Yugoslav Attack White must prise open the h-file, but once he has succeeded he should not expect the attack to play itself – accuracy and vigilance are needed to the end.

8) In the Yugoslav Attack, when White has his king's bishop on b3, Black should play his queen's knight via e5 or a5 to c4 blunting the power of the bishop and encouraging it to be exchanged for the knight.

9) It is not usually a good idea for Black to play ... ♘a5 and ... ♘xb3 because the resulting pawn structure helps to shield White's king.

10) He who vacillates is lost.

6 Positions with ... e5

Throughout this book the reader will have noticed that we repeatedly emphasise the importance of the d5 square in the Sicilian Defence. We have reiterated the fact that if Black can play ... d5 with impunity he will be able to secure at least an equal position and we have stressed the significance of controlling d5 and of Black keeping his opponent's pieces away from d5. It is therefore something of a paradox that there exist a number of variations of the Sicilian in which Black concedes the d5 square during the very first moves of the game by playing ... e5.

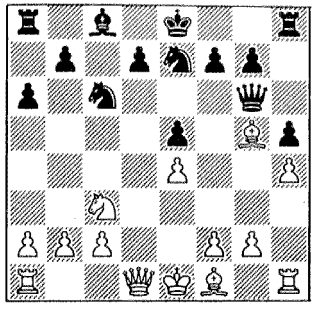
Once Black has played ... e5 the outcome of the struggle will usually depend on how much use White is able to make of the d5 square. If Black can force ... d5 with impunity he will be able, as in most Sicilian positions, to equalise the chances or obtain the upper hand. If White is able to keep d5 under complete control Black will only be able to obtain a satisfactory game if he can create counterplay on the queenside, with ... b5-b4 and/or on the kingside with ... f5.

Before we take a closer look at the strategies for both White and Black, let us examine two games, each of which presents a general picture of the type of problem that faces each side.

Zuckerman-Bleiman
Netanya 1971

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e5 5 ♘b5 a6 Black forces his opponent to gain the advantage of the two bishops in the hope that he will obtain sufficient play in the centre to compensate. **6 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 7 ♕xd6 ♕f6 8 ♕d1** The exchange of queens leaves Black with a lead in development to balance White's bishop pair. **8 ... ♕g6** In return for the gaping hole on d5 Black has obtained a lead in development and pressure on White's centre. But is this enough? **9 ♘c3 ♘ge7 10 h4** Forcing Black's reply **10 ... h5** so that now White's queen's bishop has a safe post on g4. **11 ♗g5** *(106)* Now we

can see that White has the edge because Black's position is lacking in dynamic possibilities and White still has control of d5.



11 ... d5 The only road to counterplay. **12 ed ♘b4 13 ♗xe7 ♔xe7 14 ♗d3** The logical way to protect the c-pawn, since 14 ♖c1 would deprive White of the possibility of castling queenside. **14 ... ♘xd3+** If 14 ... ♕xg2 15 ♗e4 followed by d6+. **15 ♕xd3 ♕xd3 16 cd b5 17 0-0-0 b4?** Driving the knight to a better square. After 17 ... ♖d8 18 ♖he1 White's advantage would not have been so great. **18 ♘e4 f5?** After this move Black is lost. 18 ... ♖d8 would have been better, though after 19 d6+ ♔f8 20 d4 f5 21 ♘g3 White is still a pawn up. **19 ♘g5 ♖d8 20 d4 ♖xd5 21 de ♖xe5** Black has won back the pawn but White has converted his material advantage into the qualitative one of good knight v. bishop. Also, Black's queenside pawns are vulnerable and White's king is well placed for the ending. In fact Black's position is quite lost. **22 ♖he1 ♖xe1 23 ♖xe1+ ♔f8** If 23 ... ♔d6 24 ♖e8 ♗b7 25 ♖e6+ ♔d7 26 ♖b6. **24 ♘e6+ ♔f7 25 ♘g5+ ♔f8 26 ♖e5 ♖a7 27 ♖c5** White can also win by ♔c2 followed by ♔b3 and an attack on the queenside pawns. **27 ... ♗d7 28 ♔d2 ♔e7 29 ♔e3 ♔d6 30 ♔d4 ♗c6 31 f3 ♖e7 32 ♖c5! ♖xe5 33 ♘f7+ ♔e6 34 ♘xe5 ♗b5 35 f4 ♗f1 36 g3 ♔d6 37 ♘c4+ ♔c6 38 ♘e3 ♗h3 39 ♔c4 a5 40 b3 g6 41 ♔d4 ♔b5** 1-0 because of 42 ♔d5 ♔b6 43 ♔e6 ♔c5 44 ♔e5! ♔b6 45 ♔f6 etc. This game is a model of White's strategy against ... e5 positions. First White builds up a positional advantage because of his control of d5, then Black gives up a pawn in order to minimise this positional advantage. Here White is able to return the pawn in order to revert to a position in which his qualitative advantage was enormous.

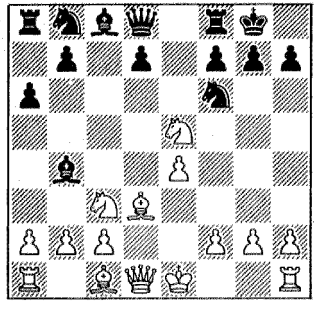
In complete contrast let us now see what happens when White is unable to exert sufficient control over d5.

Keres-F.Olafsson
Belgrade 1959

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 a6 This move is designed to prevent White's d4 knight from invading b5 (and possibly d6) after Black plays ... e5. **3 d4** This move falls in with

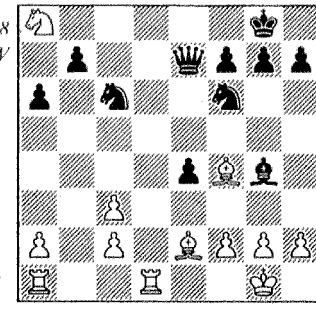
Black's plans. 3 c4 is more logical, and only later will White play d4. Then Black cannot play ... d5 at any time and White has a typical Maroczy Bind position. **3 ... cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5** Now we see the point of 2 ... a6. White's knight has been deprived of its most active square. **6 ♘f3** Obviously not 6 ♘f5? because Black would then be able to play 6 ... d5 with advantage. **6 ... ♗b4** Already Black has a slight lead in development. **7 ♘xe5?!** White should look to his development. After 7 ♗c4 ♕c7 8 ♗b3 0-0 9 0-0 ♗xc3 10 bc d6 11 ♖e1 White does not have anything to fear. **7 ... 0-0!** 7 ... ♘xe4? would allow White to make good use of the d5 square by 8 ♕d5. **8 ♗d3** *(107)*

107
B



8 ... d5 9 0-0 ♗xc3 10 bc de 11 ♗e2 ♕c7 Black has put his initiative to good effect. Already he has won back the pawn and he has the better pawn structure. **12 ♘c4 ♖d8 13 ♗f4 ♕e7 14 ♘b6 ♖xd1 15 ♖fxd1 ♘c6 16 ♘xa8 ♗g4** *(108)* White has two rooks for the queen but his forces are not well co-ordinated and Black's queen has an open board to roam.

108
W



17 ♗xg4 ♘xg4 18 ♘c7 ♕c5 19 ♗g3 e3! 20 fe ♘xe3 21 ♗f2 ♕g5 22 ♗xe3 ♕xe3+ 23 ♔h1 ♕xc3 24 ♘d5 ♕c5 Black must be careful not to allow White's rooks to get too active. If 24 ... ♕xc2 25 ♖ac1 ♕b2 26 ♘e7+ ♔f8 27 ♘xc6 bc 28 ♖xc6 and White will soon win the a-pawn when the game will be a dead draw. **25 ♖d2 h6 26 ♖e1 ♘d4 27 c3 ♘e6 28 h3 ♔h7 29 ♖f1 ♘g5 30 ♖f4 ♕a3 31 ♖c2 ♕d6 32 c4 b5 33 h4 bc 34 ♖d4 ♕e5 35 ♖2xc4 ♘e6 36 ♖d1 ♕e2 37 ♖dc1 ♕xa2 38 ♘f4 ♘f8 39 ♖c7 ♕d2 40 ♖f1 ♘d7 41 ♖a7** and White resigns. After 41 ... a5 42 h5 ♘e5 White can avoid the mating threats with 43 ♔h2 ♘g4+ 44 ♔g3 but then comes 43 ... ♕e3+ followed by the advance of the passed a-pawn.

White's Basic Strategy

1) To keep control of d5 and prevent ... d5.
2) To restrain Black's queenside advance.
3) To prevent ... f5 if possible.
4) Ultimately, to destroy Black by capitalising on his weak squares.

Black's Basic Strategy

1) To look for opportunities to play ... d5.
2) To create queenside counterplay.
3) To create kingside counterplay by means of ... f5.
4) Ultimately, to create sufficient tactical possibilities to outweigh White's control of d5.

Ideas for White

Occupy d5 with a piece.
Create pressure along the a2-g8 diagonal by ♗c4.
Attack Black's advancing queenside pawns.

Ideas for Black

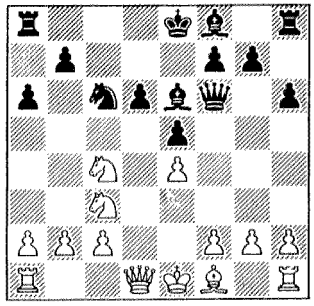
Black plays for ... d5.
Black advances his queenside pawns.
Black plays ... f5.

White Occupies d5 with a Piece

The major disadvantage of having a weak square is that your opponent can occupy it with one of his pieces. For this reason an important part of White's basic strategy will be the occupation of d5.

Since Black's f6 knight attacks d5 White should not jump in to d5 at the first opportunity without making sure that Black cannot make an advantageous exchange on that square. If Black does exchange on d5 White almost invariably wants to recapture with another piece, rather than with his e-pawn, since if d5 is occupied by a pawn White loses all the advantages of controlling that square. He also loses the pressure that he exerts on Black's backward d-pawn and he makes it easier for Black to play ... f5.

109
W

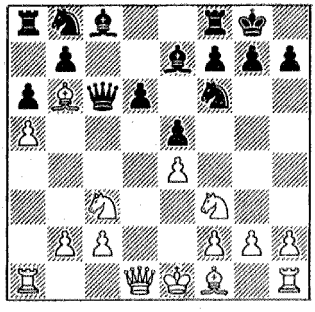


Ribli-Zinn
Zalaegerszeg 1969

11 ♘b6 Gaining a tempo while increasing his hold on d5. **11 ... ♖b8 12 ♘cd5 ♕g6 13 ♕d3 ♗xd5 14 ♘xd5 ♗e7 15 g3 ♗d8 16 0-0-0 b5 17 f4 h5** So that 18 f5 can be met by 18 ... ♕h6+ **18 ♔b1 0-0 19 h4 a5**

20 ♗e2 ♘d4 21 f5 ♕h6 22 ♖dg1 ♘xe2 23 ♕xe2 ♔h7 24 g4 hg 25 ♖xg4 ♖h8 26 ♕f2 ♖c8 27 ♖hg1 ♖g8 28 ♕a7 ♖f8 29 ♕d7 ♖c4 30 ♖xg7+ ♕xg7 31 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 32 f6+ Black resigns. After 32 ... ♔h7 33 ♕g4 forces mate. Throughout the game White's knight remained on d5, cutting Black's position in two and preventing the communication of Black's rooks. The knight also tied down the black bishop to a useless square and helped in the kingside attack by supporting the advance of the f-pawn to f6.

110
W



Mestel-Chandler
London (GLC) 1986

White seems to have established something of a bind, but it is more apparent than real. **11 ♘d5** Not good at this point, as Black soon demonstrates in classical style. **11 ... ♘xd5 12 ed ♕e8! 13 ♗e2 ♘d7 14 ♗c7 f5 15 0-0 ♘f6 16 c4 f4 17 ♖e1 e4 18 ♘d4 ♕g6** White's early occupation of d5 has rebounded in the form of a kingside attack by Black. **19 ♔h1 e3! 20 ♗d3 ♕g5!? 21 ♘f3 ♕h5 22 fe ♘g4 23 ♕e2 fe** Threatening 24 ... ♖xf3! 25 gf ♘f2+ 26 ♔g2 ♕g5+ 27 ♔f1 ♗h3 mate. **24 ♖f1 ♗f5 25 ♗xf5 ♖xf5** Threatening 26 ... ♘xh2! **26 h3 ♖af8 27 ♔g1 ♘f2! 28 ♘d4!** 28 ♕xe3 loses to 28 ... ♖xf3 29 gf ♘xh3+ 30 ♔g2 ♘f4+ 31 ♔g1 ♕g6+ 32 ♔f2 ♗h4 mate. **28 ... ♕g5! 29 ♘xf5 ♖xf5 30 ♖xf2 ♖xf2 31 ♕g4 ♕xg4 32 hg ♖xb2 33 ♗b6 ♗g5 34 c5 dc 35 d6 c4 36 ♖e1 ♖d2 37. ♗xe3 ♗xe3 38 ♖xe3 ♖xd6** Black has a won rook and pawn ending which will be even simpler to win if the rooks come off. **39 ♔f2 ♔f7 40 ♔e2** 0-1.

Conclusion

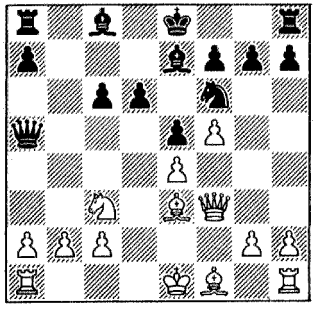
White should avoid playing ♘d5 if Black can exchange knights and force the first player to recapture with a pawn: capturing with the c-pawn frees the e-file for counterplay by Black's rooks and capturing with the e-pawn allows ... f5, with Black having greater control of the centre and kingside attacking possibilities. Provided that White can recapture with a piece, ♘d5 is almost invariably a good move.

White Creates Pressure along the a2-g8 Diagonal by ♗c4

In Chapter 4 we examined a few positions in which White played

an early ♗c4, putting pressure on f7 and preparing for the advance of the kingside pawns. It was shown in that chapter that Black does best to meet ♗c4 with ... e6, blunting the effect of White's c4 bishop, and so it is logical for White to meet the move ... e5 with an eventual ♗c4.

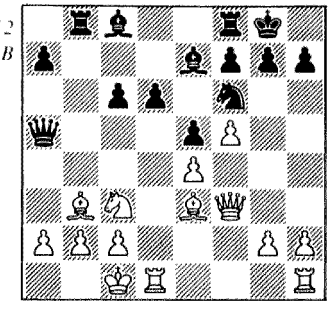
111
W



Gaprindashvili-Hartoch
Amsterdam 1976

This is not a typical ... e5 position because here White has disobeyed one of the golden rules of the Sicilian Defence and exchanged knights on c6, while Black was still in a position to recapture with his b-pawn. This exchange was necessary, however, as it enabled White to keep the initiative and block in Black's queen's bishop by f5. **11 ♗c4** Preventing ... d5 and preparing for an eventual g4-g5 and the traditional kingside mating attack. **11 ... ♖b8 12 ♗b3 0-0** If 12 ... d5 13 ♗d2 d4 14 ♘d5 ♕d8 15 ♘xc7 ♕xc7 16 g4. Black is then devoid of counterplay and has no satisfactory way of meeting the avalanche of white pawns that is threatening to descend on his kingside. **13 0-0-0** *(112)* Now Black must find an active plan otherwise he will be squashed by g4 etc.

112
B



13 ... ♖xb3 14 cb d5 Black has achieved ... d5 but at what cost? **15 ed cd 16 ♖xd5!** Returning the material in order to reclaim the initiative. **16 ... ♘xd5 17 ♘xd5 ♗d6 18 ♖d1 ♕xa2 19 ♘f6+ gf 20 ♗h6 ♔h8 21 ♗xf8 ♕a1+ 22 ♔c2 ♕xd1+ 23 ♔xd1 ♗xf8 24 ♕a8** Black resigns.

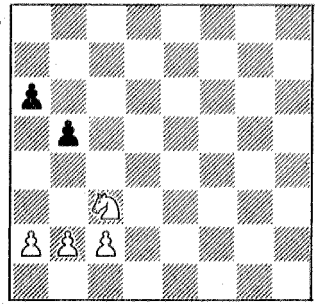
Conclusion

If White has time for ♗c4 in positions where Black has already played ... e5 then the freeing manoeuvre ... d5 can rarely be achieved, except at enormous cost, and Black is in danger of being forced to remain totally passive until he is finally squashed flat by White's kingside advance.

White Attacks Black's Advancing Queenside Pawns

White usually views his opponent's b-pawn and a-pawn as attacking units that are likely to cause White problems should they advance too far. Sometimes, however, these pawns can themselves become the object of attack.

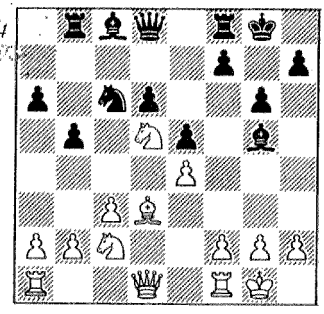
113



This queenside structure, or something very much like it, is seen in countless Sicilian Defence positions. Black's b-pawn has advanced with the support of the a-pawn and threatens to bring a certain amount of confusion to White's ranks if it is allowed to advance to b4. There are occasions on which the advance of the b-pawn will not worry White, such as positions in which the sacrifice ♘d5 is playable or positions in which White can meet ... b4 with ♘a4 followed by ♘b6 (see, for example, p. 111). In other positions the advance of the b-pawn will actually work in White's favour because the b-pawn will be more vulnerable on b4 than it is on b5.

One way for White to try to take advantage of Black's advancing queenside pawns is the thrust a4. Black can parry this in one of three different ways: (1) He can play ... ba, when White will recapture the pawn and have pressure against Black's remaining a-pawn (and a 2:1 queenside pawn majority which will be useful in the ending); (2) He can advance his pawn to b4, on which square it may be more vulnerable than it was on b5; or (3) He can leave his queenside pawns as they are, when White will be able to exchange on b5, thereby saddling Black with an isolated b-pawn.

114
W



Levy-Day
Haifa Olympiad 1976

15 a4 What should Black do? If he advances the b-pawn he loses it at once and if he allows White to

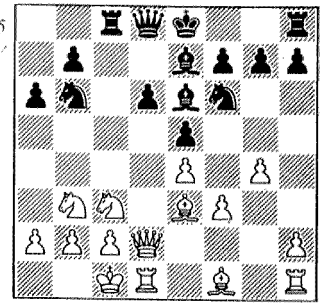
exchange pawns and then play ♕e2 he will also lose the pawn. **15 ... ba 16 ♘cb4!** Attacking the a6 pawn with gain of tempo. **16 ... ♘xb4 17 ♘xb4 ♗d7** If 17 ... ♗b7 18 ♕xa4 and the a6 pawn will be the next to fall. **18 ♗xa6** Leaving Black with the further advanced (and hence the weaker) of the a-pawns. **18 ... ♕b6 19 ♗d3** White returns to pick up the remaining a-pawn with ♗c2. **19 ... f5 20 ef gf 21 ♗c2 ♔h8 22 ♗xa4** White has won a pawn for nothing.

Conclusion

... b5 normally forms an essential part of Black's plans but the move also has its disadvantages.

Black Plays for ... d5

Without a pawn on e6 to support its advance the black d-pawn does not have an easy task in aiming for d5. Black can support this advance only with the help of his pieces and since ... e5 positions tend to leave Black a little cramped it is not easy for him to manoeuvre his pieces onto the right squares for ... d5 to become a real possibility. He usually needs the help of his king's knight on f6, his queen's bishop on e6 or b7 and possibly his other knight (from b6) and/or a major piece placed on the d-file. In general Black will achieve a perfectly satisfactory game if he can build up his position for a successful break on d5.



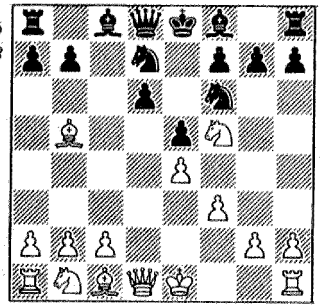
Adorjan-Ribli
Budapest (match) 1979

12 h4 0-0 13 h5! ♘c4 Black has built up his position to make the liberating pawn advance, but now if 13 ... d5 14 ♗xb6 ♕xb6 15 g5 d4 16 ♘a4 ♕c6 17 gf gf 18 ♘ac5! ♗xc5 19 ♖g1+ ♔h8 20 ♕h6 wins. **14 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 15 g5 ♘d7 16 ♖dg1** White has built up a very strong attacking position. **16 ... ♕c7 17 g6 ♖c8 18 ♗h6! ♗f6** 18 ... gh fails to 19 ♕xh6 ♗f6 20 gh+ ♔h8 21 ♖g8+. **19 gh+ ♔xh7 20 ♗xg7! ♗xg7 21 h6!** 21 ♖xg7+ fails to 21 ... ♔xg7 22 ♕g5+ ♔f8 23 h6 ♕d8! **21 ... ♗f6** There is no real alternative, e.g. 21 ... ♗h8 22 ♖g7+ or 21 ... ♗f8 22 ♕g5 f6 23 ♕g6+ ♔h8 24 h7. **22 ♕g2!** 1-0. There is no answer to the threat of ♕g7+.

Another way to effect ... d5 is to play it as a temporary pawn sacrifice. In Chapters 3 and 5 we

explain how the moves ... d5, ed can be followed with ... ♘b4, regaining the pawn. Here is another example of ... d5 as a temporary sacrifice.

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B

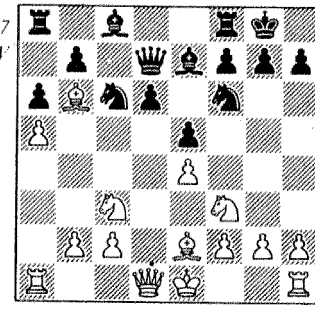


Oesch-Moran
Correspondence 1958

7 ... d5! 8 ed a6 9 ♗xd7+ ♕xd7 10 ♘e3 b5 Intending 11 ... ♗b7 when the d-pawn becomes ripe for plucking. **11 c4 ♗c5 12 ♘c3 0-0 13 ♘e4** White cannot keep the d-pawn by 13 cb ab 14 0-0 because of 14 ... ♗d4 15 ♔h1 ♗a6 and White's c3 knight must move. **13 ... ♘xe4 14 fe f5** A thematic move in ... e5 positions. **15 ef** If 15 ♘xf5 ♕d8, threatening ... ♗xf5 and ... ♕h4+ **15 ... ♕a7 16 ♕e2 ♗xf5 17 cb ♗d7 18 ba** 18 a4 is met by 18 ... ♖f4 followed by ... ♖e4, killing White in the centre. **18 ... ♗b4+ 19 ♔d1 ♗a4+** 0-1.

Diagram 117: **12 ♘d2** Heading for c4, but . . . **12 ... d5 13 ed ♘xd5 14 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 15 0-0 ♗f5 16 c3 e4** Claiming more territory and making

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W



Chandler-Portisch
London (GLC) 1986

room for ... ♘c6-e5-f3. **17 ♘c4 ♕e6 18 ♘e3 ♗d8 19 ♗c4 ♕g6** Black has established a very dynamic kind of equilibrium. **20 ♘xf5 ♗xb6!? 21 ♕d7! ♗d8 22 ♗d5 ♘e5! 23 ♕xb7 ♕xf5 24 ♕xa8 ♗c7 25 ♕b7** 25 ♗xe4 loses to 25 ... ♕h5 26 ♕d5 ♘f3+. **25 ... ♘f3+ 26 ♔h1?** 26 gf should have been played when Black would have chosen between a draw with 26 ... ♗xh2+ and trying for more with 26 ... ♕g5+!? **26 ... ♘xh2! 27 ♕xc7 ♘xf1 28 ♗xe4?** 28 ♖xf1 ♕xd5 is not pleasant for White, but held out better prospects. **28 ... ♕xf2 29 ♗d3 ♘e3 30 ♕h2 g6 31 ♕h3 ♖e8 32 ♕f3 ♕xb2 33 ♖b1 ♕xc3 34 ♗xa6 ♕xa5 35 ♗d3 ♕g5 36 ♔g1 ♘g4 37 ♖b5?** 0-1 (time). White's flag dropped just before 37 ... ♖e1+ 38 ♗f1 ♕xb5 happened.

Conclusion

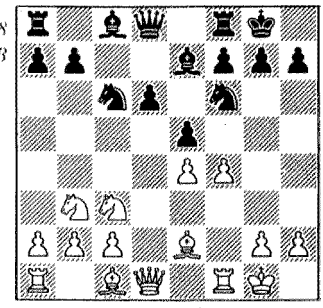
It is obviously difficult for Black

to play ... d5 since there is no pawn support for the move but that is no reason for either side to ignore the possibility completely; if it is achieved, ... d5 will still free Black's game. Whether or not Black's ... d5 is a sacrifice, White must never underestimate it. The extra activity afforded to Black's pieces can often change a cramped passive position into a dynamic one, with serious consequences for White.

Black Advances his Queenside Pawns

The advance of Black's queenside pawns is a thematic idea in most variations of the Sicilian Defence. Usually it takes the form ... a6, ... b5 and an eventual ... b4, possibly after ... a5 or ... ♖b8 or some other preparatory move. In the chapter on Dragon positions we gave some examples of Black advancing his a-pawn in order to force some weakening move in White's own queenside. Here we shall give an illustration of the same theme in an ... e5 position (diagram 118).

9 ... a5 10 ♗e3 White should have prevented the further advance of the pawn by 10 a4. **10 ... a4 11 ♘d2 a3 12 b3 ♘d4! 13 ♘c4** If 13 ♗xd4 de 14 ♘b5 ♕b6 **13 ... b5 14 ♗xd4 ed 15 ♘xb5 ♘xe4 16 ♗f3** If 16 ♘xd4 d5 17 ♘e5 ♗c5 18 ♘f3 ♕f6 19 ♔h1 ♕xf4 with a strong attack; or 16 ♘cxa3 d5 17 ♘b1



Lyuboshin-Boleslavsky
Bielorussian Ch 1955

♕b6 18 ♗d3 ♗d7 19 ♗xe4 d3+ 20 ♔h1 de 21 ♘5c3 ♗c6 22 cd ♖fd8 with a tremendous game for the sacrificed pawn. **16 ... d5 17 ♗xe4 de 18 ♕xd4 ♗a6 19 ♕xd8 ♖fxd8 20 ♘c7 ♗xc4 21 bc ♖a4 22 ♖fd1 ♖xd1+ 23 ♖xd1 ♖xc4 24 ♖d7 ♗c5+ 25 ♔f1 ♖xc2 26 ♖d8+ ♗f8 27 ♘d5 f5** White resigns because after 28 ♘e7+ ♔f7 29 ♘xf5 ♖xa2 the a-pawn will soon queen. This game shows that if White permits the advance ... a4 and ... a3 Black's dynamic possibilities are no less than in the similar situation in the Sicilian Dragon.

Let us now return to the position in the previous diagram and follow another of Boleslavsky's games in order to see what happens when White meets ... a5 with a4. **9 ... a5 10 a4 ♘b4 11 ♗f3 ♗e6 12 ♔h1 ♖c8 13 f5 ♗c4 14 ♖e1 ♘d7 15 ♘d2 ♗a6 16 ♘f1 ♗xf1** Otherwise White would play ♘e3 and one of

the knights would eventually become installed on d5. **17 ♖xf1 ♘b6 18 ♕e2 ♗g5** After the exchange of bishops Black will have the better prospects because of his queenside play (... ♘c4), the possibility of ... d5 and the fact that White's light squared bishop is badly placed.

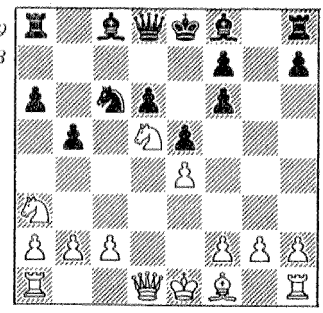
Conclusion

This is the usual form of Black's counterplay in ... e5 positions (unless Black can get in ... f5). So both sides should be alert to the possibilities of such an advance which can easily lead to the weakening of White's queenside.

Black Plays ... f5

Since White's strategy in ... e5 positions revolves largely around his control of d5 it is natural for Black to try to reduce White's grip on that square by attacking the white e-pawn. The move ... f5 accomplishes this task rather well. If White is not careful he may find that Black is developing dangerous attacking chances along the f-file and it is therefore normal for White to try to inhibit ... f5 by means of ♗d3 at some stage. The move ... f5 has been so successful in recent games in which Black played .. e5 Sicilians that in one variation the American Grandmaster Robert Byrne introduced the move g4 in order to stop it.

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B



Semeniuk-Timoshchenko
USSR 1975

This position has occurred in scores of master games during the past few years, an indication that ... e5 positions are now much more in vogue than they were at the beginning of the 1970s. **10 ... f5 11 ♗d3 ♗e6 12 ♕h5 ♗g7 13 c3 f4** Because the advance of Black's f-pawn can be so dangerous, it is usually a good idea for White to capture on f4 as soon as Black plays ... f5. **14 g3** Hoping to encourage Black to exchange off his strong f4 pawn. If 14 0-0 0-0 15 ♘c2 f5! followed by ... ♗xd5 and an eventual ... e4, with a very strong attack. It is because of variations such as this that the doubled f-pawns are not necessarily detrimental to Black's cause. After all, if ... f5 is a good move then it must be even better to play ... f5 twice in the same game! **14 ... 0-0**

15 gf? 15 ♖g1 first would have been more accurate. **15 .. ef 16 e5** If 16 ♘xf4 b4. **16 ... h6 17 ♖g1 ♘xe5 18 ♕xh6 ♘g6 19 ♕h5 ♗xd5 20 ♕xd5 ♖e8+ 21 ♔d2 ♕h4 22 ♖af1 ♘e5 23 ♘c2 ♕h3 24 ♘e1 ♖ac8 25 ♕g2 ♕h8 26 ♘f3 ♔f8 27 ♖c1** Black was threatening 27 ... ♘xf3+ 28 ♕xf3 ♗xc3+. **27 ... ♘xd3 28 ♔xd3 b4** Blasting away the cover from White's king. **29 ♘d4 ♕h7+ 30 ♔d2 bc+ 31 bc f3 32 ♕xg7+** If 32 ♕xf3 ♗h6+. **32 ... ♕xg7 33 ♖xg7 ♔xg7 34 ♖b1 ♖c5 35 ♖b6 ♖a5 36 ♖b2 ♖h5 37 ♔d3 ♖xh2 38 ♔c4 ♖e2 39 ♘xe2 ♖xf2 40 ♖b1 de 41 ♖e1 f5** White resigns.

Conclusion

... f5, undermining White's control of d5 and inaugurating pressure along the f-file, is such a potent weapon that White should consider carefully any measures at his disposal to prevent it from happening.

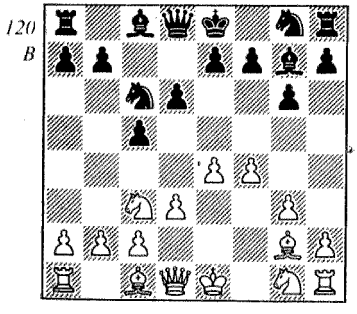
The Golden Rules for ... e5 Positions

1) White must prevent ... d5.
2) White should try to keep a piece maintained on d5 – it is much better to have a piece there than a pawn.
3) White should try to restrain the advance of Black's f-pawn.
4) If Black plays ... f5 White usually does best to exchange off this pawn before it does any damage to White's kingside.
5) Black must create queenside counterplay by advancing his queenside pawns but he must ensure that they do not become vulnerable to attack by a4.

7 Closed Positions

In this chapter we shall discuss positions in which White has not opened up the centre with d4. When White keeps the centre closed his ambition is to build up slowly on the kingside and then smother Black with his kingside advance. The point of keeping the centre closed is that Black will have fewer opportunities to create counterplay – in particular there will not be the half-open c-file for Black's rook, and White's e-pawn will not be a target because it is well supported by the d3 pawn.

A typical opening sequence in the Closed Sicilian is 1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 g3 g6 4 ♗g2 ♗g7 5 d3 d6 6 f4



White intends to continue his development with ♘f3, ♗e3, 0-0 and probably ♕d2, and then he plans to advance on the kingside by h3 followed by g4 and f5, or some similar attacking method. This standard attacking plan can be seen to full effect in the following game.

Smyslov-Taimanov
USSR Team Ch 1959

1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 f4 g6 4 ♘f3 ♗g7 5 d3 d6 6 g3 ♘f6 7 ♗g2 0-0 8 0-0 ♖b8 Normal Sicilian strategy. Black plans to counterattack on the queenside. **9 h3 b5 10 g4 b4 11 ♘e2 c4 12 ♗e3 ♗a6 13 ♘ed4 ♘xd4 14 ♗xd4 ♕c7 15 ♖f2 ♖fe8** Intending ... e5, to exchange off White's f-pawn before it can advance to f5. **16 f5 e5?** Taimanov was afraid of 17 e5, but he should have played 16 ... ♖bc8 and then if 17 e5 he can afford to capture the e-pawn since 18 ♗xe5 no longer skewers his queen and rook. **17 fe fe 18 e5 ♘d5 19 ed ♕d7** 19 ... ♕xd6 loses a piece to 20 ♗xg7

♔xg7 21 dc ♗xc4 22 ♕d4+. **20 dc ♘f4 21 ♗xg7 ♕xg7 22 ♕d4 ♘xg2 23 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 24 ♔xg2 ♗xc4 25 ♘e5 ♗d5+ 26 ♔g3 ♖ed8 27 d7** Black resigned.

White's Basic Strategy

1) Contain Black's queenside counterplay.
2) Advance steadily on the kingside.

Black's Basic Strategy

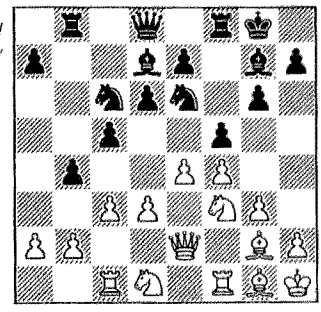
Try to create counterplay, not only on the queenside but also in the centre if the position warrants it. This means:
1) Advance the queenside pawns.
2) Be on the look-out for ways to combine the queenside advance with a pawn thrust in the centre to distract White from his kingside attack.

White's strategy is so simple and unsubtle that it is not easy to define distinct ideas within his attacking plans. (Concepts such as the advance of White's kingside pawns and the exchange of dark-squared bishops by means of ♗e3, ♕d2 and ♗h6 are discussed in the chapter on Dragon formations.) Perhaps the best way to distinguish between White's possible plans of development is to consider the three squares on which White can put his king's knight: f3, e2 and h3.

White Plays ♘f3

The Smyslov-Taimanov game given above shows how White's f3 knight can be used to support the advance e5. Here we shall look at another of Smyslov's games in which the knight plays a different role – it moves to h4 in order to support the advance of the f-pawn.

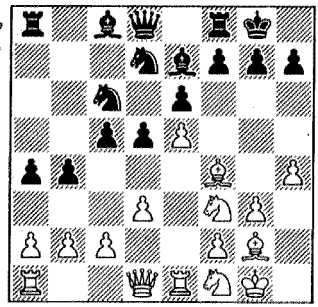
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W



Smyslov-Larsen
Munich Olympiad 1958

16 ♘e3 ♕a5 17 ef! The slow build-up is over and White is ready to break open Black's kingside. **17 ... gf 18 ♘h4 ♘ed8** Black could hardly grab the e-pawn: 18 ... bc 19 bc ♗xc3 20 ♘c4 ♕b4 21 ♗d5 ♘cd8 22 ♕c2 ♗b2 23 ♖b1 winning a piece. **19 g4! fg 20 f5 ♘e5** Once again Black cannot afford to waste time by pawn hunting: 20 ... bc 21 bc ♗xc3 22 ♕xg4+ ♗g7 (or 22 ... ♔h8 23 ♕h5 threatening ♘g6+) 23 ♗d5+ ♔h8 24 ♘g6+! winning. **21 ♘xg4 ♘xg4 22 ♕xg4 ♘f7 23 ♗d5 ♕a6.** If 23 ...

♔h8, to escape from the pins on the g7 bishop and the knight on f7 Black loses to 24 ♕h5 (threatening ♘g6+) 24 ... ♘h6 25 ♗e3 ♗e8 26 ♘g6+ hg 27 fg. **24 ♖c2** White could win at once by 24 ♗d4 cd 25 ♖g1 and mate at g7. **24 ... ♔h8 25 ♖g2 ♗h6 26 ♕h3 ♗c6 27 c4 ♗xd5 28 cd ♘g5 29 ♘g6+ ♔g7 30 ♘f4** winning a piece and the game.



122
W

Fischer-Miagmarsuren
Sousse Interzonal 1967

In this position, which arose from the King's Indian Attack, Black has begun his queenside play but now **13 a3** puts a block on its further progress. **13 ... ba 14 ba ♘a5 15 ♘e3 ♗a6 16 ♗h3** Continuing the kingside build-up and discouraging any ideas Black may have of ... f6, either to clear the centre or create room to manoevre defenders over to the kingside. **16 ... d4 17 ♘f1 ♘b6 18 ♘g5** The kingside attack progresses steadily while Black is getting precisely nowhere on the queenside. **18 ... ♘d5 19 ♗d2 ♗xg5 20 ♗xg5 ♕d7 21 ♕h5 ♖fc8** So that the black queen can get back to cover the dark-square weaknesses. **22 ♘d2 ♘c3 23 ♗f6!** A typical commencement to White's final kingside onslaught. **23 ... ♕e8 24 ♘e4 g6 25 ♕g5! ♘xe4 26 ♖xe4 c4 27 h5! cd** Black finally manages to make some progress on the queenside but events have already reached a decisive stage on the kingside. **28 ♖h4 ♖a7 29 ♗g2!** Calmly regrouping for the final mating net. **29 ... dc 30 ♕h6 ♕f8 31 ♕xh7+** Black resigned. Mate arrives after 31 ... ♔xh7 32 hg+ ♔xg6 33 ♗e4.

Conclusion

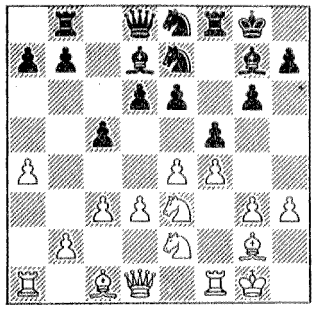
On f3 White's king's knight is well placed to take part in the kingside attack.

White Plays ♘e2

There are two advantages for White in posting his king's knight on e2 rather than f3. Firstly, on f3 the knight might slow down White's pawn advance because it obstructs the f1 rook in its support of the f-pawn. Secondly, the knight might later move to g3, after an eventual g4, and from there it can support the advance of the f-pawn to f5.

Diagram 123 illustrates both of these advantages in action: **14 g4** Were White's e2 knight on f3 this

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W



move would lose a pawn to 14 ... fe 15 fe ♖xf4. **14 ... ♗c6 15 ♕b3 ♘c7 16 gf gf 17 ♘xf5 ♘xf5 18 ef** ♖xf5 19 ♘**g3** ♖**f7 20 f5** White has a very strong attack.

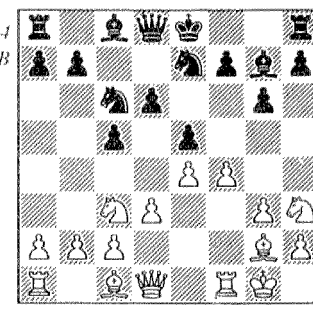
Conclusion

The disadvantage of developing the king's knight on c2 is that if Black plays an early ... e5 then the knight will have no great future on e2. See, for example, the Smyslov-Botvinnik position on page 102.

White Plays ♘h3

h3 is an unnatural square for the white knight. The only real point in putting it there is to support the move f4 when Black has played ... e5. If Black then exchanges pawns on f4 White will recapture with the knight and then invade the d5 square with one of his knights. This plan is not sufficiently dynamic and is unlikely to offer White any real hopes of an advantage.

124
B



Bilek-Evans
Lugano Olympiad 1968

8 ... ef 9 ♘xf4 0-0 10 ♘fd5 ♘xd5 11 ♘xd5 ♗e6 12 ♘f4 ♗d7 White's knight appears to be quite well placed on f4 but in reality it accomplishes very little. **13 c3 b5 14 a3 a5 15 ♗e3 ♘e5 16 h3 a4** White has no serious attacking possibilities on the kingside whereas Black's queenside counterplay has made rapid forward progress. **17 ♕d2 ♗c6 18 ♖f2 ♖b8 19 ♖af1 ♕d7 20 ♕d1 ♕b7 21 ♗c1** Already White is on the defensive, trying to meet the advance of Black's b-pawn. **21 ... b4** Black has the advantage. **22 ab?** Black's advantage increases after this move. Better is 22 cb cb 23 ♗d2. **22 ... cb 23 c4 b3! 24 ♔h2 ♕a6 25 ♖e1 ♖b7 26 ♗e3 a3 27 ♕e2 ♘xc4! 28 dc ♗xb2 29 ♕d3 ♗e5 30 ♗d4 b2 31 ♘e6 a2 32 ♗xe5 b1♕ 33 ♕xd6 ♖e8! 34 ♘c7 ♖xc7 35 ♗c3 ♕xe1 36 ♗xe1 a1♕ 37 ♕xc7 ♕b7** White resigned.

Conclusion

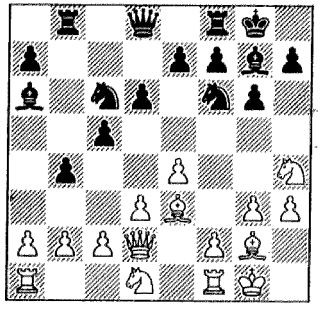
The development of White's king's knight to h3 and f4 lacks punch.

Ideas for Black

Black advances his queenside pawns.
Black plays ... ♘d4.
Black plays an early ... e5 and/or ... f5.

Black Advances his Q-Side Pawns

We have already seen from the previous example that Black's Q-side pawn advance forms the basis of his counterplay. Here, to emphasise this point, is a highly successful example from Black's point of view.



Hecht-Keene
Teesside 1972

In the previous example (Bilek-Evans) Black's task was made relatively easy by the fact that White played c3, thereby giving Black's advancing queenside pawns a target for attack. Here White has avoided weakening his queenside and so Black strikes at the only white queenside pawn to have advanced beyond the second rank – the d-pawn. **12 ... c4 13 f4 ♕c7 14 ♖f2 ♖fd8 15 d4** Otherwise ... d5 will be even stronger. **15 ... d5 16 e5 ♘e4 17 ♗xe4 c3! 18 bc de 19 ♔h2** If 19 cb ♘xb4 followed by ... ♘d5, when Black has tremendous pressure against White's queenside and White's extra pawn is worthless. **19 ... e6 20 ♕e1 ♗f8 21 f5** Desperation. Relatively best was 21 ♗d2. **21 ... ed 22 ♗g5 bc 23 ♗xd8 ♕xd8 24 ♕xc3 ♖c8 25 ♘e3 ♕xd4 26 ♕xd4 ♘xd4 27 ♖d1 ♘c6 28 ♖d5 ♖e8 29 g4 ♗h6 30 ♘exf5** If 30 ♘hg2 ♘xe5 31 gf ♘f3+ 32 ♔h1 ♖b8. **30 ... gf 31 ♘xf5 ♗f8 32 ♘d6 ♖xe5** White resigned.

Conclusion

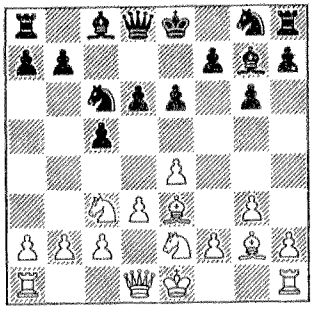
If they advance quickly enough, Black's queenside pawns can create a serious diversion before White's kingside attack has made much progress.

Black Plays ... ♘d4

Part of White's basic strategy in the Closed Sicilian is to deprive Black of open lines on the queenside. Black's queenside pawn advance seeks to combat this strategy by forcing one or more of White's queenside pawns to capture the

black pawns as they reach the fifth or sixth rank. If this strategy succeeds, Black will usually be able to create sufficient play along these newly opened lines to distract White from his steady advance on the king's wing.

Another idea for opening up lines on the queenside is the move ... ♘d4. On d4 the black knight causes a certain amount of confusion in White's ranks since, at the very least, it will be able to exchange itself for White's knight on e2 or f3, thereby reducing the pressure on Black's position. The real point of ... ♘d4, however, is that if White exchanges off this knight Black will recapture with the c-pawn, half opening the c-file and creating the possibility of putting pressure on White's c-pawn. Black must only ensure that once his c-pawn reaches d4 it will not soon be lost.



7 ... **♘d4**. The right moment, since White was intending 8 d4 cd 9 ♘xd4, when Black's d-pawn would come under heavy pressure. **8 ♕d2 ♕a5**. This prevents the move ♘d1, which is sometimes played with the idea of continuing c3. If now 9 ♘d1 Black will exchange queens and achieve full equality at once. **9 0-0 ♘e7**. Heading for ... c6, from where it can support the d4 knight. **10 ♔h1** If 10 ♘xd4 cd 11 ♘e2 ♕xd2 12 ♗xd2 ♘c6 **Black has a perfectly satisfactory** game. The doubled d-pawns are not a weakness and Black will be able to create play along the c-file. **10 ... ♘ec6 11 f4 0-0** Black has achieved equality but he must not be too greedy. If 11 ... ♘xe2 12 ♕xe2 ♗xc3? 13 bc ♕xc3 14 ♕f2 White has the advantage of the two bishops and good attacking chances against Black's denuded kingside. As a general rule in the Sicilian Defence, it is inadvisable for Black to go pawn hunting at an early stage of the game if it involves exchanging off his fianchettoed king's bishop. This is because the exchange of his g7 bishop leaves Black with weaknesses on all the dark squares near his king and makes White's attacking task considerably easier.

Conclusion

If ... ♘d4 is playable, it usually restricts White's options.

Black Plays an Early ... e5 and/or ... f5

It has already been mentioned that when White develops his king's knight on e2 in the Closed Sicilian it is logical for Black to play ... e5, so that White does not exert so much influence over the f4 square. The move ... e5 might appear to weaken Black's position by creating a 'hole' on d5 but, as the following game illustrates, the weakness of d5 is largely illusory.

Smyslov-Botvinnik
World Championship Match 1954
(15th Game)

1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 g3 g6 4 ♗g2 ♗g7 5 d3 d6 6 ♘ge2 e5! 'A good plan. The white king's bishop is safely blocked and the advance d4 is also rendered difficult. Black can also meet an eventual f4 by a timely ... f5. The weakness of the central square d5 does not have a great deal of significance as White can occupy this square with only two minor pieces whereas Black can defend it with three. It is not hard to draw the conclusion that Black is already out of his opening difficulties – a grave conclusion for supporters of the Closed Variation.' – Botvinnik. **7 ♘d5** 'If 7 0-0 ♘ge7 8 f4 0-0 and 9 ... f5, when Black also has no difficulties.' – Botvinnik. **7 ... ♘ge7! 8 c3 ♘xd5 9 ed ♘e7 10 0-0 0-0 11 f4** 'After this pseudo-active move White gets a difficult game. The pawn on f4 merely limits the mobility of his knight and queen's bishop.' – Botvinnik.

Conclusion

Botvinnik has shown that active play in the centre is quite sufficient to defuse White's kingside attack.

Other Ideas in the Closed Sicilian

The reader might wonder why, in all of the closed positions examined so far, White's king's bishop has been developed on g2. This fact may seem even more puzzling when taken in conjunction with our assertions elsewhere in this book that the development of White's king's bishop on g2 is not normally consistent with an attack on the kingside, since the bishop assumes a rather inoffensive role on g2.

The answer to this question lies in the lack of suitable alternatives. The square d3 does not come into consideration because White should not block a central pawn with a minor piece as that restricts his mobility and interferes with his development. The only other possibilities are e2, e4 and b5.

On e2 White's bishop would be no more active than it is on g2, and since White always plays d3 in the

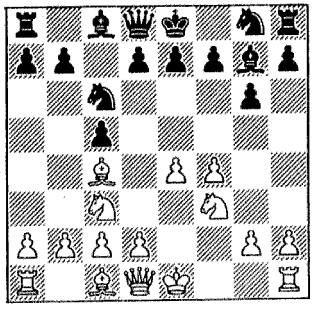
Closed Sicilian there is not even the possibility of an eventual ♗d3 to help the kingside attack. This reduces the possible alternatives to two.

The moves ♗c4 and ♗b5 are both playable but against accurate play by Black neither of them should cause the second player any difficulties. The following examples should suffice to convince the reader.

White Plays ♗c4

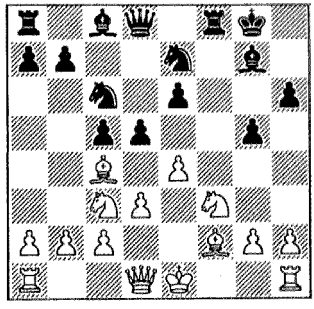
1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 f4 g6 4 ♘f3 ♗g7 5 ♗c4

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The only advantage of this move, pressure along the a2-g8 diagonal, disappears almost at once if Black plays sensibly. **5 ... e6** The sort of thing that White might be hoping for can be seen from the variation 5 ... d6 6 d3 ♘f6 7 0-0 0-0 8 f5 (increasing the pressure on f7) 8 ... gf 9 ♕e1, and White has the making of a strong attack with moves such as ♘g5 and ♕h4 to follow. But as we have seen from the chapter on the little centre, the move ♗c4 should, where possible, be met by ... e6, blunting the power of the bishop. **6 f5** If White does not play this move at once, Black will play ... ♘ge7 followed by ... d5, taking complete command of the centre and making White's c4 bishop look foolish. **6 ... ♘ge7 7 fe fe 8 d3 0-0 9 ♗g5 h6 10 ♗h4 g5 11 ♗f2 d5** Black already has the advantage.

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W



Conclusion

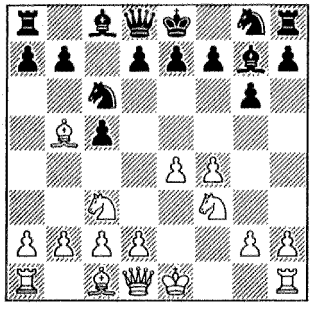
Meet ♗c4 with ... e6 and an early ... d5.

White Plays ♗b5

1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 f4 g6 4 ♘f3 ♗g7 5 ♗b5 *(129)*

If White is allowed to do so he will exchange on c6 ad then proceed with his attack by 0-0, d3, ♕e1 and ♕h4 etc. **5 ... ♘d4!** Why not? As in other variations of the Closed Sicilian, the doubled pawns are of

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little or no consequence. **6 ♘xd4 cd** After only six moves Black has the initiative. **7 ♘e2 ♕b6 8 ♗d3** If 8 ♗c4 e6 followed by ... d5. **8 ... ♘f6 9 0-0** If 9 e5 ♘d5 and Black will eventually undouble his pawns by ... d6. **9 ... d5 10 e5 ♘e4!** White has a very cramped position. If he exchanges on e4 Blacks central pawns will become very dangerous, while if the black knight is permitted to reside on e4 it is difficult to see how White can activate his pieces.

Conclusion

Black should try to take immediate advantage of the overstretched position of White's bishop on b5.

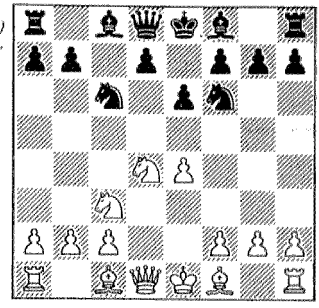
The Golden Rules of the Closed Sicilian

1) White's king's knight is best developed on f3.
2) White should avoid making weakening pawn moves on the queenside.
3) Black should advance his queenside pawns, making sure that his queen's rook is not left on the exposed long diagonal for too long.
4) Black should try to establish a stronghold on d4 and not worry about getting doubled pawns in the process.
5) Black should be aware of the possibilities of ... e5 and ... f5 at all times.

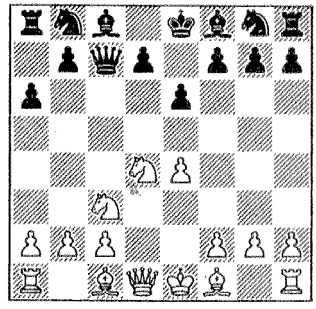
8 Positions with ... e6

There are many variations of the Sicilian Defence in which Black plays the move ... e6. In some of these variations Black also plays ... d6 at an early stage, thereby producing the central pawn structure which we have named the 'little centre' and which is discussed in detail in Chapter 4. Here we shall consider only those positions in which Black has played ... e6 but not ... d6.

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W



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W



Diagrams 130 and 131 both arise after five moves by each side. Both are normal ... e6 positions and they show the typical pawn structures that occur when Black plays ... e6 without ... d6. A few salient observations at this point might help the reader to understand more clearly the ideas that follow.

The most important feature of ... e6 positions is that Black's king's bishop is free to move to any square along the f8-a3 diagonal. It is rare in ... e6 positions for the bishop to reside on e7 because there are many active possibilities for Black associated with the development of his king's bishop on the squares d6, c5 and b4 – and even a3. Also, when Black plays ... ♗e7 he usually combines this with ... d6, and we are not concerned with such positions in this chapter.

The move ... e6 deprives White's

knight of the square d5 from the very outset, although if Black is careless he can later fall victim to one of the sacrificial attacks based on the move ♘d5. The move ... a6, which is a very frequent companion of ... e6, deprives White of the use of b5, although once again careless play by Black can give White the possibility of an advantageous sacrifice on that square. Since White is unable to play ♘d5 or ♘b5, it is perfectly safe for Black to develop his queen on c7, and this in fact is the normal square for the queen in ... e6 positions.

The move ... a6 helps to support the advance of Black's b-pawn, and so on a6 the pawn performs a dual role. In many elementary chess books we are told not to advance our rook's pawns in the opening because it wastes time, but here the time is well spent, and ... a6 should be considered as an almost essential part of every ... e6 position.

Since Black's king's bishop is most likely to be developed away from the kingside, the black kingside itself will be more vulnerable to attack than in many other Sicilian positions. To offset this there is the fact that the king's bishop will be used more actively than in many other Sicilian positions and so there will be a greater number of dynamic possibilities for Black, as well as for White.

Before proceeding with our discussion of the basic strategies for each side, it is perhaps worth reminding the reader that certain move orders in the ... e6 systems allow White to establish a Maroczy Bind by playing c4, but those positions are discussed separately in Chapter 3.

White's Basic Strategy

1) Quick, fluid development, keeping Black's counterplay in check.
2) Capitalise on Black's dark square weaknesses if possible.
3) Launch a kingside attack.

Black's Basic Strategy

1) Avoid any permanent dark square weaknesses.
2) Make the greatest possible use of the king's bishop.
3) Play for early queenside pressure by means of ... b5.
4) Ultimately, develop so much counterplay that White will be unable to proceed with his kingside attack.

Ideas for White

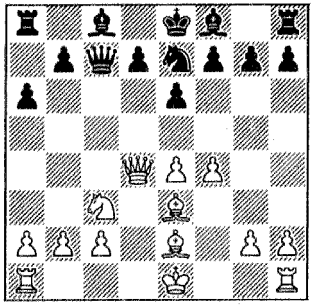
Take control of b6 before Black has played ... b5.
Take control of d6 by playing e5.
White sacrifices on b5.
White sacrifices on d5.
White attacks on the kingside.

Ideas for Black

Develop the king's bishop on d6.
Develop the king's bishop on c5.
Develop the king's bishop on b4.
The tactical shot ... ♗a3.
The queenside attack.

White Takes Control of b6 Before Black has Played ... b5

In the second of the positions shown on page 105 there are two squares in Black's half of the board that appear to be vulnerable to an invasion by White's pieces: b6 and d6. The weakness of b6 is, or rather should be, only of a temporary nature, since Black nearly always plays ... b5 at a relatively early stage of the game, after which the occupation of b6 by a white piece is difficult to accomplish. But if White manages to install a piece on b6 and tie down Black's b-pawn then Black will find it very hard to relieve himself from the bind.



Dely-Brzozka
Polanica Zdroj 1965

Black has exchanged knights on d4 and intends to bring his king's knight to c6. This manoeuvre is quite common in many ... e6 positions and whether or not it is a success usually depends on whether or not White can make good use of the time spent by Black in carrying out the manoeuvre and take advantage of the absence of the knight from the kingside. Here Black should play 9 ... b5 followed by ... ♘c6, but instead he chose **9 ... ♘c6?** and after **10 ♕b6 ♕xb6 11 ♗xb6 ♗b4 12 0-0-0 ♗a5 13 ♘a4** it was apparent that Black could not free himself from the wedge driven into b6. **13 ... ♗xb6 14 ♘xb6 ♖b8 15 ♖d6** Sewing Black in on the dark squares. **15 ... e5 16 f5 ♘d4 17 ♗c4 ♔e7 18 ♖d5 d6** Black has achieved a little freedom of movement but hardly enough to save the game. **19 c3 ♘c6 20 ♖hd1 ♖d8 21 g4 f6 22 b4 ♘a7 24 a4 ♗d7** White threatened 24 b5, when none of the blacks pieces would be able to move. **24 ♖xd6 ♗c6 25 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 26 ♖xd8 ♔xd8 27 ♗d5** and White duly won the ending.

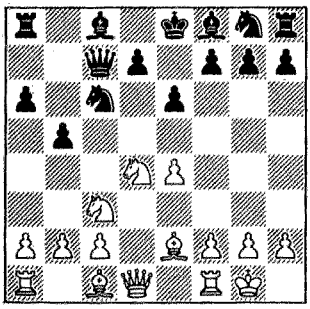
Conclusion

Black must ensure that White cannot plant a piece on b6, because if White can maintain it there Black will find himself strangled to death.

White Takes Control of d6 by Playing e5

The advance e5 looks very tempting for White in ... e6 positions because it secures him a big space advantage and seizes control of the d6 square. If the e-pawn can be maintained on e5 then its advance to that square will almost certainly be advantageous for White provided that it does not give Black too much play along the a8-h1 diagonal. When considering the advance e5 it is therefore necessary for White to ask himself two questions: (1) Can I keep this pawn on e5 or can Black eliminate it in some way such as by playing ... d6 or ... f6? (2) Can Black kill me along the diagonal leading to g2?

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W



Shishov-Suetin
USSR 1963

Black has just played 7 ... b5. **8 ♘xc6** A strong move. Normally in the Sicilian Defence it is a strategic error for White to exchange knights on c6 because Black can recapture with his b-pawn, which strengthens his centre and helps him prepare for ... d5. In many ... e6 positions, however, Black plays ... b5, so that when White captures on c6 Black is not able to recapture with the b-pawn. In fact, in those variations in which Black plays ... b5 when he has a knight on c6 and White has a knight on d4, it is often best for White to meet ... b5 with an immediate ♘xc6, so that if Black recaptures with his queen the queen will be on a potentially exposed square. Delaying ♘xc6 allows Black to recapture with the bishop. **8 ... ♕xc6** 8 ... dc leaves Black with no prospects of counterplay along the c-file. **9 e5 ♗b7 10 ♗f3 ♕c7 11 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 12 ♕d3 ♘e7 13 a4** When White is intending to move his c3 knight in any event he often does well to encourage Black's b-pawn to advance to a square on which it will be more vulnerable. In fact it is rather paradoxical that White often plays a3 to prevent ... b4, driving away the knight, but that when he wants to move the knight White first plays a4 in order to coax Black's b-pawn to b4. **13 ... b4** 13 ... ba 14 ♖xa4 would leave White with a very active rook and pressure against the black a-pawn. **14 ♘e4 ♘g6 15 f4 ♖c8 16 ♗e3** Black can never reclaim control of the d6 square

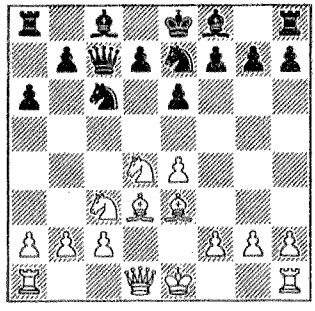
and White will be able to build up pressure on his weak d-pawn.

Conclusion

Before playing e5, White must consider: (a) whether he can maintain the pawn there; (b) whether such maintenance will involve the creation of an isolated pawn on e5 – a serious endgame weakness; (c) whether anything terrible will occur on the h1-a8 diagonal. Black, of course, must also consider these factors.

White Sacrifices on b5

The situation of Black's queen on c7 and the fact that the d6 square is often rather weak can sometimes combine to make it possible for White to sacrifice successfully on b5.



Ivanović-Nikolić
Yugoslav Ch 1969

Here the d6 square is just about as weak as it can ever get, and it is easy to see that a white knight on b5 will attack that square and the black queen simultaneously. And so: **8 ♘db5!** This type of sacrifice is sometimes possible when Black has already played ... b5. In those cases White picks up an extra pawn on the way. **8 ... ab 9 ♘xb5 ♕b8 10 ♗b6** A supreme example of Black's dark square weaknesses – the threat is 11 ♗c7 winning the queen. **10 ... ♘d5 11 ed ♕e5+ 12 ♔f1 ♖a4 13 ♗c7 ♕xb2** If 13 ... ♕xd5 14 c4. **14 ♖b1 ♕f6 15 dc** White has won a piece.

An extra motif to the sacrifice on b5 is that if White's d3 bishop did not block the d-file it would be possible for White to follow up 9 ♘xb5 with 10 ♘d6+ ♔d8 11 ♗b6+ winning the queen, and even if Black had played ... b5 so that ♗b6 was not possible, 10 ♘d6+ ♔d8 could be followed up by 11 ♘xf7+ forking king and rook. In short, watch out for sacrifices on b5; they often prove to be immediately decisive.

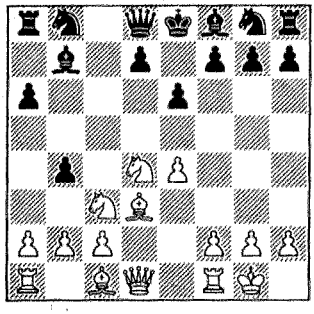
Conclusion

Both sides should watch carefully for the possibility of a sacrifice by White on b5.

White Sacrifices on d5

Just because ... e6 apparently prevents White's ♘d5, it would be unwise for the reader to assume that the move *always* does so.

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Estrin-Shatskes
Moscow Central Club Ch 1967

While White has been developing his pieces in a sensible manner Black has arrogantly advanced on the queenside without any regard for the general principles of chess. White is now so far ahead in development that he can afford to give up a piece to open up Black's king and still remain with more pieces in play than his opponent. **8 ♘d5! ed 9 ed ♗xd5** In the case of most ♘d5 sacrifices in the Sicilian, White maintains the d5 pawn and uses it to support his d4 knight should it need to advance into c6 or e6. Here, however, Black's d-pawn is still on d7 and so the moves ♘c6 and ♘e6 do not come into consideration. Consequently White's d-pawn is not such a necessary item. The only significant factor about the capture of the d-pawn is that the black bishop is now in a position to block the e-file by ... ♗e6, but this is not a serious drawback from White's point of view. **10 ♖e1+ ♗e7** If 10 ... ♗e6 11 ♕f3 ♖a7 12 ♗e3 ♖c7 13 ♗f4 ♖c8 (a novel way for Black to get his rook to c8) 14 ♖ad1 with dangerous threats. **11 ♘f5 ♘c6** If 11 ... ♔f8 12 ♕g4! ♗f6 13 ♗f4 with a tremendous bind. **12 ♘xg7+ ♔f8** White now went wrong and played 13 ♘f5, which gave his opponent time to consolidate his kingside: 13 ... ♗e6 14 ♕g4 ♗f6. Instead he should have played **13 ♘h5! ♗e6 14 ♕f3** Threatening 15 ♖xc6 de 16 ♕xc6. **14 ... ♗f6 15 ♗e3 h6 16 ♗c5+ ♗e7 17 ♖xe6! ♗xc5 18 ♗g6** and White wins.

Conclusion

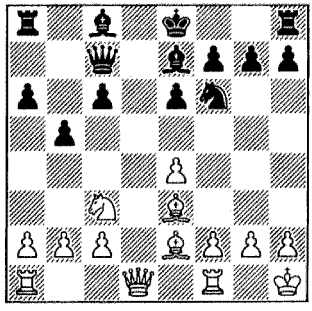
If Black has either a minor piece on c6 or a queen on c7, both sides should bear in mind the possibility of ♘d5. If Black's piece disposition includes both of the above then each player should think very hard indeed about the consequences of the knight 'sacrifice'.

White Attacks on the Kingside

Almost all kingside attacks against ... e6 positions will involve the move f4 by White. Since f4 is nearly always answered by ... d6 to prevent e5, it follows that most kingside attacks against ... e6 positions usually turn into kingside attacks against little centre positions, and we have discussed these attacking

methods in Chapter 4. There are, however, three black set-ups that are distinctly ... e6 in nature: (1) Positions in which White has exchanged knights on c6 and Black has recaptured with the d-pawn, so ... d6 is not possible; (2) Positions in which Black plays ... ♘ge7 followed by ... ♘g6; (3) Positions in which Black plays ... ♘ge7, ... ♘xd4 and ... ♘c6.

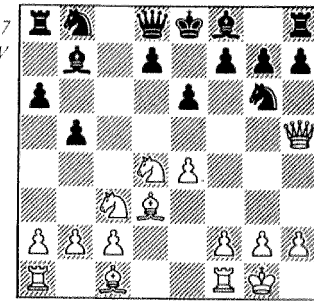
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W



Voskanian-Godes
USSR Student Ch 1964

11 f4 b4 12 ♘a4 0-0 13 ♘b6 ♖b8 14 ♘xc8 ♕xc8 15 ♗d3 Now we have a standard type of attacking position in which Black is unable to prevent e5. **15 ... a5 16 ♕f3 ♖d8 17 ♖ae1 a4 18 e5 ♘d7 19 ♕g3** With White's forces marshalled on the kingside and Black's far away on the other flank it is hardly surprising that White's attack rapidly becomes overwhelming. **19 ... f5** Otherwise 20 f5 is killing. **20 ef ♗xf6 21 ♕h3 ♘f8 22 ♗c5 ♖xd3** Otherwise Black cannot protect both his h-pawn and his e-pawn, which would both be *en prise* after 23 ♗xf8. **23 ♕xd3 ♕d8 24 ♕xd8 ♖xd8** and White soon won.

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W

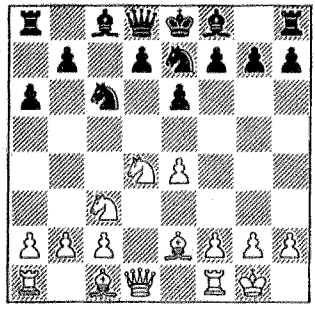


Novopashin-Ruderfer
USSR 1966

Black's ... ♘ge7 and ... ♘g6 has one serious drawback that becomes immediately apparent from the position in the above diagram – White can play an early ♕h5 with impunity and then launch a kingside attack before Black has completed his development. **9 ♘f3** Crude but effective. White threatens ♘g5. **9 ... ♘c6 10 ♗e3 ♕c7 11 ♘g5 d6 12 f4** 12 ♘xh7 does not come into serious consideration because the knight would never extricate itself and eventually it would be lost. **12 ... b4 13 ♘a4 ♘d8 14 ♖ae1 ♗e7 15 ♘b6 ♖b8 16 f5 ef 17 ef ♘e5 18 ♘e6! ♘xe6 19 fe g6 20 ef+ ♘xf7 21 ♗xg6 hg 22 ♕xg6 ♖f8 23 ♖f2 ♗c6 24 ♗g5 ♖xb6 25 ♖xe7+ ♕xe7 26 ♗xe7 ♔xe7 27 ♕f6+ ♔d7 28 ♖e2 ♔c8 29 ♖e7 ♖b7 30 ♖xb7**

♗xb7 31 ♕g7 ♖e8 32 ♕xf7 ♗c6 33 ♕c4 ♔d7 34 ♕xb4 ♖e4 35 ♕d2 ♗b5 36 ♔f2 Black resigned.

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B



Plaskett-Hartston
Uppingham 1986

7 ... ♘xd4 8 ♕xd4 ♘c6 9 ♕d3 ♘b4 10 ♕g3! White hampers the development of Black's f8 bishop. **10 ... ♘xc2 11 ♗g5 f6** If the queen moves then 12 ♖ac1 with a formidable attack for the pawn. **12 ♗f4 ♔f7** Absolutely horrible, but the alternatives are not much better: 12 ... e5 13 ♗xe5 fe 14 ♗h5+ g6 15 ♕xe5+ ♕e7 16 ♕xh8 gh 17 ♘d5 is very strong, while 12 ... ♘xa1 13 ♗h5+ g6 (13 ... ♔e7 14 ♗d6 mate) 14 ♗xg6+ hg 15 ♕xg6+ ♔e7 16 e5! wins. **13 ♗c7 ♕e8 14 ♖ad1 b5 15 e5 ♗b7** 15 ... f5 loses to 16 ♗f3 ♖a7 17 ♗b6 ♖b7 18 ♗xb7 ♗xb7 19 ♕d3. **16 ef ♔g8** 16 ... ♔xf6 (16 ... gf 17 ♗h5+ and mate next move) 17 ♗e5+ ♔f7 18 ♗h5+ ♔g6 19 ♗xh8 would be no more successful. **17 fg ♗xg7 18 ♗e5** Black resigned. The d-pawn goes with check, followed by the bishop on b7.

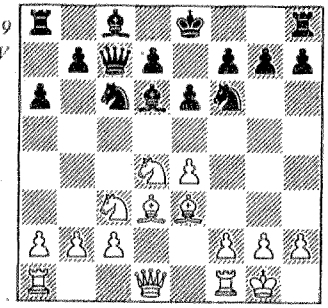
Conclusion

If Black retains a purely ... e6 type of position (rather than switching to a little centre type) in the face of a kingside attack by White, he is liable to be playing into the hands of the first player, who will not find it so difficult to play the important e5 and who may also find black minor pieces which form targets for the pawn advance.

Ideas for Black Based on ... ♗d6

The development of Black's king's bishop to d6 is a rather superficial idea. It is true that with the support of the queen from c7 the bishop threatens White's h-pawn and has the possibility of playing to f4 or e5 in order to exchange off a pair of minor pieces, but with accurate play from White none of these 'threats' should pose any serious problems and the development of the black bishop to d6 should be shown to be unwise.

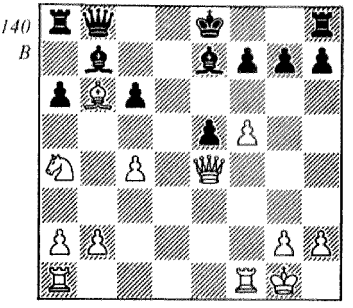
139
W



Dückstein-Portisch
Raach 1969

It is perhaps worth pointing out that if White's king's bishop were on e2 instead of d3 and if White did not have his king on a square that allows a check from Black's d6 bishop, then White could win a pawn by ♘db5, forking the queen and bishop, and if ... ab then ♘xb5 followed by ♘xd6+. This idea is a simple extension of the sacrificial theme discussed on page 109, and it explains why the move ... ♗d6 is seen almost exclusively in positions where White's own king's bishop is already on d3.

9 ♘xc6 the most accurate continuation. 9 f4 loses a pawn to 9 ... ♘xd4 10 ♗xd4 ♗xf4, and 9 ♔h1 can be be met by 9 ... ♗f4 (not 9 ... ♗xh2 10 g3 ♗xg3 11 fg ♕xg3 12 ♕f3 when White's extra piece is worth more than Black's three pawns) 10 ♗xf4 ♕xf4 with an approximately equal position. 9 h3 simply wastes a move. **9 ... bc** This move strengthens the centre and so it must be stronger than ... dc. Normally White should not play ♘xc6 in the Sicilian if Black can recapture with the b-pawn, but here there are dynamic considerations that outweigh this general principle. **10 f4 e5** The only way to meet the threat of e5. **11 f5 ♗e7** Now that the bishop has been shown to have no useful function on d6 it retreats to make way for the advance ... d5. **12 ♕f3 ♗b7 13 ♘a4!** Intending 14 c4, which would impose a kind of Maroczy Bind and prevent ... d5. This idea of ♘a4 in conjunction with c4 occurs quite frequently in ... e6 positions. **13 ... d5 14 ♗b6 ♕b8 15 c4** Even though Black has already played ... d5 this move is still strong because it puts Black's d-pawn under pressure. **15 ... de 16 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 17 ♕xe4**



White has a definite advantage because of his queenside majority and the fact that Black's mobility is so severely restricted.

Conclusion

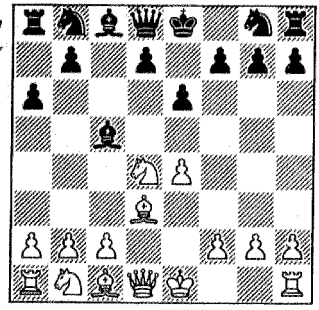
Black should think very carefully before playing the usually superficial move ... ♗d6. White, faced by ... ♗d6, should be on the lookout for the chance to play ♘db5.

Ideas for Black Based on ... ♗c5

c5 is the most logical-looking square for Black's king's bishop in ... e6 positions because from there it exerts pressure along the a7-g1

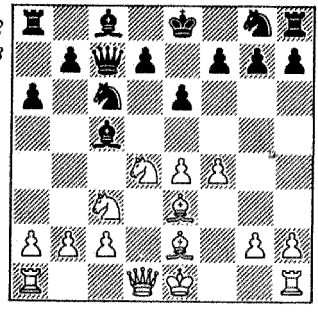
diagonal and introduces tactical possibilities based on the fact that White is striving for f4, which gives the bishop even more scope. Perhaps the most primitive form in which the move ... ♗c5 occurs is in the variation **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♗d3 ♗c5**

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6 ♘b3 ♗a7 This is the logical continuation. Black's idea is to control the important central squares d4 and e3 and to exert pressure on the kingside, but White will soon exchange off this bishop by ♕e2 and ♗e3, e.g. **7 0-0 ♘c6 8 ♕e2 ♘ge7 9 ♗e3 ♗xe3 10 ♕xe3** Black's dark square play has disappeared and he is behind in development.

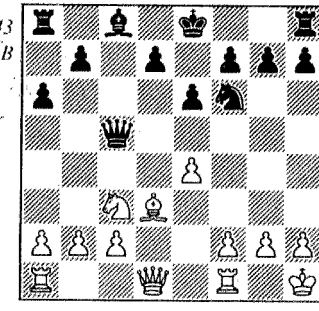
142 B



Here Black is under pressure. If 8 ... ♕b6 9 ♘a4 ♕a5+ 10 c3, and Black is faced with many threats. Or 8 ... d6 9 ♕d3 ♘ge7 10 ♘xc6 ♘xc6 11 0-0-0 0-0 12 ♗f3 ♖b8 13 ♗xc5 dc 14 e5 ♖d8 15 ♕c4 ♘d4 16 ♘e4 b6 17 ♘d6 with a clear advantage because of the beautifully posted knight at d6. Once again Black's c5 bishop was deprived of an active role by White's e3 bishop.

From these two examples it would appear that White does not need to worry about Black's pressure along the a7-g1 diagonal once the dark-squared bishops have been exchanged. But there is one exception to this rule – the situation in which the role that was first adopted by Black's king's bishop is later taken up by his queen.

143 B



11 ... d6 Black must rule out the possibility of e5 (after f4) since it would cramp him and allow White to activate his bishop. **12 f4 e5 13 ♕e1 0-0** The active position of Black's queen has allowed him to

reduce White's possibilities in the centre (notably e5) and complete his development in a satisfactory manner.

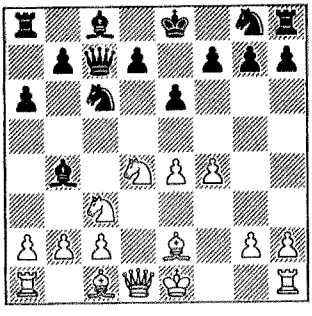
Conclusion

If Black has played ... ♗c5 then both players must be alert to tactical possibilities on the a7-g1 diagonal; these may persist even after the exchange of dark-squared bishops.

Ideas for Black Based on ... ♗b4

The move ... ♗b4 is Black's most active development of his king's bishop. On b4 the bishop pins the white queen's knight and immediately increases Black's pressure along the c-file by the threat of exchanging on c3 to saddle White with doubled isolated pawns on the semi-open file. How should White react to this move?

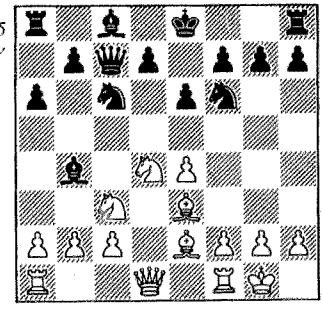
144
W



When Black has not yet developed his king's knight White can take advantage of the fact that ... ♗b4 has left Black's g-pawn vulnerable: **8 ♘xc6 bc** 8 ... ♕xc6 (to keep up the pressure on c3) 9 ♕d4 is still very strong, e.g. 9 ... ♗xc3+ 10 bc ♘f6 11 e5 ♘d5 12 ♗d2 (White threatens 13 c4) 12 ... b5 13 a4 ♗b7 14 ♖b1 with a very active game. **9 ♕d4 ♗f8 10 e5 ♘e7 11 ♗d3 ♘f5 12 ♗xf5 ef 13 ♗e3 ♖b8 14 0-0-0 ♕b7 15 b3 ♗a3+ 16 ♔b1** White has strong pressure in the centre and it is difficult to see how Black will develop his queen's bishop.

In the next example Black has delayed ... ♗b4 until both sides are better developed than in the previous example. White's e-pawn is now under the direct threat of 9 ... ♗xc3 10 bc ♘xe4.

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W



9 ♘a4 An interesting idea based on various tactical considerations. If Black grabs the e-pawn he comes under tremendous pressure: 9 ... ♘xe4 10 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 11 ♘b6 ♖b8 12 ♕d4 ♗f8 13 ♗f3. **9 ... ♗e7** Since the bishop is serving no useful purpose on b4 now that White's c3

knight has moved, it looks natural to retreat it to a safer square. If 9 ... ♗d6 White has the tactical shot 10 ♘b6! when 10 ... ♕xb6 is met by 11 ♘xe6 ♕b4 12 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 13 c3 ♕xe4 14 ♕xd6+ ♔xg7 15 ♗h6+. 9 ... b5 can also be met by 10 ♘b6 with similar ideas. **10 ♘xc6 bc** If 10 ... ♕xc6 11 ♘b6 followed by e5, with a winning bind on the position. **11 ♘b6 ♖b8 12 ♘xc8 ♕xc8 13 e5 ♘d5 14 ♗c1 ♗c5 15 f4 ♘e7 16 b3 ♕c7 17 ♗b2** White has obtained a clear advantage by means of a series of simple, logical moves; he has the two bishops and more space, as well as potential pressure against Black's backward d-pawn.

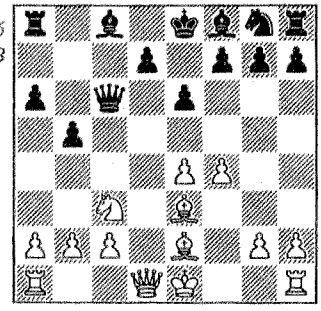
Conclusion

The main points to remember about ... ♗b4 are: (a) Can White take advantage of the vulnerability of Black's g-pawn? (b) can Black win White's e-pawn? If so, is it safe to do so? (c) Can White avoid having to recapture with a pawn on c3 if Black should exchange his bishop for the knight?

Ideas for Black Based on ... ♗a3

The move ... ♗a3 is not really a developing move in the usual sense of the expression since it does not put the king's bishop on a square where it is likely to remain for very long. It is really a tactical stroke aimed at weakening White's queenside but it is most often seen during the opening since once White's position is fully developed the move ... ♗a3 will probably do no more than put Black's bishop *en prise*. The move does, however, have a certain shock value and can easily be overlooked by a casual player.

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B



Ficht-Jansa
Czechoslovakia 1970

White's knight is defended only by the b-pawn, and so **9 ... ♗a3!** Decoying the b-pawn. **10 ♗d4** Nothing else looks any better. If 10 ♕c1 ♕xc3+!. **10 ... ♗xb2 11 ♘xb5 ♗xa1 12 ♗xa1 ab 13 ♗xg7 ♘f6! 14 ♗xh8 ♘xe4 15 ♗d3 ♗b7 16 ♕h5 ♕b6 17 ♕e2 ♖a4 18 ♗e5 f6 19 ♗b2 ♖xa2 20 ♗xe4 ♖xb2 21 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 22 ♔e3 ♗xe4 23 ♔xe4 ♕c3** winning at once.

This tactical resource does not arise very often in ... e6 positions, but it is important for the reader to be aware of it. The move ... ♗a3

can, of course, be prevented by White's a3 (since ... ♗xa3 can be met by ♖xa3) but then White has weakened his queenside structure. Nevertheless, the move a3 is perhaps not quite so weakening in ... e6 positions because Black's c6 knight is often exchanged off, with the result that it is more difficult for Black to force ... b4.

Conclusion

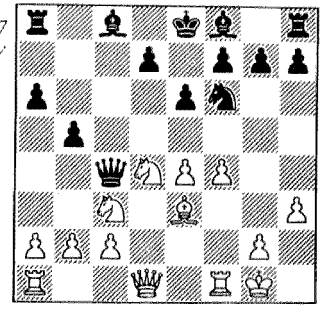
Neither player should forget about the move ... ♗a3. Although it can be played only rarely, when it is played its effect is usually devastating.

Black Attacks on the Queenside

In fact he does not attack on the queenside very often. This is because in ... e6 positions the struggle normally revolves around control of the dark squares and Black does not usually have time to launch a queenside attack (unless White plays too slowly in the opening). Another problem that faces Black in ... e6 positions is that b6 is rather weak and the advance ... b4 drives White's knight to a4 (unless it can be sacrificed on d5), from where it can eventually invade b6.

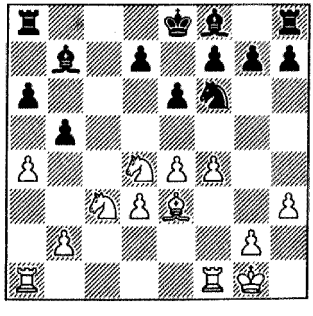
One motif that is sometimes seen in ... e6 positions is the manoeuvre of Black's queen's knight, via e5, to c4. There it is exchanged for White's light-squared bishop and Black recaptures with his queen.

147
W



Black's idea is that his queen is strongly placed on c4. If White tries to play tactically, Black may be proved correct, e.g. 12 e5 ♘d5 13 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 14 ♕e2 ♗b7 15 ♘b3 ♖c8, with enough queenside counterplay to hold the balance. But White can play instead for a pronounced endgame advantage with **12 ♕d3 ♗b7** If 12 ... d5 13 e5 ♘d7 14 ♕xc4 dc 15 f5 with the initiative. **13 a4 ♕xd3 14 cd**

148
B



Black's bishop is badly placed and his b-pawn is weak. This plan

of exchanging queens casts doubt on Black's strategy of activating his queen on the queenside.

Conclusion

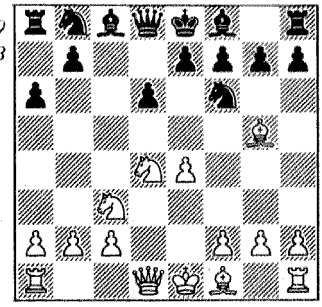
Black should only launch a queenside pawn advance after very careful consideration. If Black carelessly advances his queenside pawns then White should look for ways of infiltrating (usually via a4) the weaknesses that are created in Black's structure.

The Golden Rules of ... e6 Positions

1) Keep your eye on the dark squares – particularly b6 and d6.
2) Be aware of sacrificial possibilities on b5 and d5.
3) White should not play e5 unless he is sure that he can maintain the pawn there.
4) If Black develops his king's bishop before his king's knight, his kingside might be vulnerable to attack.
5) If Black plays ... ♗c5, White should play to exchange off this bishop by ♕e2 and ♗e3.
6) If Black develops his king's knight on e7 rather than f6, his kingside may become vulnerable.
7) If Black plays ... ♗b4, White should immediately try to take advantage of the vulnerability of the dark squares – either b6 (by ♘a4) or g7 (by ♕d4 or ♗d4).
8) Watch out for ... ♗a3 by Black.
9) Black cannot afford to play ... g6 and ... ♗g7 in an ... e6 position because his d6 square will be left fatally weak.
10) White should not exchange his d4 knight on c6 while Black can still recapture with his b-pawn, strengthening his centre and preparing for ... d5. But the moment that Black advances his b-pawn White should give careful consideration to the immediate ♘xc6 so that Black's queen will be on an exposed square.

9 ♗g5 Positions

There are two aggressive opening variations in the Sicilian in which White plays an early ♗g5. These are: the Najdorf Variation, 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6, and now 6 ♗g5 is the most popular and double-edged move; and the Richter-Rauzer Attack, 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6, and now 6 ♗g5. Both systems rely heavily on a number of long, forcing variations where a detailed knowledge of the line is virtually essential for anyone who plays it with either colour. In these cases there are few, if any, general principles of any value – the game is won by the side whose opponent diverges from the well trodden paths. Having said this, we shall now mention the most salient features of ♗g5 positions so that the reader will be more aware of the many tactical possibilities that exist for both sides.

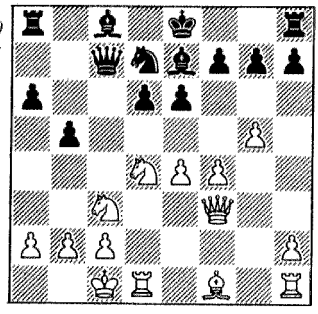


149
B

This is the position that arises after White's ♗g5 in the Najdorf Variation. White threatens to exchange on f6, weakening Black's kingside pawn structure and making it difficult for Black to castle. Black's usual response is 6 ... e6, controlling d5 and avoiding the doubled pawns should White play ♗xf6. Black will continue with ... ♗e7, ... 0-0 and ... b5, and he will eventually pursue his queenside attack by means of ... b4, possibly after ... ♖b8. The next diagram shows a typical ♗g5 position in

the Najdorf after 12 moves by each side.

150
W



White has exchanged on f6 in order to make way for the advance of his g-pawn as part of the traditional kingside pawn storm. Black has started his queenside counterplay by advancing ... b5. In positions such as these there are four sacrificial ideas that crop up from time to time, and the reader should be acquainted with all four of them:

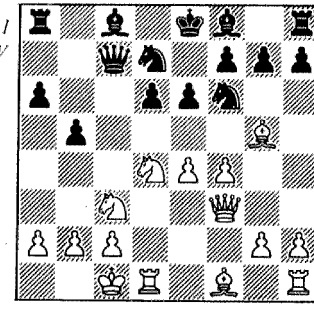
1) Sacrifices on b5.
2) Sacrifices on d5.
3) Sacrifices on f5.
4) Sacrifices on e6.

Sacrifices on b5

The most common form of the sacrifice on b5 nets White three pawns for the piece. White first plays ♗xb5, then after ... ab he recaptures with the d4 knight, attacking the black queen on c7 and the black pawn on d6, and finally, once the black queen has moved to a safe square, White captures the d6 pawn with his knight. For this to be possible White must already have considerable pressure on d6 before making the sacrifice – in the position shown in the last diagram Black has his d-pawn sufficiently well protected and White's piece sacrifice would only recoup two pawns.

In the following example White only gets two pawns for his piece but the black king is immediately thrown into the quagmire, from which it is never able to extricate itself.

151
W



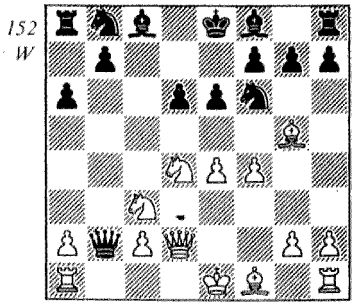
Tal-Stean
Hastings 1973-74

10 ♗xb5! ab 11 ♘dxb5 ♕b8 If 11 ... ♕b6 12 e5 ♗b7 13 ♕e2 de 14 fe ♘d5 15 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♖xd5 ed 17 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 18 ed+ ♔f8 19 ♕e7+ ♔g8 20 ♕xd7 with a tremendous position for White. 11 ... ♕b7 is also met by 12 e5 and if 12 ... ♕xf3 13 gf White wins back material because if the black knight on f6 were to move, ♘c7 would

force mate, e.g. 13 ... ♘d5 14 ♖xd5 ed 15 ♘c7 mate. **12 e5 ♗b7** If 12 ... ♖a5 13 ♘d4 followed by ♕h3 and a sacrifice on e6. **13 ♕e2 de 14 ♕c4 ♗c5** Many other moves look feasible in this position but White's initiative is so great that nothing can stop the attack, e.g. 14 ... ♕c8 15 ♘c7+ ♔d8 16 ♘3b5 with the threat of 17 ♗xf6 gf 18 ♖xd7+ ♔xd7 19 ♖d1+ ♗d5 20 ♖xd5+ ed 21 ♕xd5+ ♔e7 22 ♕d6 mate. **15 ♗xf6 gf 16 ♖xd7! ♗e3+ 17 ♔b1 ♔xd7 18 ♖d1+ ♗d4** Unknown to Black his opponent had witnessed a game a few weeks earlier in which one of his Latvian compatriots had played this sacrifice as White, and up to this point the games were identical. Here the Latvian player's opponent tried 18 ... ♔e8 but lost quickly after 19 ♘c7+ ♔f8 20 fe ♖a5 21 ef. **19 fe fe 20 ♘xd4 ed 21 ♕xd4+ ♔e7 22 ♕c5+ ♔f6 23 ♖f1+ ♔g6 24 ♕e7 f5 25 ♕xe6+ ♔g7 26 ♕e7+ ♔g6 27 h4 ♖a5 28 h5+ ♔xh5 29 ♕f7+ ♔h4 30 ♕f6+ ♔g3 31 ♕g5+ ♔h2 32 ♕h4+ ♔xg2 33 ♖f2+ ♔g1 34 ♘e2** mate.

It can sometimes be possible to capture first on b5 with the knight, as in the following example, where the same player is on the receiving end.

9 ♘b3 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 b5 11 0-0 ♘c5? 11 ... ♕a3 would have been much better. **12 ♘xc5 dc 13 ♗xf6 gf 14 ♖ab1 ♕a3 15 ♘xb5!** Black



152
W

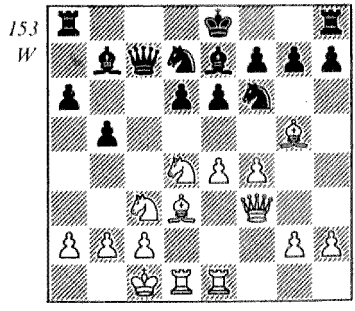
Belyavsky-Stean
Lucerne Olympiad 1982

resigned. If 15 ... ab, 16 ♗xb5+ ♔e7 17 ♖fd1 forces mate.

Conclusion

While Black's king is still on e8 he must be very careful not to permit a sacrifice on b5 that will disrupt his king and force it to relinquish its right to castle.

Sacrifices on d5



153
W

Velimirović-Ljubojević
Yugoslav Championship 1972

We have already seen examples of

White's ♘d5 sacrifice against the Sicilian in the preceding chapters of this book, but we feel that this motif is so fundamental to an understanding of Sicilian positions that we are presenting one further example here. From diagram 153: **12 ♘d5! ♘xd5 13 ed ♗xg5 14 ♖xe6+** 14 ♘xe6 also gives White a dangerous attack. **14 ... fe** Possibly 14 ... ♗e7 is stronger, and if 15 ♘f5 fe 16 ♘xg7+ ♔d8 17 ♘xe6+ ♔c8 18 ♘xc7 ♔xc7 with an unclear position. **15 ♘xe6!** 15 ♕h5+ looks tempting but does not work: 15 ... g6 16 ♗xg6+ ♔e7 17 ♕xg5+ ♘f6 18 ♘xe6 ♕a5 19 ♗moves ♖ag8 and White is a rook down for nothing. **15 ... ♕a5** After this game was played it was widely argued that 15 ... ♕b6 would have saved Black. Whether or not this is so has not yet been firmly established, but even if Velimirović's sacrificial idea is not 100% sound it is no less a great creative achievement. Chess is a practical game and one consideration that must be borne in mind when making a speculative sacrifice is that if the resulting position is sufficiently difficult to defend then, from a purely practical point of view, the sacrifice must be considered worthwhile (unless there is a more direct way to victory). **16 ♕h5+ g6 17 ♕xg5 ♖g8** If 17 ... ♘f8 18 ♕f6 and White's attack persists. **18 ♖d2** Heading for e2. **18 ... ♘f8** 18 ... ♘c5 is met by 19 ♘xc5 dc 20 d6, with an overwhelming position. **19 ♘xf8 ♕d8 20 ♘xh7 ♕xg5 21 fg ♔f7 22 ♘f6 ♖h8 23 g3 ♗c8 24 h4 ♗f5 25 ♗xf5 gf 26 h5 ♖a7 27 ♖f2** Black resigned.

This example of the ♘d5 sacrifice differs from the others that we have examined in that here Black does not play ... ed in reply to 12 ♘d5. Had Ljubojević replied 12 ... ed White would have continued 13 ♘f5 with a very complicated position in which White's practical chances are probably worth a piece. Note that the presence of White's g5 bishop contributes to the pressure on Black's king position and that in order to eliminate this bishop Black was forced to exchange off his own bishop, thereby making his king even more exposed.

Conclusion

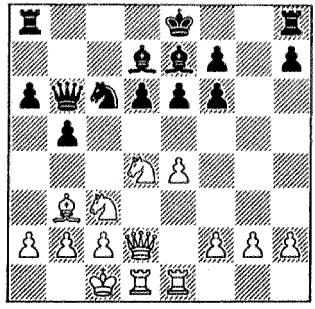
Sacrifices on d5 are more difficult to assess than any other Sicilian sacrifice. When White has played ♗g5, he exerts more pressure than in the corresponding positions without ♗g5, and the ♘d5 sacrifice therefore has greater chances of success.

Sacrifices on f5

Since d5 is the focal point of attention in the Sicilian Defence, it is logical for White to try to decoy away anything that is defending

d5 so that the square will be ripe for occupation by a minor piece. Black's e6 pawn represents the biggest obstacle in White's path and so if White wants to make use of d5 he should try to find some way of decoying this pawn to e5 or f5. The knight sacrifice on f5 is one such way.

154
W



Palmiotto-Primavera
Italian Championship 1965

White has played ♗g5 and then exchanged bishop for knight on f6. When this happens Black can often afford to recapture with the g-pawn, strengthening his centre, and in many positions he is actually forced to make the pawn recapture because ... ♗xf6 would leave the black d-pawn extremely weak or even *en prise*. This theme of pressure on Black's d-pawn is one of the ideas behind White's ♗g5 in the Sicilian – the unpinning move ... ♗e7 puts Black's bishop on a square where it performs two guarding roles, and White can often exploit the overworking of this piece.

Here White's position is perfectly developed and he is able to cash in on the position of Black's queen on b6 by jumping into d5 with gain of tempo. **13 ♘f5! ef** Forced, otherwise the d-pawn is lost for nothing. **14 ♘d5 ♕d8** If 14 ... ♕a5 15 ♕h6, threatening 16 ef, 17 ♘xe7 and 18 ♕xf6, and if then 15 ... 0-0-0 16 ef ♖he8 17 ♘xe7+ ♖xe7 18 ♖xe7 ♘xe7 19 ♕xf6, when 19 ... ♘xf5 allows White to trap the knight by 20 g4. **15 ef 0-0 16 ♖xe7! ♘xe7 17 ♘xf6+ ♔g7** If 17 ... ♔h8 18 ♕h6 ♗xf5 19 ♘h5 ♖g8 20 ♕f6+ and mate next move. **18 ♕c3** With the threat of mate after 19 ♘e8+ ♔h6 20 ♕g7+ etc. **18 ... ♘xf5 19 ♘xd7+ ♔g8 20 ♘xf8 ♕xf8 21 ♕f3 ♘g7 22 ♗xf7+ ♔h8 23 ♖xd6 ♖a7 24 ♖f6 ♕e7 25 ♗d5 ♕e1+ 26 ♕d1 ♕b4 27 c3 ♕e7 28 ♕f3** and Black resigned. This successful sacrifice was made possible by White's g5 bishop, which had exchanged off one of the defenders of the d5 square. Once Black's f6 knight had left the board the way was open for the decoying sacrifice ♘f5, which itself paved the way for the occupation of d5.

Conclusion

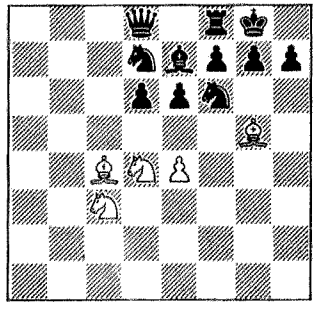
The sacrifice on f5 will usually be sound only if White can make good use of the d5 square and/or

the attacking potential of his e-pawn when it recaptures on f5 and joins in the kingside advance.

Sacrifices on e6

On page 49 we saw an example of a piece sacrifice on e6 that netted White three pawns and a promising attack. When White has his bishop and d4 knight lined up on e6 there are often tactical ideas based on the sacrifice of one or other of these minor pieces, but not all of them are as promising as they look. For example, consider the following skeleton position.

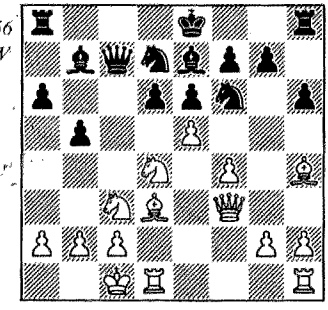
155
W



White can play 1 ♗xe6 fe 2 ♘xe6 and 3 ♘xf8, winning a rook and two pawns for two minor pieces and exposing Black's king slightly. It is, however, known from experience that in the middlegame two minor pieces are nearly always superior to a rook and two pawns because they give the side with the rook only one fighting piece to his opponent's two. It should also be remembered that in carrying out the minor operation shown above White's attacking forces have been depleted, and so the fact that the black king has been slightly opened up is normally of little or no consequence.

For a successful sacrifice on e6, the most important part of White's compensation must consist in the exposed situation of Black's king. This exposure is often aggravated if Black has played ... h6 to drive away the g5 bishop, because then Black has a weak square on g6 which is ready for invasion once White has sacrificed on e6 and the sacrifice has been accepted by Black's f-pawn.

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W



Gligorić-Bobotsov
Hastings 1959-60

13 ♘xe6! fe Black must accept the sacrifice since 13 ... ♗xf3 14 ♘xc7+ and 15 ♘xa8 would leave White with a decisive material advantage. **14 ♗g6+ ♔f8** This is the safest square. On d8 Black's

king would be exposed to the wrath of White's queen's rook: 14 ... ♔d8 15 ♕h3 de 16 ♕xe6 ♕c6 (or 16 ... e4 17 ♗xf6 gf 18 ♖xd7+ ♕xd7 19 ♖d1 winning) 17 ♖xd7+ ♘xd7 18 ♕xe7+ ♔c7 19 ♖d1, when White's position is overwhelming. **15 ef! ♗xf3 16 fe+ ♔g8 17 gf ♘f6 18 ♗xf6 gf 19 e8♕+ ♖xe8 20 ♗xe8 d5?** It was later discovered that 20 ... ♔f8 is correct, leading to a complicated struggle that ought to end in a draw. As we have already stated, however, part of the value of a sacrificial idea lies in the practical problems that it sets the defending player, and with the clock ticking away it is not easy to find the correct move every time. Now Gligorić could have built up his position by **21 f5 ♕f4+ 22 ♔b1 ♕xf5 23 ♖hg1+ ♔f8 24 ♗g6**, when White's pieces would all be actively placed. Instead, himself hampered by the clock, he chose an inferior move, and it was only after a couple of time trouble errors by his opponent that he was able to win.

Conclusion

Sacrifices on e6 are normally successful only if they strand the black king in the centre.

Other Ideas in ♗g5 Positions

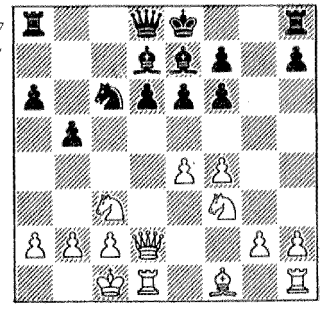
1) White exchanges on f6 to double Black's pawns.
2) Black drives away the g5 bishop by ... h6 (and the tactical stroke ... ♘xe4).
3) Black sacrifices the exchange on c3.

White Exchanges on f6 to Double Black's Pawns

The ♘f5 sacrifice given on page 123 stems from a typical ♗g5 position in which White has exchanged bishop for knight on f6 to double Black's pawns and weaken his kingside. This exchange gives Black a strong central pawn mass and the advantage of the two bishops, but the fact that his king will find difficulty in seeking a safe haven means that Black's chances tend to be somewhat worse than those of his opponent.

Let us now look at another position of this type and explore two different paths in order to see the pros and cons of such positions.

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W



Here White's chances will depend on whether or not he is able to effect the advance f5 under suitable circumstances, since Black will then

have to choose between conceding the d5 square by ... e5 and allowing his king's position to be opened up. Black will seek counterplay on the queenside as usual, and also along the half-open g-file.

i) White's f5 is successful

12 f5 It seems from experience that this move is best played at once in the last diagram, although in many cases players of the white pieces have first tried to build up their positions by moves such as 12 ♕e3 and 12 g3 (and 12 ♗d3, which is discussed below). **12 ... b4** Driving away the white knight so that ... e5 cannot be answered by ♘d5. Better than the text seems 12 ... ♕a5 (active counterplay) 13 ♔b1 ♖c8 14 ♗d3 ♘b4 15 ♘d4 ♘xd3 (In contrast to the situations discussed in the chapter on the little centre, this exchange is sensible for Black because his queenside counterplay is already well advanced) 16 ♕xd3 b4, with good counterplay for Black. **13 ♘e2 e5 14 ♘g3 h5** Black cannot allow ♘h5. **15 ♗c4** Capitalising on the weakness of the d5 square. **15 ... ♘a5 16 ♗d5 ♖b8 17 ♘f1** Heading for e3 and d5. **17 ... ♗f8 18 ♔b1 ♗h6 19 ♘e3 ♕c7 20 ♗b3 ♗xe3 21 ♕xe3** White has a positional advantage because of his control of d5 and the weakness of Black's d-pawn.

ii) White plays too slowly

12 ♗d3 This move came into vogue after Fischer employed it in his match with Spassky. White tries to improve the co-ordination of his pieces before advancing f5, but on d3 the bishop reduces White's central pressure by blocking the d-file. Also, the move turns out to be a waste of time and Black can use the extra tempo to get his king into safety: **12 ... ♕b6 13 f5 0-0-0 14 ♔b1 ♘e5** By extricating his king from the centre Black has removed the necessity of meeting f5 with ... e5 and it is therefore possible for him to use the e5 square to greater effect. The chances now are roughly equal.

Conclusion

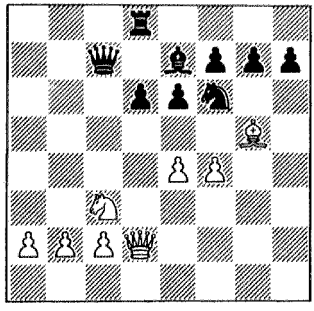
If White plays actively (with an early f5) he can benefit from the doubled black f-pawns. Otherwise the central pawn mass helps Black.

Black Drives Away the g5 Bishop by ... h6

The move ... h6 is designed to force White to commit himself in one way or another. If he exchanges on f6 the position becomes more clear-cut and it is easier for Black to make a plan. If he retreats to h4 he may be putting his bishop on an exposed square (it will no longer be defended by the f4 pawn) where

it can fall victim to the combinative stroke ... ♘xe4. If Black has a bishop on e7 this move will open up an attack on White's h4 bishop and so the combination will net Black a pawn.

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B



If Black plays 1 ... h6 White cannot retreat 2 ♗h4 because of 2 ... ♘xe4, and if 3 ♘xe4 ♗xh4, when Black is still a pawn ahead. It is important when considering this particular combinative idea to follow the lines of attack of the black knight and the white bishop. If the black knight attacks the white queen from e4 then the move ... ♘xe4 is more likely to be successful, unless Black's queen is still on d8 in which case, after 1 ... ♘xe4 2 ♗xe7 ♘xd2, it is White who wins material by 3 ♗xd8.

Provided that the sequence ... h6, ♗h4 does not lay White open to the tactical stroke ... ♘xe4, it will normally favour White because of the weakening effect that the move ... h6 has on Black's kingside. This is even more apparent if Black follows up with ... g5, driving the bishop back still further. In general, only play ... h6 in ♗g5 positions if you have a very good reason for doing so.

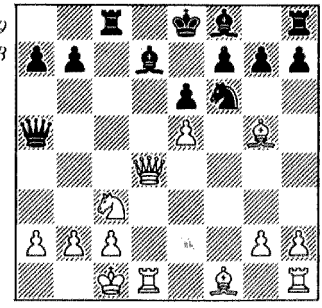
Conclusion

... h6 weakens Black's kingside and should only be played as part of a deep plan.

Black Sacrifices the Exchange on c3

As in many Dragon positions, this exchange sacrifice can be extremely effective once White has castled queenside (and it is sometimes playable even when he has not).

159
B



In the Dragon White usually has some protection for his a-pawn, such as his king's bishop on b3, but here he is more vulnerable to attack because his a-pawn is only protected by the knight on c3. And so . . . **12 ... ♖xc3! 13 ♗d2** If 13 bc ♗c5 followed by ... ♘d5 Black has a strong attack; or 13 ef

♕xg5+; or 13 ♕xc3 ♕xc3 14 bc ♘e4 and Black wins back the exchange and emerges with a big endgame advantage because of White's doubled pawns on the semi-open c-file. **13 ... ♕xa2 14 ♗xc3 g6** Threat ... ♗h6+. **15 ♔d2 ♗c5 16 ♕c4 ♕xc4 17 ♗xc4 ♘e4+ 18 ♔e2 ♘xc3+ 19 bc ♗c6** Black has more than enough compensation for the sacrificed material since his pawns are better placed than White's and he has the two bishops.

Conclusion

The exchange sacrifice is not quite so effective as in Dragon positions because Black does not have a fianchettoed bishop to attack the c3 pawn, but ... ♖xc3 can still cause White problems.

The Golden Rules of ♗g5 Positions

1) Remember the basic positional tenet: White attacks on the kingside, Black attacks on the queenside.

2) Can White weaken the black kingside by exchanging bishop for knight on f6?

Thereafter, because these positions tend to be almost entirely tactical in nature, remember the following tactical possibilities:

3) Is there a sacrifice possible on b5? If White does sacrifice, will he get a winning attack or a tense ending of three passed queenside pawns against a minor piece?

4) Is there a sacrifice possible on d5? If White does sacrifice, will he catch the black king in the centre?

5) Is there a sacrifice possible on f5? If White does sacrifice, is it:

a) to parachute a knight in on d5, winning everything; or

b) to catch the black monarch in the centre?

6) Is there a sacrifice possible on e6? This one can be especially dangerous as it has tremendous attacking potential, and even if that attack does not succeed all is not lost for White since he has probably gained three pawns for his piece.

7) Can Black sacrifice an exchange on c3 to break open the position around White's castled king for a mating attack?

8) Can Black play ... ♘xe4 gaining a bishop on h4 in return for the knight and so winning a pawn?

10 The Golden Rules of the Sicilian Defence

Here we shall summarise the contents of the preceding chapters in 'Golden Rules'. As with the rules that appear in Chapters 2-9, they are not to be taken as gospel but treated as useful rules of thumb. Chess is a game in which it is necessary to think for oneself at almost every stage, and the reader should not therefore expect to be told exactly what to do in every Sicilian position. If the reader has read and understood the ideas explained in this book, and if he memorises these few vital rules and those pertaining to particular types of position, then he will be assured of scoring many more points in his Sicilian Defence games.

1) Black should always aim for the freeing break ... d5. If he can play it with impunity he usually achieves at least equality, and often more.
2) White should not exchange his d4 knight on c6 while Black can recapture with the b-pawn because this recapture strengthens Black's centre and makes it easier for him to play ... d5. When Black plays ... b5, however, intending ... ♗b7, White should give careful consideration to exchanging on c6 as both ... dc (removing a pawn from a central file) and ... ♕xc6 (putting the queen on a potentially exposed square) are usually to White's advantage.
3) As Black, do not give up your fianchettoed king's bishop in order to win a pawn (or even the exchange in some cases) while queens are still on the board, as this will make it much easier for White's kingside attack to score a quick knockout.
4) As White, do not weaken your queenside pawns by a3 unless it is going to be very difficult for Black to force ... b4.
5) Be on the alert for sacrifices on b5, d5, e6, f5 and c3.
6) In 'little centre' positions White should always be willing to exchange off dark-squared bishops since the weak squares in Black's position will then be more difficult to defend.

8) In ... e5 positions White should try to keep d5 for one of his pieces rather than one of his pawns, and he should help to keep control of d5 by inhibiting ... f5.

9) If in doubt as White, strengthen your position by improving the location of your worst placed piece or make an attacking move on the kingside.

10) If in doubt as Black, strengthen your position by improving the location of your worst placed piece or make an attacking move on the queenside.

11) Maroczy Bind positions with ... g6 tend to favour White because Black's counterplay is limited, whereas Maroczy Bind positions with ... e6 are perfectly playable for Black because of the increased likelihood that the dynamic break ... d5 will become a reality.

12) Endings tend to favour Black because:

a) the half-open c-file is of more use to him than the half-open d-file is to White; and

b) he can launch a minority attack with his pawns.

Exceptions to this rule are positions in which White's 3:2 majority has been (or can be) reduced to a 2:1 majority and the white king is well placed to reach the queenside.

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